



RECOVERING
Maggie

KT MORRISON

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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Also by KT Morrison

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Recovering Maggie

A MAGGIE novel

Maggie Series, Book 7 of 7

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Prologue One

SIX YEARS AFTER THE TWILIGHT

OUTSIDE THE HISTORIC seaside church the country's first president once attended stood a sign with a proclamation that staggered her heart. Though fully prepared for it—it was her wedding day, after all—somehow seeing the white letters of their two names arranged in union on a lined black field meant to affirm to their guests they'd arrived at the correct wedding made it all seem luminously real. In one hour she would no longer be Maggie Becker.

It had been a long journey. A painful one at times, but one always with abounding love, even when moments were at their darkest. Love, yes, but for a long time rarely the truth. And though love could exist for a while without truth, surviving behind the shield of immaturity, it was insupportable. Lies were the ballast that curved love's trajectory. They were all liars, horrible ones, but they'd been young, and the worst lies were the ones they told themselves.

A group of older men regaled with sudden deep laughter behind her, standing in a loose bespoke clutch on the slope of the lawn. Martin, Westlake, and some other cronies from Oxbow all on the grass, her father leading them, looking good in his tailored tuxedo. They smoked cigars, handed out by Martin while they waited for the ceremony to begin, and congratulated him on the marriage of his only daughter. Beyond them, a crooked wrought iron line ran the perimeter of the old Trinity cemetery, marking off mossy hundreds-year-old tombstones.

There was glad-handing amongst them now, a steward in black pants and a white dress shirt coming and taking away what remained of their

expensive cigars, putting them in a black pail of sand he carried in one hand, the group breaking up. The men found their way inside the church to take their seats as her father made his way toward her, adjusting his cuff links and giving smiles and nodding to some who still lingered on the church's steps, radiating his proud father-of-the-bride smile.

She stepped ahead, following the officiant, her father catching up and putting a hand on the small of her back as they gathered with the wedding party in the nave of the old wooden church. Martin popped a piece of gum in his mouth but she told him: "You still smell like cigar," reaching to his tie and straightening it.

Though he looked at her sternly, he said, "You look beautiful today, Margaret. Your husband is a lucky man."

Eyes narrowed, raising her chin to him, she slowly let herself smile. "He is," she agreed, and now her father smiled as well.

The nervous banter amongst her bridesmaids and groomsmen thinned with quiet tension and she saw the officiant now making eye contact with them all. The room grew quiet. It was time to begin.

In twos, bridesmaids and groomsmen filed out, arm in arm. Maid of Honor next, heading out with a knowing wink and then a wide open but silent joyous scream. The flower girl and ring bearer followed. Martin let her assume her posture, get comfortable, clutching her bouquet low on her belly, over the life only she knew grew inside her.

Somewhere above them on the balcony that faced the altar, the processional began. The very traditional Wagner's Bridal Chorus; Grace Cho—a girl she remembered from Tanglewood—on the massive pipe organ that bellowed through the church, resonating in all the old wood so she felt its vibrations in the floor and traveling up her legs, its power and volume and majesty making her shake.

Father linked an arm through hers tightly, taller than her even in her heels, but letting her form a diamond between waist and elbow where he could fit his forearm. Shoulders back, smiling now, she let him escort her to the mouth of the aisle.

Spring sunlight glowed off the chandeliers hanging slightly crooked down the center of the high cathedral ceiling, and her whole body tightened with excitement. Every face in the Trinity was turned to her, sequestered in their boxed pews, and she let her smile grow wider. On the beat, she took her first step to her new life walking the red carpet, eyes turned up to the

pulpit, staggered diagonal lines of the bridal party leading up the steps to the pastor; Max and Cole there, waiting for her, both of them beaming ...

Prologue Two

TWELVE DAYS AFTER THE TWILIGHT

THE BECKER'S lodge home on Schroon Lake was almost a two-and-a-half hour drive from the airport in Albany. Road conditions were terrible, whole sections whited-out once he'd entered the highlands of the Adirondacks. He'd seen the lodge in pictures before, but had never visited in person.

One thing for sure: the Nissan Rogue looked out of place in the wide circular driveway of the massive log home. Smoke curled from the chimney and he would otherwise think she hadn't arrived yet; no other vehicle parked, no tracks in the snow around the house.

When he agreed to meet her, she offered him the flight, but his parents paid anyway. She'd arranged the car, a sturdy little AWD SUV to help him navigate the treacherous wintry roads; his Maggie eager to see him, hopefully as eager as he was to see her. This being their first-time face-to-face since he pulled his engagement ring from her finger in the Twilight Motel. As her countless texts to him pleaded forgiveness, he was ready to hear them in person, and he would genuflect before her, too, with his own boundless apologies.

Out of the car and opening the hatch, he popped the collar of his peacoat to protect his neck. Though the temperature wasn't frigid, a wind had picked up suddenly and howled at his back, accelerating under the peaked log awning that extended off the front doorway to cover the heavy stone steps and driveway. Above him, metal groaned; a massive iron outdoor chandelier swayed with the wind's action. The thing was bigger than his rental SUV, metal arms shaped like antlers, woven through with boughs of

evergreen, dotted with pale globes unlit at this time of day. If it collapsed from its chains, it would demolish the Rogue.

With his bag slung over his shoulder, he closed the vehicle and trotted up the granite steps. The front door stood ten feet tall, bifold with a Gothic arch like it once opened into a European church. He rapped the brass knocker and stepped back, bouncing on his toes, a sudden surge to his heart rate that at once made him lightheaded. He took deep breaths and clutched his hand inside the pocket of his khakis, felt the hardness of what he brought, felt its weight far heavier than its small size would predict.

The heavy door opened and Maggie was there. Two weeks since he'd seen her beautiful face. A smile came to her, weak and cautious but the sight of it soared his heart and he would easily have gone to his knees before her if he hadn't promised himself to be strong. Instead, he smiled too, cautious at first like her, then both of them widening simultaneously.

She said, "Can you believe the weather?"

"I know," he said, pivoting and looking out beyond the huge log-supported awning. Fat flakes of snow whisked sideways.

"You going to come in?" she said, her face mirthful but still hesitant.

"I'd love to, Maggie," he said.

She stepped aside, looking sweet in a white baggy top and black tights, her feet bare in the warm house. The smile she held was swallowed now, but her expression still bright and buoyant like she wanted to bubble over; *she* bounced on *her* toes. He knew the feeling.

He entered the grand lodge's hallway, three stories high, another iron chandelier above them both. The floor was angular granite flagstones, and a staircase wound in a circuit, its bannister and railings in glossy wood with black metal moose antlers and branches. Maggie walked the door closed, and it sounded a doom, then the large space was eerily quiet in the absence of the wind's high whistle. They stood face to face, those restrained smiles returning, his fiancée looking so goddamned adorable he couldn't wait till this was over and he would sweep her up in his arms and make her laugh again.

The sound of shuffling feet on stone made him turn. Coming from the depths of the huge home, Cole walked, eyes turned down to regard a bottle of Scotch he held in his hand.

He was saying, "Is this the one?—because this is almost thirty years old and I can't ..."

Air punched from Max like he'd been thumped in the belly. His mouth fell open. He said to Maggie, "What's *he* doing here?"

Cole stopped short, face darting up to see them both watching him from the front door. His features sagged, and he grew a look of pain. He said, "What's *he* doing here?"

Splatter

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 27TH

DINNER, Friday night, tired from the commute from Vermont to Rhode Island. Private chef-prepared salmon and arugula, served in the sunroom off the kitchen. Though mother had warning, she was still miffed at the change in dinner plans; Maggie coming alone. No Max. No Cole. *Maybe forever.*

“You’re hardly eating,” Carol said.

“I’m not hungry,” she said toward her plate.

“You should eat properly while you can.”

“What do you mean?”

“Too much junk food at school, Margaret. I can see it in your face. Inflammation.”

“Oh,” she said, pushing salmon around. “Maybe.”

“Your cheeks are fat.”

Father’s errant fork scraped his plate with a screech while he ate and eyed his iPad.

The thought right now of sitting in the front window at Altieri’s—under the arc of its gold stenciled letters, eating a white pizza, eating brownies with her Max—did her in. Her chin dimpled and her lower lip buttoned to the upper. The warmth in that image—the sparkling ardor it conjured dwarfed in scale by its absence, its potential impending perish; the thought of something so vital she had, took for granted, now extinguished—broke her heart all over again right at the dinner table. She moaned with grief and dropped her fork, clattering explosively against her plate.

“Margaret, your manners, please,” Carol said.

“Sorry,” she said, and pressed her fingertips below her eyes, desperate to pinch off her tear ducts, though, she was sure, mother thought she was checking for fatness.

“What is wrong with you?”

She was silent for a moment. The spot where that wonderful ring sat itched in the gold’s absence. A tickle would incessantly form and she would rub the inside of the lonely finger with the pad of her thumb until it became uncomfortable.

“We ... We postponed the wedding. Possibly.”

Carol watched her without expression, set her fork and knife down and laced her fingers together, resting her forearms on the edge of the glass table. Her eyes darted to Martin, and he paused as well.

“Why I came here alone,” she said, a swirling nausea low in her belly.

“I imagined,” Carol said.

“What?”

“Your ring. You weren’t wearing it.”

“Oh.” And there was her thumb again, looking to wear a hole where that symbol once circled. Her eyes darted between mother and father, neither one blessing her with even marginal compassion. She said, “We ... Max said ... Max said if I’m going to ... going to go to law school ... maybe we should, you know, maybe we should wait.”

Martin’s tongue moved around inside his mouth as he considered it. Then he nodded, corners of his mouth turned down venerably. He said, “Very pragmatic, young Max.”

Hearing positivity toward the boy she loved buoyed her, she continued to lie. “Perhaps. We’ll have to see. I can ... I can do both. I know I can. But, he ...” And then fantastically, her thoughts took a jag. “Or, you know, maybe he could come to Harvard as well.”

Carol continued to stare at her expressionlessly, and it started a tremble in her fingers.

Martin said, “For law?”

“I don’t know,” she said quietly, that moment of weak evocative joy dissipating.

Martin resumed eating.

“Max would go to Harvard?” her mother chased her, and she felt cornered already.

“He could.”

Carol smiled. "The three of you, together again."

"Three?"

"Your handsome friend, Margaret. Cole."

"Max's friend," she said inexplicably.

"Yes, Margaret. I used the plural, collective 'you.'"

"Right."

"Max expressed plans for Harvard?"

She shook her head no.

"Margaret?"

"No. No, he hasn't. But ... He's incredibly smart. If he ... He would benefit from postgrad."

Without looking up, Martin said, "He doesn't need to."

Mother's gaze on her was unwavering and she even smiled now.

"What? ..."

Her mother said, "Max looks out for you."

"He does."

"It's very noble what he's done."

"I know. Maybe not, though ... we could still ..."

"Yes, you may still. But Max will be at Oxbow," Carol said, looking to Martin who nodded in agreement without raising his gaze, "and you have your collective friend to watch over you."

"Cole? ..."

"Isn't that right?"

"Yes."

Carol sat straighter but still regarded her. "Now, Max wanted to postpone until you are done law school?"

"Right."

"He took his ring."

Red flames began to work up her neck, and she felt her cheeks catch fire as well, shame pounding in her eardrums.

Martin said, "I'll cancel Valerie on Monday."

Maggie said, "The wedding planner? Wait—"

Carol said her name: "Margaret ..."

Maggie turned and said, "Can we just wait?"

Carol said, "Margaret, take my hand." She stretched her thin arm to her, palm side of her elegant hand turned up, Cartier bangles singing softly against the glass top.

“Why?” she said. Mother had never offered a hand before, and despite the gesture’s aberration, she reached across and mother and daughter curved hooked fingers together, feeling each other’s nails on the insides of their knuckles.

Carol looked in her eyes and said, “Margaret, you’re doing the right thing and I am proud of you.”

“What right thing?” she whined, and Carol’s nails dug a little deeper, like they hated the sound of her weakness.

“School, Margaret. Don’t let your boys get in your way.”

“My boys?”

When she tried to retrieve her hand, she couldn’t. Carol held her tightly.

“Max loves you and he would postpone the wedding if it would help you ...”

“I know ...”

“But he would never take his ring back ...”

The ‘*unless* ...’ hung in the air, silent and enormous.

Her jaw trembled, and she clacked her teeth shut. Carol still stared in her eyes and while she felt no warmth, she detected its distant cousin, support.

With trembling voice, Maggie whispered, “I want Max ...”

Carol nodded, still smiling.

Martin said, “You’re too young, anyway.”

She said, “I’m not too young. Max was good ... I want Max back ...”

Carol said, “There are countless men, Margaret, you’re—”

“I want my Max, not other men.” She said it firmly, carefully returning the grip her mother held her with.

Carol said, “You want Max because you hurt him, and in turn he hurt you—and you believe the hurt you feel will go away if you’re together again.”

“What?—may I please be excused?” Her voice was a tight gasp and when she pulled her hand back her mother let go this time, but she still held her gaze.

“The pain will go away on its own, Margaret.”

“I have to go to my room,” she whispered, standing quickly but stiffly, the feet of the ebony chair squealing across polished concrete.

The eyes of her parents on her back as she trotted out of the sterile room made her feel naked. And by the time she’d hammered up the steps and

sealed herself in her bedroom she was afraid she knew why.

HIS FLIGHT, the second one in a month, left him tapped, and he took a bus from the airport instead of a cab. It took almost two hours to get from O'Hare to the lake shore.

Now he was in the center of campus, right where the directions told him, but it couldn't be right.

"What the hell?" he said, looking from phone to building and back again.

It *was* right, but not what he expected. Once inside the massive church he saw a directional arrow with descriptive text telling him the way to the dorms. The passages were dark and narrow, black wood ceilings and gothic archways; his footsteps echoed off the pale stone. The route took him through a library where sombre students sat reading old tomes at polished tables, under circular timber chandeliers suspended on chains.

Up three steps from the library, under one more arch, he found himself at a wooden door with black numerals spelling out 115. He pushed his travel bag behind his hip, knocked, and hoped the timing would be all right.

When a surly voice called out, "What?" from behind, he knocked again, this time more firmly.

Footsteps shuffled on wood floor, then the door yanked open and the expression on his brother Connor's face was priceless.

Max said, "What's up, player?"

"Oh my God, Max," Connor laughed and held out his arms.

He stepped into his brother's dorm room and they embraced, slapping each other on the back and rocking back and forth.

"Dude, Max, what the hell are you doing here?"

"Came to surprise you," he said.

"For what?"

They stepped back and looked each other over. Connor was looking good and healthy, his red hair cut short but kept long and wavy up top. Max smiled and did the best to hide his pain.

"No reason," he said, but his brother's smile showed he'd been caught.

He strolled into Connor's room and slung his bag onto a chair. "You gonna let me crash here for a night or two?"

"I could have booked you a guest room," he said.

"It's not Mom and Dad, it's me."

"Yeah, man, of course. Of course you can stay here. Everything cool? How's Mom and Dad?"

"They're good. I just saw them. So, seriously, this fucking building. Fucking Hogwarts shit."

"I know," he laughed. "Isn't it crazy?"

Max looked around his brother's dorm room. He'd already heard (been bragged to) about it. A room the size of his double at Farmingham but solo occupation. The dorm room shared a bathroom with one similar dorm on the other side, and then another common living area. It had been a seminary school at one time and there were a dozen prime dorms in the old church now assumed by the university.

"This is unreal."

"Upperclassman shit," Connor said, as if he wielded some seniority on the campus of twenty-thousand.

Max said, "I'm an upperclassman, I still got a roommate."

"Yeah, but you go to that weird little school in the mountains."

"I like my school."

"You get credit for making maple syrup, right?"

"Yes," he said, rolling his eyes.

"Your Dean—I heard he's a mean flatfoot dancer."

"We all are, asshole."

"Can I offer you some moonshine?"

Max sighed as if he would answer, but abandoned it, instead sitting down heavily on Connor's bed.

They stared at one another for a while without saying anything, then Connor asked: "How's Maggie?"

"I don't know," he said, looking away.

Connor nodded. "Why not?"

"I called the wedding off."

"Oh, Jesus," Connor murmured and rubbed his forehead.

Max took a deep, long, and careful breath; it was very easy to get lost in the emotion of it and he didn't want that. "Yeah, I did."

Connor sighed. "Max, man, what happened?"

Max shrugged, the words frozen in his mouth. The whole reason he came here, and now he couldn't even utter what hurt him.

Connor sat down next to him. "Is it final?"

He opened his mouth but still nothing came out, his throat croaked. "I ... I hope not."

"Then why ... why did you call it off?"

"I ... I made a big mistake," he muttered, gaze cast across the room at his brother's desk, laptop opened, messenger active, texts popping up in word balloons from his friends.

"What did you do?"

"She made mistakes, too," he muttered.

"Maggie? What did she do?"

He moaned and hid his face in his hands. Connor's hand fell on his back, rubbing his shoulder blades and squeezing his neck.

"She cheated on me."

Connor laughed. Max turned to face him.

Connor stopped, said, "No, she didn't," frowning in disbelief. "Maggie? Dude, is it your imagination?"

He shook his head no.

"Come on," Connor said.

Max showed him a face that would prove he was serious.

"Maggie? I just can't believe it. She's not like that. What do I know, I guess ... Are you sure?"

"Yes."

"Maybe it's not what you think—"

"I saw it. I saw it with my own eyes."

"Oh," he said, sitting straighter. "Oh, fuck."

"Oh, fuck is right," he said.

"Saw what?" Connor asked.

Max huffed and faced him again, "What do you think?"

"Sorry," he said. "You can be ... sorry, you can be weird and hysterical sometimes."

"What? Fuck off," he said.

"Dude, I am so sorry," Connor said, putting his arm around his back and hugging him. "I mean it, man. I thought Maggie was perfect, I mean so perfect for you. I'm sorry."

“She is. She’s so perfect,” he sobbed, heaving forward, but clenching a grip on his knees and keeping it at bay.

Connor’s hand went in soothing circles again, and he said, “No, fuck her, Max. I mean it. Fuck that bitch.”

“Don’t say that,” he moaned. “Don’t call her a bitch.”

“Don’t defend her, Max. How can you trust her now? You’re going to marry someone you can’t trust?”

“I love her ...”

“Who?”

“Maggie?”

“No, who did she sleep with, Max?”

He groaned again and hid his face in his hands.

“Well, was she drunk or something? I mean maybe ... I don’t know ... tell me what happened.”

Maybe coming here was a big mistake. There were things he couldn’t confront, and he knew he was running away. But, fuck, he was getting what he wanted. A hand on his back, compassion, support. Love. In the fallout from what he witnessed in *The Twilight* he’d never felt more alone in his life.

“Cole,” he said.

“Your friend?—wait, your fucking Best Man?”

He nodded and felt the tears seeping into the creases of his palm and fingers.

“You have got to be kidding me, Max ...”

He shook his head slowly, his back beginning to heave with silent sobs.

Now Connor encircled him with his arms and held him. He exhaled, “Oh, Max, Max, Max ...”

“I made so many mistakes, Connor ...”

“It’s okay, Max, it’s okay ...”

“I want her back. I want her back more than anything.”

Connor squeezed him tighter. “No, you don’t, Max. No, you don’t.”

SHE’D NEVER INTENDED to reveal to her parents a single thing about her and Max. Somehow, once her barricades took a couple of hits, her

sentimental heart sent its hurting contents gushing over the barrier. And her mother *knew*. Somehow *knew*; a woman more machine than human, heartless certainly, saw the entirety of her sheltered daughter's complex relationships, putting pins in their moving vectors with remarkable clarity. And now there would be no way to claw back her privacy—a glimmer of her hurt and truth revealed to her parents, and it is, of course, met with uncaring pragmatism. That pain was her own and maybe she flashed it to them because, for once, she might like to feel someone care for her. Now that her Max was gone.

She reeled, kicking off her loafers and crossing the room, climbing up on her bed, one she'd shared with the two boys she loved ... and she was climbing right over the bed, stepping off on the other side, stumbling into the bathroom and collapsing on her knees at the base of the toilet—dinner wanted up but she pinched her lips closed and slumped till her forehead touched the cold floor.

This was too much to bear; her parents fully enveloped in her reality now made all of their transgressions even worse; worse by emptying them of meaning—you messed up, Margaret, everybody got hurt and we don't care for the details, you have Harvard at the end of August to concern yourself with.

"Fuck!" she cried, pounding a knee with her fist.

What did she expect?

The new horizon for Margaret Becker?—suffocated in the fold of her parents' control, starting school anew, honor, discipline, hard work, and results tantamount. No relationships. Work work work. Study study study. She'd been free. So close to free. Maggie and beautiful Max together and married and happy, and away, and free free free, and oh, how she wanted it. And the cause of her ruin?—the repressed sexuality her teenage imprisonment allowed to fester and swell; she'd been kept in her birdcage so long, when someone finally opened its door she beat her own wings so frantically she bashed her little stunted bird brains against the windows of her greater confinement. What did she even want? She wanted it all, apparently. But maybe she was selfish—did that make her selfish? What made her think she could have two lovers, a fiancé, a dangerous stalker, painting, cello, perfect grades, and now Harvard Law?

The absence of her two men sent an ache through her. One she exiled and kept at bay though he begged for her, the other a ghost, a spectral

visage, no longer by her side where she needed him, refusing to talk to her, leaving school for a week now. He was hurting, and she'd done it. She loved him bottomlessly. The look on his face in the Twilight Motel would haunt her forever. Surfing on her newfound effect on men she'd seen the scale of her power revealed, and to witness its damage to her loving Max broke her heart. Not a platitude: when he'd removed the ring from her finger she'd suffered profound physical pain in the centre of her chest. Crumpled, broken, devastated; she collapsed on the motel room floor and while her beautiful Cole caressed her and coddled her as she wailed, she hated him for it. It was his fault. Cole had brought the pain to Max and now Max had redirected it to her, and oh, how it hurt. It hurt incomprehensibly.

How could she suffer so greatly when no one struck her?—because it *wasn't* Cole's fault. It was her. *All her.*

“No, no,” she moaned, grinding her brow into the stone floor. It was her lust, her dirty lust.

Out again, out from the bathroom, looking to avoid it all, looking to escape her own thoughts, her accusations ... Standing at the foot of her bed under the gaze of the enormous manifestation of that sheltered fervor straining against her seams. She laughed at it. That stupid fucking little girl. That dumb mouse. She opened her arms to it.

“Here it is, okay? You wanted it.”

Laughter turned to tears, and she went to her easel in the corner, slid her metal stool in place underneath the huge award winning painting she'd been so proud of at seventeen. Like she'd got away with something. Laid it all out, splattered her sexual angst onto canvas and then stood back as the erudite pursed their lips and studied it with manufactured interest, pretending to see meaning when there was nothing real at all to it. Not that they would see. Nodding knowingly, but the joke was on them; you better not be nodding knowingly, you are essentially looking at a half-Chinese nerd opening her legs and pulling her panties aside, begging for someone to fuck her pussy.

She laughed again, cried too, lifting the painting off its two metal posts that held it in place, forgetting how heavy it was, and watching now as it left her hands, scissoring down hard on top of the shelf below, lightbulb popping in a blue flash as it toppled a table lamp before crashing onto the floor on one corner, sending a cracking tremor through the frame. It pivoted, landed paint-side-up and she jumped from the stool landing her

bare feet in its centre. She jumped a few times, watched that once-cherished painting flex, heard the tap-tap of the canvas as it slapped the floor under her feet.

Something was weighing on her, over her shoulders and back, an enormous weight. She hopped off the painting, dropped to her knees to the cart on wheels on the right side of her easel, knocked over bottles till she found what she was looking for. Got the white nozzle flicked open and stood, feet apart and black latex bottle gripped in two hands. It squirted and squelched, and she drew squittering zigzags, whipping the lines back and forth and for a while today's addition didn't alter the composition that much. But it wasn't long until most of that young girl's burgeoning sexuality was completely spritzed in black.

She plunked down the paint bottle, grabbed a broad brush, returned, and straddled each corner of the painting, leaning over and covering it with wide, arcing strokes, moving from point-to-point until almost the entirety was blacked out. By the time she was done, she breathed heavy, back heaving, that weight still pressing. Huge and broad, not like a narrow point.

Now it was hard to breathe. She dropped the paintbrush onto the centre of the ruined painting and turned, falling to her knees and looking at her bed—that place where only two months ago she had sex with Cole while Max watched. She'd been loved by both of them, and the joy she felt, the passion, the salaciousness, had her and Cole bursting from this room looking to spread their filth as far as they could.

Now she was on her knees and elbows supplicating herself before the altar where she'd first fucked Cole. The weight couldn't be ignored.

Horrible thought, but unshakable: ... She could paint it all black but that thought couldn't be avoided. When she'd bared herself unwillingly—unwittingly—to her mother, Carol's acknowledgement, Carol's shocking clarity, had a frightening implication.

She could picture a high definition video of a daughter and that daughter's best man skipping through the halls, naked, running to the music room, pictured a mother watching that daughter get fucked. Mother could've watched her own daughter taking two men at once. One in each hole. She could've seen her own daughter orgasm. Did she? If her mother saw that, what would she do? A mother like Carol? ... It couldn't be possible, could it ...? ...

If a mother watched a daughter in a video so terrible could she use that knowledge to manipulate her daughter?

“Aww, no,” she cried at the enormous fear that she’d been seen, that all she thought was private was known.

On her belly now, she writhed until she lay under her bed. Still trembling she pulled her phone from her pocket and called the only person in the world she could think of who would talk to her right now.

When he answered, she said, “I need you, I need you so bad. Will you come to me? Please, please, come to me ...”

Costumes

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 28TH

JUST PAST MIDNIGHT on Saturday and Max was drunker than he'd been since high school, a night he ended up hospitalized.

How the evening came about: Connor's girlfriend Skyped Connor in the morning and he told her she and their friends needed to go out and get hammered, it was Saturday night after all, *and* Halloween; told her his brother was in town and needed cheering up. Connor put him in a headlock and brought him to the laptop, and his girl, Andie, said *Oh, he's cute*, and that she would invite Marta, who Connor seemed to know, and when Max said he was engaged Connor told Andie Max was kidding.

During the afternoon, while Max and Connor chilled and talked, Andie worked at the school's Project Pumpkin giving Chicago kids a haunted house tour, fun in a bouncy castle, and she and a bunch of other students, including Marta, painted their faces, ran games, and gave out candy.

Andie and Marta showed up in the early evening, Andie, a tiny girl dressed in a tight fuzzy monkey costume (with long curled tail, the face hole enough to show her pretty features but he couldn't even tell the color of her hair) which accompanied Connor's yellow pants, shirt, hat, and polka-dot tie. Marta was from Portugal but had no trace of an accent. She wore red short-shorts, a pink T-shirt, and canvas Keds. When she hung up her coat behind Connor's dorm room door he saw she sported a pale purple backpack. He burst out laughing. Dora the fucking Explorer.

Marta and Andie, knowing he had no costume, presented him with a very official-looking protester's picket sign that read: NUDIST ON STRIKE! BARGAINING MUST BEGIN!

They went out for dinner; Max, Connor, Andie, and Marta. Also attending: a guy with a long beard called Samuel who graduated Journalism at Northwestern (but now just ran his own YouTube channel), dressed in a Boy Scout uniform with shorts and cuffed socks; Mikey, an African from Nigeria here to study Mechanical Engineering, who came as Titus Andromedon from Kimmy Schmidt, just tossing a generous purple scarf around his neck, already sporting a shaved head; and Yvonne and Harry, an engaged couple attending Kellogg for Management, in the most unbelievably elaborate foam Mario and Luigi costumes.

They ate at a Vietnamese restaurant called Yum Dum Duk and he had a Bánh Mì with fried egg and a pork vermicelli noodle salad, and the first three beers of the evening. After dinner they walked around downtown Evanston, winding up at Bay 12 which was raucous and out of control. A wild sports bar with beer towers and vintage American flags; they got a table and split nachos and six pitchers of beer. Coats back on, they took cabs to campus, ambled into a packed lecture hall and watched a crazy chemistry demonstration in the dark. Some lecturer blowing fireballs out of his mouth and making controlled explosions in scary darkness—performed with a backup student dance troupe, cheerleaders, and a marching band.

He knew he was properly drunk when he saw Andie down there in her monkey costume (what the fuck?), holding her hands out while an enormous purple fireball blossomed from her palms; the crowd roared and clapped and he looked around and wondered where the hell he was.

Not sure of the logistics, but somehow, probably another cab, they went back to Evanston, most likely, and watched live music in a past-capacity Irish pub. The volume was eardrum-bursting, he could barely hear himself above the din, even when he yelled. Titus bought two rounds of Jameson's doubles, and he and Marta locked arms and knocked them back each time. There was a lot of Guinness. The band that played were old white-haired men in fishermen sweaters and dunce caps; they played fiddles, jugs, bodhráns, flutes, banjos, one wore a wolf-man mask and played an accordion and it freaked him the fuck out. But he danced and danced, and he fucking laughed his head off. Arm-in-arm with Marta they spun and reeled, encouraged and assisted by clapping red-faced locals.

Now he was in a bathroom at a house that he was sure was off-campus and he kind of thought it was a married couple that owned it, grad students, maybe, friends of Andie's ... No idea how they got there, pretty sure the

others had gone home, it was just him and Connor and Andie, and Marta. Marta was in the bathroom with him, Parquet Courts and laughter and good-natured shouting floated beyond the bathroom door, Marta kissed his neck and his hand was inside her panties.

"CONDOM," Marta muttered. Both her hands cupped his cheeks and her lips kissed at his chin.

"What?" he mumbled, drunk and dry lips sticking together.

"You have a condom?" she whispered.

"Mm, lemme finger."

When he closed his eyes, the room tilted and rotated, so he hoisted them back open. Marta's Explorer shorts were around her knees, her white with red dot panties hiked down mid-thigh. His blue wool sweater lay flopped over the lip of a robin's egg blue bathtub. The bathroom was small, its walls tiled, its fixtures from the fifties.

His fingers stroked up and down her labia and her hips humped her pussy against his touch. He shook his head. She was soft, slippery, hot to the touch and so slick. He got hard in seconds.

"Mm, yeah," she mumbled.

He said, "Where *are* we?"

She said, "Don't know."

His shirt was untucked and her other hand gripped his bulge through his pants now. Her fingers worked his buttons, and he teased her entrance, letting his fingertip sink further in her folds, testing the heat of her core.

"I can't," he whimpered.

"Condom," she said again, thinking that was what stopped him.

He shook his head no.

"Get one from your brother," she whined, slipping her hands inside his open shirt and rubbing his ribs and stomach.

"Not that," he said. His hand moved up from her labia, fingers pausing to scratch her wetness off his finger on the coarse patch of hair she left unshaved just above her sex.

"Don't stop," she urged, her hands undoing his belt buckle and his button, his hands resting over top of hers, not stopping her but slowing her down. She took it and put his hand in the wet stripe between her thighs. Fly unzipped, she pulled out his cock and stroked it.

“Oh God,” he sighed, falling back and hitting his head on the wall, sliding and falling against the toilet.

Marta scrambled to her knees, fell into his lap face first and his cock slipped into her warm mouth.

Her head bobbed up and down, her mouth making smacking noises around his hardness. He ran his fingers through her black hair, medium length, cut in a bob with a fringe almost exactly like Dora the Explorer. His other hand rolled her T-shirt up to her armpits, and he undid her bra. Her breasts were a smaller cup size, but wide scoops. He palmed them, felt her hard nipples. Maggie’s were about the same size, but her chest narrower so her petite bosom was also narrower, and when she would bend over like this, they hung to a creamy rosebud point. The other hand smoothed her lower back, rubbing on her tailbone, then his fingertips sliding down her crack. He smelled her. She smelled sexy, she smelled warm and aroused. Musky, spicy. Not like Maggie though. Not her scent. It twisted his heart. Still, he slipped a finger inside her. She worked her hips against him for a while and he rested his head on the tiled wall.

After a while, she rose up. “What’s wrong?”

“What? ...” he mumbled. She gripped his cock between thumb and forefinger, pinching it tight, her other hand stroking quickly. His weakening cock flopped around as she jerked.

“I don’t know,” he moaned.

She kissed his neck, pinching him harder and stroking faster. She straddled him, wriggling her hips till her panties rolled to her knees and when she opened them wider, they scrolled to her ankles with her shorts. Now she was over him, her ankles together over his ankles.

“Come on,” she said, trying to position him where he needed to be though he wasn’t rigid.

“I can’t,” he said.

“Oh God,” she moaned.

“I can’t,” he said again.

She got to her knees, scratching at his neck as she kissed his chin.

He slurred, “I’m engaged ...”

It was punctuated with the sound of her soft kiss lifting off his face. She cupped his cheeks again and looked in his eyes. “You broke it off,” she murmured.

He nodded, belched in his mouth and turned to the side. "I'm so stupid," he said.

"You broke it off," she repeated.

He sobbed a few times though no tears came.

"Hey," she said, and she scratched his hair above his ear.

"What is wrong with me?" he said.

"Sit up," she said.

"Such an idiot," he sobbed.

She fell against him and leaned with her palms together around his neck and on his shoulder. "Andie said you broke it off."

"I did."

"*Are* you engaged?"

"She cheated on me."

"Bitch," she said matter-of-factly.

"She's not a bitch."

Marta sighed now, exasperated, disinterested. "Get her back," she said.

"I can't."

"Why not?"

"It's my fault."

"What's your fault?"

"She cheated."

"You made her cheat?" she asked.

"I don't know," he moaned. "She's so amazing. She's so pretty and she's so smart ..."

Marta said nothing, but she lay against the wall as he did, bringing her knees up, she worked her thumbs into her panties and shorts and began to pull them up her legs.

Max said, "She's going to go to law school ..."

"Good for her," she said.

"Going to go with my best friend."

Marta paused, shorts pulled part way up her thighs. "That who she cheat with?"

He nodded.

Marta said, "She cheated with your best friend?"

He nodded again.

"Yeah, sure, she's not a bitch."

"I'm going to marry her," he said.

"I'm sorry," she said.

"Nothing to be sorry about," he said, slipping his hand down to his pants pocket and finding his phone.

She said, "Connor told Andie she broke your heart."

"She did," he said. And then he showed her a picture. "Look, this is us." It was a picture of him and Maggie together, sitting on a couch at school, a selfie taken as they studied, became distracted, and started to get frisky with each other. Both of them wore big smiles.

"She's pretty," she said.

"So pretty," he said. "So smart. She can play the cello."

"That's good," she said, her hand feeling around, finding her purse and dragging it over.

"No, I mean she could play in an orchestra. And she paints. Oh, you should see her drawings. She's amazing ..."

"She sounds amazing," Marta said, rooting through her purse and finding a packet of gum.

"She is. I'm so stupid."

"What did you do?"

"Only a bunch of bullshit," he cried, his words close to unintelligible.

"What did you do?" she repeated, her voice higher.

"I'm such a fucking liar," he said, and he fell against her.

She said, "Everybody lies."

"But somebody's gotta be the best at it," he murmured.

She pet his cheek, hiked an arm around him and hugged him to her shoulder, offered him a stick of gum.

"Look, look," he said, showing her the phone again, taking the gum but holding on to it. "She wants me back. Look what she texted me ..."

On the screen were Maggie's sweet pleas for him to talk to her, *Please, Max, tell me why you're so mad, whatever it is I'm sorry, we can make it right* ... He'd ignored them. Cherished that they were sent, but let them go unanswered ...

He said, "What am I going to do?"

"I don't know. What *are* you going to do?"

He turned to her. She had a lovely face, a dark complexion and almost jet black eyes. "What do *you* want to do?"

She sighed, looked away, said, "I *wanted* to have fun tonight."

"We had a lot of fun."

“I broke up with my boyfriend too.”

He asked, “In Portugal?”

“He’s from Portugal. He goes to LSU.”

“He cheat on you?”

“I don’t share with strangers,” she said, not looking at him but smirking. Her pallor had faded, and she looked waxen.

He lifted his head and looked in her eyes, and she looked in his, holding a serious expression until she started laughing.

He said, “We can still have fun.”

“Can you keep it up?”

He shook his head no. “Too much ... Too much whiskey ... Want me to use my hand on you?”

With her lips pursed, she looked at him seriously for a moment, her eyes narrowing, head swaying. She mumbled, “No, hold my hair, I think I’m going to be sick.”

The Dean

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 29TH

IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE TO CONCENTRATE, but she studied for the LSAT, regardless. Study guide open, she lay on the fluffed white duvet, elbows on the king-size bed, chin in her palms. Behind her, gray October light streamed in from Fountain Street, Downtown Providence, coming through the hotel room's narrow window and casting the shadow of her head over the page she had read about three times now, yet to comprehend it.

One-forty-five now in the afternoon, so what was even the point?

The book closed with a wallop, breezing her hair from her face. He would be here soon anyway, and maybe she was wrong, but he could hold his hand out and hoist her from her mire. While she'd waded out into it unwittingly, or at least carelessly, they shared a primordial kinship and perhaps, just perhaps, he would have insight to navigating its dangers.

And with that thought came a double rap on the door. Early, of course.

Off the bed and crossing the suite's polished black floor in bare feet, she adjusted her top and the waistband of her tights, watched her reflection in the hallway mirror, pausing to see if her eyes showed tracks of tears. She sniffed and dabbed at the corners with her ringless ring finger. Just a little puffy.

Lever turned swiftly, she pulled open the door, a bright energy meant to chase away the somber ghosts seeking to drag her down over the last twenty-four hours. She even smiled though Ken saw through its façade; he'd grown up in the same household.

"Maggie," he said, head tilted affectionately, cautiously, prepared for her façade to quickly crumble; for her to collapse on the hotel room's

threshold, given the high emotional tension of her under-the-bed phone call.

"I can't believe you came for me," she said, managing to complete half the sentence before her throat constricted her voice to a mousy squeak.

"Oh, Maggie," Ken said, coming to her and gently holding her arms just above the elbows as her stifled tears veritably streamed from her. "Hey, hey," he said quietly.

"I'm fine, I'm fine," she said, turning away from him. "I'm sorry, Ken."

Ken let her go and stepped into the vestibule, turning and closing the door, slinging off the shoulder strap of his travel bag and settling it on the floor under the mirror. She led the way, and he followed, the two of them coming together in the suite's living room area; two rigid geometric couches and a low square table, glass on steel.

Ken stood like their father, feet shoulder width apart, hands on hips, index fingers hooked over his tricolor canvas belt. Only, unlike Martin, Ken's expression showed warmth and care, as uncomfortable as his body language may seem. Then she was abruptly self-aware of her own body language: bare feet together, arches touching, one big toe squeezed over the other, forearm folded across her stomach, hand gripping the opposite elbow.

She snorted and pulled her lips into a sheepish lopsided smile.

"What? ..." he said, his eyes brightening.

"We are so awkward."

"What do you mean?" he said, but slipped his hands in his pockets and slouched a little.

She could be fun and happy Maggie when she was in Vermont, far from Rhode Island, safe with her Max and her Cole, but Ken was a reminder of how it once had been.

"You held me at the door."

He nodded, brow lowering with concern.

"Could you do it again? ... Hug me?"

His expression softened and his hands slipped out of his pockets. "Of course," he whispered.

They came together cautiously, her with her arms up on her chest, loose fists under her jaw, and with, at first, a diffident clutch, his hands in the middle of her upper back. Nothing was said for a long time, and eventually they pressed together warmly and their stiffness dissipated.

"It's nice," she said.

“It is,” he agreed, and felt comfortable enough to run his palms in easy circles between her shoulder blades. “Tell me what happened.”

She sighed deeply first, preparing herself, said, “I’m an awful person.”

He chuckled once, answered, “No, you’re not, Maggie. You’re one of the sweetest people I know.”

“Then you don’t really know me.”

SOME TIME during the night he’d peed his pants. The cold crotch of his khakis clung to the insides of his thighs.

On his back now, he stared at the ceiling. Coffered, white-painted wood. It was a good chance that he was in Connor’s dorm. The room vibrated. When he closed his eyes it spun. So now he rolled, getting himself onto an elbow. When he had the strength to lift his head, he looked around.

Connor’s room, thank God.

He was on the floor. Above him, hanging over the side of the bed, he saw bare feet that he recognized as his brother’s. He tried to stand, rolling onto his stomach, but found his arms bound together by the sleeves of his shirt and sweater turned inside out. He wrestled one arm free, pulled them off and tossed them out of his way.

It was a struggle, but he managed to get to his knees. The curtains were closed, but they were sheer, leaving the room lit in a pale, hazy brume. One foot underneath him and lifting up to stand, his stomach lurched. Head pounding, he doubled over and rested his forearms across his thighs.

“Holy shit,” he breathed. He could feel his heartbeat in his eyeballs.

On the bed, his tall brother lay sideways, his feet hanging off the edge, arms folded up with a pillow underneath his messy ginger hair. Curled up on the pillow at the head of the bed was Andie, still in her monkey costume, its springy tail pressed up against the headboard. Her feet were bare, and the cowl of her monkey hood pulled down around her neck revealing she had thick chestnut brown hair. He stumbled to the bed, looking to join them, then saw a comatose body laying on the floor on the far side—just a pair of calves and feet. Recognized them as Marta’s.

There was no denying he would vomit, and he needed to get out of the soiled pants, so he reeled backward, throwing a hand out to steady himself

against the wall, practically fell into the narrow bathroom Connor shared with the dorm room on the other side. With maladroit hands he worked his belt off, zipped his fly down, unbuttoned his pants, climbed out of them turning them inside out, pulled his underwear down too, and dropped to his knees in front of the bowl. Didn't even take the insertion of a finger before he threw up a mess of hot Vietnamese food, beer, and whiskey. Instantly better. Except for the pounding headache.

Above him he reached clumsily, hand searching then finding a towel that he hoped belonged to his brother, snatched it from where it hung, got to his knees and tied it around his waist. When he put his hand near his face, he caught the very strong smell of Marta's pussy and it made him groan with regret. On his feet, stumbling away from anxious thoughts right now he crossed the bathroom, listing as he went.

As he opened the door, intending to search for his travel bag and find some clean pants, he came face-to-face with Connor. His face told the story: looking to make a deposit in the toilet just as Max had done. Max laughed, Connor didn't. Max gave him berth and closed the door behind them as his brother stumbled and fell to his knees and vomited into the toilet.

Max leaned his bare back on the cool wall across from the toilet and slid down till he sat his rump on the tiles, arranging the towel to cover himself. He watched his brother's back as he coughed and spit and retched. When he ceased, he groaned an echo into the bowl.

"You okay?" he asked him.

"Been better," Connor said with that same echo.

"Me too," Max said.

Now his brother heaved himself off the toilet with great effort, sat wedged between the bowl and the cupboard below the sink. He looked at Max and said, "Why are you naked?"

Max kicked at his bundled up pants on the floor between them, his belt jingling and change clinking in his pocket. He said, "Peed in them."

Connor chuckled, said, "Some night."

Max said, "Thanks."

Connor said, "What you think of Marta?"

Max shrugged.

Connor said, "You fuck her?"

Max groaned and squinted. "I don't think so. I hope I didn't."

"She's a nice girl," Connor said in defense.

“I made a big mistake,” he said.

“No regrets, Max,” Connor said, head lolling on his shoulders.

Max said, “I have got a lot of regrets.”

They both sat silent for a long time, listening to the sounds of two guys talking in the dorm room opposite, hoping neither of them would need in the bathroom. His heart throbbed in his neck. Connor looked like he fell asleep.

Max whispered, “I lied.”

Connor’s eyes fluttered, waking. “About Marta?”

“About Maggie.”

“What about her?”

“She didn’t cheat on me.”

“What? ...” Connor squinted, trying to sit upright but finding it too much of a struggle.

“She didn’t cheat on me.”

“She didn’t cheat on you? What are you talking about?”

“I lied to you.”

Now Connor made the effort, banging his elbow on the toilet seat, and lifting himself to sit forward, grunting with the extreme effort. “Jesus, Max. I told you—” He burped, his face going green like he would be sick again.

“You going to barf again?”

He shook his head no, sat up right. No longer in his yellow suit and polka-dot tie, he’d somehow been lucky enough to change into something comfortable before he collapsed into bed with his girlfriend. He sat cross-legged now, leaning on the toilet, wearing long satin basketball shorts in the Chicago Bulls colors. He looked gravely at Max and said, “Did she cheat on you or not?”

“I’m sorry, Connor. I don’t know why I said all that. She didn’t cheat on me.”

“Max, you fucking *told* me ...”

“I know,” he groaned.

“Why would you do that? You were fucking crying ...”

“I think ... it’s just my imagination,” he said with hesitation.

“I fucking knew it, Max. I fucking knew it,” he said, looking to the ceiling.

“I’m sorry. It’s not cut and dried, it’s not so simple ... she’s not innocent.”

Connor leaned to the side, twisting at the waist and putting his head in the bowl. He horked into it. "I felt so bad for you," he said, his voice with that porcelain echo.

"You *should* feel bad for me. I'm sorry I lied to you."

"Max, remember when you came in, I said it was all in your head and you said you *saw* it with your own eyes ..."

Max sighed, with no way to explain to his brother he just let it hang. He deserved it. "I know. Anyway, I wanted to believe it."

"You *wanted* to believe she cheated on you?"

He could lie some more: *I got cold feet ... I think I'm afraid to get married ... Just looking for a way out ...*

He said, "I'm just under a lot of pressure."

"Aren't we all?" Connor said, then spat into the toilet again.

"Yeah, we are. I just freaked out."

"Hysterical," Connor said into the bowl.

"Hysterical," Max agreed. That was quite accurate. He was hysterical.

"So, you understand? ... Maggie *didn't* cheat on me."

"Bro, I *told* you it was crazy."

He said, "She's too good to cheat."

"What *did* you see?" Connor asked him.

"It's not what I thought. I have to be honest. It's not what I thought."

"What was it?"

Oh boy. He sighed, said, "It's very complicated ..."

KEN ALREADY KNEW she'd slept with Cole, had witnessed them all in the music room that night, his sister fucking two guys at the same time. What he didn't know was her fiancé had instigated it—wanted it. *Got off on it.* That was too personal, too much Max's business, so she told Ken: "It was fun at first—you know ...? We're friends and it was just supposed to be ... God, I don't know what it was supposed to be."

"Just sex," he said quietly.

"Just sex," she repeated.

They sat opposite each other, one on each rigid couch, the table between them. The sun dipped lower now, evening coming earlier as winter

approached. Ken lit up in fading orange, the shadow of her head folding next to him over the face of the couch. Ken had cracked an Evian from the bar fridge, the glass bottle half empty on the table, cap resting next to it.

Ken said, "When did it become ... *more*?"

"I'm not really even sure."

"Sounds like you don't want to face it."

"What do you mean face it? Face what?"

"Sorry. I didn't want it to sound like that. I just mean ... Well, was it before or after the first time?"

"Before or after *sex*? ... How could it be more before we ... you know ..."

"When did you first have feelings for Cole?"

"Oh."

"Before or after?"

"*Feelings*? ..."

"You know what I mean, Maggie, come on."

"After," she said, but couldn't look him in the eye.

"That's good," he said.

Now her mouth worked around. Had it been before? Sure. It was—she could lie to Ken and she could hide the truth from herself, but ... the evidence was there. She had curiosity for Jay, Max allowed an exciting transgression, it *was* exciting, too, wasn't it?—only it solved nothing for her sexual curiosity, in fact, now in retrospect, it had only piqued it further. Jay was fun but there was no feeling, and if Max allowed Jay, fucking *got off on it*, then gosh, what about that boy (that forbidden boy!), that set her heart dancing when he was around? Max's lust had been used to pursue what she always wanted. She'd been cheating this whole time and denying it, even to herself.

"What's wrong?" he asked her.

"Nothing," she muttered weakly, folding her arms over herself, sinking into the couch seat and curling the soles of her feet over the glass edge of the table.

"It's okay," he said.

"No, it's not," she said, then tears arriving, covering her face with her hands.

She heard Ken say, "Oh, Maggie, sorry, sorry," felt him sit on the seat next to her, put his arms around her. She curled up against him.

He said, "I'm sorry, Maggie, I came here to make you feel better, not worse."

Tears wiped from her cheeks, she sniffed, rubbed a knuckle in an eye. "It's good, Ken. It is."

"What went wrong?"

"The three sometimes would be two."

"No Max? ..."

She nodded her head yes, ran her hands through her hair.

"Maggie, you can't do that," he sighed.

Now she sat up on her hip and watched Ken's face.

He said, "What do I know?—look, maybe you didn't mean anything, or it didn't to you, but you've got to know ..."

"That it would hurt him? I thought he was okay."

He reached out and held her wrist. "Did you just *want* him to be okay with it?"

She nodded yes again, more rapid; inhaled deeply to stave off tears that sought to return. Falling to her back on the couch, she covered her face again, murmured through her hands, "I hurt him so bad. I'm so selfish."

"What are you going to do?" The hand that held her wrist now took her ankle.

"I don't even know. Max won't talk to me. He left school, went home."

"For good?" Ken's voice alert, concerned.

"No, no ..." She sat upright quickly. "I don't think so. He'll be back. He just wanted ... To go away." But now she reeled with Ken's evident belief that Max wouldn't return to Farmingham, or her, ever. Her stomach flipped, and she dug her fingertips into her cheeks, staring frightened holes in the ebony floorboards.

"Max is a good guy, Maggie," he said, patting a hand on her shoulder, frigid Ken getting into human contact now. She covered his hand with her own.

"He's the *best* guy. He's not talking to me, Ken."

"What about Cole?"

She groaned. "*I'm* not talking to him."

"Why not?"

"I don't know ... Things got ... *heated*."

"Between Max and Cole?"

She nodded.

“Oh no, Maggie.”

“It was ugly, Ken. We’re all so ugly.”

He pulled her close, and she rested her cheek on his shoulder. He said, “Do you even know what you want?”

She exhaled long, lips popped out. “I want Max back.”

“You want to marry him?”

“I want to marry him.”

“And Cole? ...”

The groan came out against her will and she winced.

Ken said, “What about Cole, Maggie?”

She drew her knees up and dropped her chin between them. When she was able, she looked to Ken and said, “I love him. I love him so much.”

“Oh, wow, Maggie,” Ken sighed, eyebrows pinched and forlorn, closing a hand over his heart. “Maggie ...”

“What do I *do*?” she whined, hating the sound of her own voice. “I hate myself.”

They sat silent for a while, both listening to the heavy pendulous ticking of an oak grandfather clock.

Ken said, “The way you cried on the phone, Maggie ...”

“I’m so sorry ...”

“Don’t be.”

“I’m sorry to lay this out on you.”

“I want to be here for you. And I want you to be there for me.”

“I’m here for you.”

“I got some stuff to lay on you, too.”

“Go ahead,” she said, studying his calm, kind face, realizing how much she needed him in her life—and how the hell did they ever drift apart?

A broad smile narrowed his sparkling eyes. “Another time, Maggie. Mine is nowhere near as time-pressing. I’m here for you today, but soon I’ll need you.”

“What is it?”

“You’ll be there for me?”

“I swear I will.”

“You know what you have to do now?”

She shook her head no.

“How did you wind up here?” he said, looking around her hotel room, far from home, her real home, in Vermont.

She laughed. "Because I went to see Mother and Father."

Ken didn't laugh. "I mean the situation. Not Providence."

"I know," she muttered.

"You're a liar."

"I'm a liar."

"So what are you going to change?"

"It's that easy?"

"Telling the truth? Max deserves the truth."

"Oh God," she sobbed. "He really does."

Ken stopped her from covering her face again, holding both her wrists.
"Max tells lies, too."

Now she really laughed, and he let her wrists go so she could cover her cachinnation.

"What? ..." he laughed.

She said, "How do you know that?"

"He is, isn't he?"

Happy tears brimmed her eyes now. "He's my good, sweet, lovable liar."

Ken looked at her directly, said, "You tell him, too. Tell him you need the truth. Tell him from me."

When her happiness settled, the somberness returned, and she said, "Max isn't so innocent."

"No one is. We're all guilty of something. We all tell lies. I think Max has your best interest at heart. I really do."

She nodded. "Me, too."

After another long quiet moment she got up and walked to the bed.
"How long can you stay?"

"I have a flight home tomorrow night."

"Can I take you to Chong Qing House and we'll eat hot pot and dumpling till we explode?"

He nodded and smiled warmly. "I love you."

"I love you, too, Ken," she said, suddenly so glad she crawled under her bed and sobbed her woes to her brother, embarrassing as it was. As she slipped on socks and Birkenstocks she asked something that weighed on her incredibly. "Hey, is there any way Carol could have seen the security video before you erased it?"

"Oh. Before I erased it? ..."

“Yeah. I have this *weird* feeling ...”

Ken scratched his chin, averted his eyes. He frowned then, smiled, said, “No way. Maggie, if she saw ... Sorry, but if she saw that, she would absolutely kill you.”

“I know,” she said, shaking off the crazy notion. She would.

Ken looked at her strangely and it reminded her he’d seen it, and seen it live.

She said, “Let’s get out of here. Let me get you something to eat. We have a lot to talk about.”

Black Forest

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 31ST

AT THE END of Rockwell Court, she sat in her rental car and watched the house with the street-side mailbox with a number 21 on the side, and below that: The Miltons. A nice home in an affluent neighborhood, on a big lot that Max's dad kept razor-sharp with a riding mower. Hedges trimmed, Max's mother's blooming garden died down and put to rest for winter under burlap. Two stories, brick, white Colonial accents all the way out here in Michigan; pretty. The Stars & Stripes fluttered from a flagpole.

Today it was decorated for Halloween; orange and black bunting hung from the eavestroughs, tombstones in the yard with comical names of the deceased, and on the porch a stuffed scarecrow sitting in a rocker; the kind that might grab you when you went to retrieve candy. Not that she'd been trick-or-treating, but she'd seen movies.

She put the car back in gear, let her foot off the brake and rolled up the empty driveway. Out and slamming the door, she saw where she'd scraped the rear bumper—not two minutes after she started it after picking it up at the airport. Driving was not her thing. But she had a mission and there would be consequences; hopefully not casualties.

From the back seat, she drew out a pink box and a bouquet of flowers. Bundled together, she walked with them to the front door chewing her lip. She knocked on the door, wary of the scarecrow with its black button eyes and tattered overalls, took a deep breath, conjured up the happiness still hidden somewhere inside her and brought it to her face. Through the glass inserts on either side of the door she saw a shadow pass across the hall, heard the sound of slippers on tile, a muffled football game from the

television in the front room. Before the door was answered she knew it was Max's father.

The look on his face was priceless.

His features exploded with sudden joy and he shook his head with shock and took a step back, clutched his chest mimicking a heart attack then called her name exuberantly: "Maggie! ..."

His reaction swelled that happy part of her and flooded away the moroseness.

"Mr. Mil-ton!" she sang, imitating his happy tone.

"Oh my God," he said. "What a surprise. What are you doing here?"

"I'm here for a surprise," she said.

"Come in, come in," he said, stepping out of the way and ushering her with a rotating hand.

When she was in, he put his hand on her back and pulled her so he could kiss her cheek. "My God," he sighed, then turned and called out, "June! June, come out here ..."

From the kitchen: "Huh? ..."

"Jesus," Max's dad muttered, "deafier than me."

She laughed, said, "This is for you," presenting him the pink box.

"This just keeps getting better and better," he said, taking it from her, peeking in the acrylic window on the top and eyeballing the black forest cake inside. His favorite—the pink box giving it all away as she'd stopped at the trademark Pinky's in town, all the Miltons' favorite bakery.

"June!" he yelled again, then muttering to Maggie: "Jesus."

She giggled. "These are for her," she said, fluttering her bouquet, the triangular point of its paper wrapping pulled back and the white chrysanthemums blossoming out the funnel.

"What is it? ..." June said, coming out of the kitchen wiping her hands on a tea towel, irritated yet somehow pleasantly so. She squealed when she saw Maggie; dipping at the knees like she would almost wet herself, she clutched first her thighs, then her face.

"Oh, my," she gasped, quick-stepping now, coming into the light that spilled into the hall from the outside. "Let me look at you," she said, her warm dish soap-smelling hands cupping Maggie's cheeks and tilting her so she could get that light on her face. She said, "Look at that face ... Keith, will you look at this face ..."

"I know," he said comically.

“My gosh, my Max is so lucky.” Then she kissed her on the corner of her mouth. “Sorry,” she said then, wiping the slight smudge of lipstick she might have left. Max’s mother’s eyes were wet but happy. She’d aged it seemed since the summer, dark circles under her eyes, but that limitless love and happiness she always exuded still radiated.

Maggie said, “I came to surprise you.”

“Surprise us? Well, it’s certainly a surprise. My goodness, I can’t believe you’re here ... Come in, take your shoes off, all that,” she said, backing away and Maggie pried her loafers from her feet.

“These are for you,” she said, presenting her the bouquet.

Mrs. Milton took them, eyeing them, running her fingers over their shapes, letting the petals spring under her touch. “Come on, come to the kitchen, let’s get these in water—I’m going to make us tea.”

“Okay,” she said.

“Coffee for me,” Mr. Milton said, then to Maggie, “You’ll get into this cake with me, won’t you?”

She said, “I’ve been smelling it in the car the whole way from town—I was hoping you’d offer ...”

He hooked an arm around her shoulder in a friendly headlock and kissed the top of her head.

IN THE KITCHEN, Mr. Milton sat at the table while Mrs. Milton poured water in the kettle.

Maggie said, “Is Max here?”

Both of them turned their heads at the same time with similar looks of puzzlement.

She said, “What ...?”

Max’s dad said, “No, he’s not here.”

“He’s not here?”

“Sorry, Maggie. Did you think he was here?”

“He told me he was coming home.” She hated the look of disappointment on their faces. She said, “His loss anyway. More cake for us.”

Max’s dad laughed as he opened the lid to the cake box, his hand poised with a long knife to carve them some. “I want big pieces,” he said. “Don’t you?”

June said, "He was here, he just went to go visit his brother."

Maggie nodded to Mr. Milton, wanting a big piece as well, saying to Max's mother: "Connor? Or Michael?"

Mr. Milton said, "Connor. In Chicago."

June said, "He didn't tell you?"

She struggled to keep her expression bright. She said, "I must've missed ... I must've missed his text."

"Call him," June said to Keith.

He said, "Yeah, let me get the phone ..."

Maggie stood up and stopped him, set him back in front of the cake. "No, no, no, no, please, don't."

"He has to know you're here. We'll make him come home."

She said, "No, that's why I don't want to tell him I'm here. Let him have fun."

"Don't be silly," he said. "You came all this way ..."

She said, "Yeah, I know. I'm going to go home tomorrow, anyway. He wouldn't be home before I left."

June's face brightened, "You'll stay here tonight?"

"Oh," she said. "I don't know ... I thought I would get a hotel ..."

Mr. Milton said, "You're staying here. Don't be silly. Come all this way ..."

"I don't want to put you out ..."

June said, "Put us out?" She turned from her tea set, almost laughing, drying lemon off her hands on a paper towel. "You're family. You are *family*."

And she felt it. Real warmth. She *was* a Milton. Or would soon be. And that was pretty good. "Okay," she said, satisfied, fortified—looking forward to staying with them. "Yeah, I'll stay here. I'd love to stay here. Thank you."

"We wouldn't let you go to a hotel. We'll have a better time without Max anyway, dragging us down."

She laughed and said, "All his moping."

Keith chuckled, putting very generous slices of black forest cake onto plates.

"When did he go to see Connor?" she asked, coming to the opposite side of the counter across from June, standing between two stools and leaning with her elbows.

Keith said, "I guess, was it ...? Was it ... June, was it Thursday?"

"Friday," she said, getting tea from the cupboard.

"Yes, he went last Friday, he's been there since then."

Maggie said, "And how was last weekend?"

He flicked a puzzled look at June, then back to Maggie, saying, "What was last weekend?"

"Max came to see you last weekend?"

June said, "No. We were away last weekend."

"Away?" she said.

"We were away in Lexington. We went to see my sister."

"You didn't see Max here?"

Keith said, "Oh, he was here when we got home."

"When you got home?"

"I guess it was Tuesday. We come in he was sleeping on the couch in the family room with the TV on."

"Oh," she said, a sudden worry that he'd gone off last weekend to do something secret, something nefarious. But now embarrassed that she was very evidently completely unaware of her fiancé's schedule.

June said, "It was a real surprise, just like you today. We came home, he was here. He stayed here three days, left on Friday to go see his brother."

"Oh," she said, "how is Connor?"

"He doesn't keep in touch like Max does—which still isn't enough—but from what he tells us it sounds like it's going all right." June poured boiling water into the teapot and Max's dad passed the cake on plates to Maggie and where June would sit.

"Perfect timing with this, kid," he said to Maggie, nodding to the cake with his chin. "My blood sugar was plummeting and June won't let me at the Halloween candy till after the kids come."

"I had to hide the candy from him," June said into a drawer.

"You like your sweets," she said to Mr. Milton.

"You want to help me scare the crap out of some of the neighborhood kids? There's this one little smart-mouth ... what's the family name, June?"

"Sylvester," June said.

Back to Maggie now, he said, "You wouldn't want to dress up as a scarecrow by any chance?"

"I might," she said with a smile.

THOUGH MAGGIE HAD BEEN HIDING its absence well, when they sat down at the table together June spied right away ...

“Oh no, where’s your ring?”

She’d been prepared. She thumbed where it should be, getting very used to doing that, saying, “We’re getting it resized.”

“Bigger?” June said to her, her voice a hesitant gasp.

It was tough not to roll her eyes up while she thought of what her lie would be, but she said, “Yes, bigger.”

Now June earnestly gasped and put her hands on her cheeks so quickly she knocked her spoon and it clanked on the saucer.

Keith looked at her.

“What ...?” Maggie said.

June hissed, “Are you pregnant?”

“Pregnant?”

June was smiling now, but trying hard to hold back, her face working through a trembling range of elastic happiness; reaching across the table and grabbing her hand, the one that should be wearing a ring, she said, “Please, tell me you’re pregnant.”

Maggie put her hand over June’s and said, “No. I’m not pregnant,” then she burst into tears but laughing uncontrollably, kissing June’s hand, and never feeling more accepted and welcomed in her whole life.

Lacuna

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 2ND

AFTER A BLOCK of free studio time, she checked her phone, standing at the doorway that passed from the glass-walled atrium, where the easels stood, out to the main outer corridor of the Fine Arts building. Still nothing from Max.

Hair tied back in a ponytail, fingernails stained crescents of oil paint, she dropped the useless phone into the pocket of her sweats and took her wool coat off its hook. Max needed to come around soon, the sharp blade of the hurt he applied was beginning to dull.

By now he would know that she visited his parents in Michigan, expecting for him to be there and also learning he hadn't been there the weekend before when he said he would be. The texts she'd sent him this week—ten days now—were heartfelt and honest and frankly heartbreaking. Max not answering her, staying silent, she worried, was less about his heart and more about punishing her. It would seem, after all, that he'd gone to Northwestern to whoop it up with his rowdy brother. And what of the weekend before? If he wasn't with his parents where had he gone?

Part of her considered that her sweet but apparently manipulative Max could draw out his silence for another reason. Anticipating his sweet and hurting fiancée would be so devastated by the relinquishing of her ring, he'd hope she would abstain from her contact with 'the other man.' Max would hope the longer he forced her abstinence the more Cole's power over her diminished. Risky, though, for Max, and she didn't think he could really keep his nerve. He would worry that she would soon turn to Cole (it would be so easy), therefore, sadly, Max's lacuna was real. Her Max was hurting.

And it was painful that she could think of him as a machinator. But he'd led her to that, hadn't he? The divulging he knew she'd tied Jay's hands with pink tights could only mean one thing, and its implication was huge and frightening. How much of their relationship was artful construction and what was really ... real? If Max could devise ...

Thoughts aborted, she stopped her step so abruptly her K-Swiss squeaked on the polished concrete floor of the corridor. Dead ahead, waiting for her: a familiar silhouette. Cole leaned on the metal handrail, the wall behind him expansive polarized glass, the wintry sun casting a tight halo of light around him.

It had been ten days since she'd seen him, and the suddenness of this revelation thumped her in the stomach.

Both hands tucked into the front pockets of his jeans, one desert boot heel hooked on the concrete curb running the base of the window. His long blonde curls framed the masculine features of his pretty face and he jutted his chin forward when their eyes met, tilting his head affectionately, a wary smile tugging his lips. It stopped her in her tracks.

"Cole," she sighed, exasperated, defeated, remaining strength draining out her feet, her posture slumping.

A hand came from his pocket and gave her a gentle wave, but he stayed where he was. "Hi," he said.

She stood her ground, watching him as students passed between them, moving left and right along the corridor. While she didn't want to see him, when the way was clear she crossed the hall and came to stand in front of him.

"What are you doing here?" she said in a whisper that whisked with the trace of a whine.

"I know, I know," he said, tucking his hand back in his pocket, though she could tell his urge was to touch her. And she longed to be touched, too.

"I told you I can't."

"I respect that, Maggie, I do. But when?—you know? Not ever?"

"I told you when."

"It's been ten days."

"I'm not ready."

"I miss you."

She slumped again, a quick sigh escaping her, and she rolled her eyes and looked way, way up to the iron girder ceiling. A reluctant complaint

groaned from her.

“What?”

“This is what I didn’t want,” she said, and now she took the spot next to him, resting her rump on the same handrail, both of them facing the same direction across the corridor, watching the door to the studio space from where she came.

“Maggie,” he sighed, looking down at his feet.

“No.”

When he turned, the honest expression on his face took her breath away and she moaned again.

“Maggie, I want to be your friend. At least let me be your friend.”

“You are my friend, Cole.”

“Don’t shut me out.”

“I don’t trust myself around you.”

“Don’t punish me for that.”

She looked away. “It’s not meant to punish.”

“Did I call you? Text you?”

“No.”

“I respected what you asked me.”

She shook her head at him, smirking now. “You’re here now—waiting for me.”

“It’s been ten days,” he pleaded.

“I told you when I would be ready, Cole.”

“Have you talked to him?”

She shook her head no, looked down at her own shoes.

“Why won’t he fucking talk to you?”

Why do you think, Cole? She just shrugged.

“He still at home?”

“No,” she said, turning to face him. “I went to his house.”

“You went to Michigan?”

“Yeah,” she sighed, nodding. “Max was in Chicago. To see his brother.” She left out the subterfuge of the last weekend she spent with Cole and they had fun, and Max was who knew where. Maybe spying on them from the closet.

“Oh,” he said, turning to face her. “I’m sorry.”

“I hung out with his mom and dad.”

“What did you tell them?”

“Nothing,” she said, bowing her head.

“Can I ... Can I just touch you? ... Touch your cheek?”

She shook her head no.

“Please, Maggie?”

Elbow on the handrail, his masculine but well-groomed hand was held palm up and it would be so easy to put her hand in his. She shook her head no again.

He said, “How’ve you been? Are you okay?”

“I’ve been better,” she laughed weakly, and put her hand over her forehead like she was feverish.

He lamented: “The last time I saw you ...”

Now she hung her head. The last time they’d been together they were both naked, just had sex, Max interrupted, took his ring, and then ...

Her hand curled his thumb, gripped him for a heartbeat, then she raised his hand to her cheek, held his wrist while he stroked her cheek with his knuckles. His hand was warm; strong and gentle.

The last time they’d been together she’d wailed and cried. Cole soothed her, cradled her while she sobbed into his chest, the two of them wrapped in their sex-dirtied sheets. In the aftermath: besides the pain Max inflicted, there was a profound... *embarrassment*. While Cole comforted her she was painfully self-conscious of what he saw that day and how he would regard her. A strange worry that she wasn’t attractive when she cried. What did she look like sobbing, tears running down her face? Worried that her drama would be ... would turn him off. When Cole was, and had been for a long time, her close friend, it frightened her that her heart had made adjustments in their dynamic. He really was more than a friend.

She rubbed her cheek against him as much as he caressed her. The bottomless dread of the last ten days felt suddenly narrower with Cole next to her.

He said, “It’s time, Maggie. Let me be your friend again.”

A light chuckle escaped, and she closed her eyes, focusing on the pleasure of his touch. After a moment, she nodded her head.

“Yeah?” he said, the relief in his voice palpable.

“Yeah,” she sighed, resigned, opening her eyes and staring into his.

His pupils darted back and forth over hers as his tentative smile widened. “Skip class. You have GOV—let’s go somewhere and talk instead.”

“Skip class?” she said worriedly. She’d taken two days off to go to Michigan and two days last week. She said, “Where?”

“Anywhere. Satinder’s away today and tomorrow.”

She let his hand down.

“Your *room*? Come on, this is what I’m saying ...” Now she turned her back, wishing everything was so much easier.

His arms came around her and being in his embrace raced her heart wildly. He whispered, “Not like that, Maggie, I swear not like that.”

“Cole,” she complained while he rocked her in his arms. Out of his embrace, she turned to regard him. “This is what I’m talking about.” He regarded her plainly, mouth agape, eyes wet and wondering; she saw he was honest, just struggling for connection, communication.

Both hands on his chest, she smoothed his dark wool sweater, felt the hard body underneath. A sudden imagining of Max appearing in the hall—ten days waiting, being good, and he wanders in at this moment, dashing all hope. She whisked her hands away, curled her thumbs inside loose fists. “Take me ... Would you please take me to Altieri’s?”

“Really?” he laughed.

“Buy me a pizza, okay?”

He nodded. “Yeah. Yes. Thank you.”

AS THEY WALKED side-by-side across campus, heading for the village, her phone buzzed in the pocket of her sweats. Fished out, she read on the screen:

Max: I want to talk. Will you talk with me?

Ten days. Max let her suffer for ten days of silence and, though she knew he’d been hurt too, the coincidence that he would text her in the minutes after she reconnected with Cole was striking. She stopped on the path and Cole continued, turning after a few steps, saying, “What?”

Phone back in her pocket, she turned around in a circle, watching the horizon, watching behind trees and windows, wondering from where he spied her.

“Nothing,” she said.

But by the time they reached the main street, passing under the FarmFresh student laundry, she had an idea. “Cole, would you go away with me this weekend?”

LAYING ON HIS TEENAGE BED, looking down between the V of his sock feet, he saw: his dresser, then from floor to ceiling on either side, dark wood cubbyhole shelving; storage for a basketball, a baseball glove, his favorite books, speakers for the stereo, metal boxes with snap latches that contained mementos ... Things that had meant something at one time, though he rarely thought about them anymore ... Drawings girls had given him, sometimes letters, postcards from aunts and uncles ... In the corner, leaning sideways, his snowboard that hadn't seen use in five years; leaning against the snowboard, his skateboard, which hadn't seen use in maybe ten years. Above the dresser, affixed to the wall, a mirror with a blue Mexican tile border. One he'd stare into, looking at his stupid face every morning before going to school, checking his sideburns, running his fingers through his hair, and when he started shaving, double checking to make sure no stubble was missed. Tucked inside the frame: photographs. Through the years, various female faces stared back from those spaces. All removed, of course, now having found the love of his life. There were ticket stubs, notes from Maggie, and only two photographs now. One of her that she had given him, wearing her blue blazer from private school, a young, pretty, teenage Maggie with a serious face. The other photograph, one of the two of them together, cheeks pressed, a selfie taken on his iPhone then sent away to be printed, mailed to his dorm room. The two of them together, at their most buoyantly happy, probably after eight months of dating.

When he returned from Connor's, he found something else tucked there. A stiff card, and on it, in his Maggie's pretty handwriting, three statements:

I love you.
I miss you.
Please, come back to me.

And below, a faint impression of her lips pressed in a kiss. Not one for makeup, he traced the shape of those loving lips with the pad of his index finger, trying to determine the pale silvery shape her colorless lip gloss had pressed.

One week ago, if asked, he would've claimed though he knew it was a mistake, taking his ring back was still somehow the right thing. That vague determination waned the farther from the date. He was complicit. More guilty than Maggie even. And he was punishing her ...?

His fiancée, the fucking love of his life, so bewildered by his silence, his hurtful treatment, flew to Michigan to make things right. He didn't even deserve her.

It was all his mom could talk about. *Maggie's doing this, Maggie is doing that, you see these flowers? ... Maggie brought them ... we all had dinner in the dining room, and she helped; you should have seen her and your father, scaring those little kids; she let him dress her up as a scarecrow; I was pulling straw out of her shirt all night; she's so pretty, she's so smart, you know she's going to law school?—why didn't you tell us?*

They could've offered Maggie the guest room for her to stay, but his dad told him Maggie wanted to sleep in his bed. Mom had washed and changed the sheets since, but Max imagined he could still smell her.

His phone, laying on his stomach next to her handwritten card, buzzed with his Maggie's response.

Maggie: where are you?

Max: I'm at home

Maggie: home where?

Max: in Michigan

Max: with mom and dad

Maggie: you're not in Vermont?

Max: I just got home from Chicago

Max: laying on my bed

Max: can't believe I missed you

Maggie: when are you coming here?

Max: Friday

Max: will you talk with me?

Maggie: would you go away with me?

Max: away where?

Maggie: we need to talk

Max: tell me where and I'll be there

Lodgers

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

He entered the grand lodge's hallway, three stories high, another iron chandelier above them both. The floor was angular granite flagstones, and a staircase wound in a circuit, its bannister and railings in glossy wood with black metal moose antlers and branches. Maggie walked the door closed, and it sounded a doom, then the large space was eerily quiet in the absence of the wind's high whistle. They stood face to face, those restrained smiles returning, his fiancée looking so goddamned adorable he couldn't wait till this was over and he would sweep her up in his arms and make her laugh again.

The sound of shuffling feet on stone made him turn. Coming from the depths of the huge home, Cole walked, eyes turned down to regard a bottle of Scotch he held in his hand.

He was saying, "Is this the one?—because this is almost thirty years old and I can't ..."

Air punched from Max like he'd been thumped in the belly. His mouth fell open. He said to Maggie, "What's he doing here?"

Cole stopped short, face darting up to see them both watching him from the front door. His features sagged, and he grew a look of pain. He said, "What's he doing here?"

THE THREE OF THEM, together again, standing in the grand high entrance of the Becker lodge; polished logs stretching from floor to high

ceiling, the gnarled roots of their trunks spreading and disappearing into the stone floor.

The look of profound disappointment on Cole's face was probably very much like his own. Both of them under the assumption Maggie had invited them away to be alone with her.

Cole set down the bottle he held on an iron leg table next to the staircase. He covered his face in both hands, sighed a long inhale, rubbed his cheeks, pulling them down till crescents of bright pink flesh under his lids showed, raked his fingers through his long blonde hair, bunching it up in a ball behind his head, standing now holding it that way, eyeballing Maggie with a humorless face. "What are you doing?" he asked her.

Maggie shrugged, turned her palms out, caught red-handed. None of them smiled.

She said, "Sorry."

"Goddamnit," Cole sighed, he looked to the ceiling and stretched his neck.

There was a greater clarity to be seen here; the reason why she had brought them all together—but he didn't care. There was a striking similarity to the way he'd *last* seen them, and the ignition that had prompted him to remove her ring, wanting to hurt her by severing the symbol of their bond. Yet again, he'd found them together, the woman he loved and his best friend.

He looked directly in her amber eyes and shook his head with admonishment. "You've got to be kidding me." And with that he turned on his heel and yanked the enormous door open. Cold wind faced him, squinting his eyes and ruffling his hair. He went out.

Maggie's voice behind him, thin and brittle pushing against the cold: "Max, wait!"

He disregarded her, punishing her again, but the sight was honestly too great to bear. She caught him at the top step, trotting behind in warm bare feet on cold stone, arms clutched around herself. He turned to face her, his scowl restrained yet still evident.

"Don't you dare, Max. Don't you dare leave."

"You wanted me to find you two alone together again? Brought me all this way to stick it to me?"

"That's not what you think, Max. You *know* what I'm doing."

"No. What are you doing?"

“Come back inside, Max.”

He shook his head. Cole watched from the open door with an expressionless face.

She urged him again, “Come inside.” Hands tucked into the sleeves of her sweater, she shivered visibly.

He said, “Why would you do this to me?”

“For your own good. For *our* own good.”

He slumped, rolled his eyes, then his jaw returned to its hard line. “You’ve been fucking him?”

She said, “Not at all, Max. Not even once.” She looked directly in his eyes.

“Have you been hanging out with him?”

She hugged herself tighter against the cold. “No.” She shook her head, correcting herself, saying, “Yes, but only since Thursday. A day and a half.”

“Did you sleep with him?”

“Max, I told you—”

“No, I mean in bed. Sleep next to him, hug him or cuddle with him?”

Her face softened briefly, then her lips trembled again as a gust of wind hurled up the stone steps at them. “No, Max, I swear. We just talked. One hug. Brief.”

He grimaced at the thought. A hug, even brief, hurt his heart to imagine.

Next to them, the metal that supported the enormous chandelier groaned, the wind setting it swaying again, dangling precariously over the Rogue she had rented him.

Maggie looked into his eyes pleadingly. “Would you hug me?”

They stared at one another, Maggie making the gesture he longed to make, saying the words he longed to say, a hurting in his heart looking to reject her again. The hope in her eyes never diminished, staying connected to his, growing wet with tears. She blinked them away as the cold stung at them as he imagined it stung his own.

She said, “I want to hug you so bad, Max.”

He nodded rapidly, his heart bursting against his ribs like they were too small a cage.

They came together in a collision that grunted their breaths away. She whispered in his ear, “I’m so sorry, Max, I swear, I’m so sorry.”

He squeezed her as tightly as he could, his hands forming fists on the center of her back. He lifted her feet off the ground. “Maggie, I’m so sorry,

too. I'm so sorry ..."

"Please, come back inside with me. Take me in where it's warm. It's cold out here, Max."

THE SEIZING COMPUNCTION that had gripped her for ten sorrowful days had begun to ease. It was like a tangible energy that slipped out of her in low-voltage waves, her embrace with Max the connection needed for its release, a circuit completed, their pain dissipating into the cold stone at their feet.

Max arriving and finding her with Cole wasn't the best way for a reintroduction but its occurrence was mostly unavoidable. Had she told either of them the other would be present this weekend they would have begged off. Or worse, been infuriated. So it had to be done this way.

Before coming in with her, holding her in his arms on the wintry doorstep, Max had whispered, "Why didn't you just tell me what this was about?" and she'd said, "You wouldn't have come." And it wasn't just about Max and Cole, it was her as well. Something they all shared, something of tremendous value, had been rent and the only thing that would knit it was truth and presence. What they had between them all was worth the hardship.

Now she was alone in the kitchen, and her boys, as Carol had called them, were together without her. There was a power she still held over them, and as mad as they both were about the other's presence, ultimately they each wanted to be with her. She would use that to get what she wanted, and it was for the noble benefit of them all.

The Schroon house, or lodge more accurately, was one of father's investments; one that he only occasionally used for his own enjoyment. She'd never visited, only remembered seeing pictures when it was purchased. The lodge had a schedule of use, when it was being used and when it was vacant, and she'd boldly called father's property manager to see if it was free this weekend. The keys were requested, granted, and she supposed they would inform Martin. Neither Carol nor Martin had called to prevent it, and the keys had been arranged for pickup at a real estate rental office in the Schroon Lake hamlet. The absence of interference from her mother and father could be hopefully attributed to their belief she sought

closure with one of them, Max or Cole, especially given the visit home last weekend.

Which brought another harsh element to this weekend's agenda: she would have to let Max know the wedding had been called off. Whether the revocation of his ring had been real or not, his antics and ensuing silence came with real repercussions.

Max's silent treatment, whether masterfully contrived or simply an honest reaction to the hurt she'd callously wrought, had another (perhaps intended) effect: it worked a hex on her beneficial to her fiancé, sure; gone from her thoughts on Cole was the broiling lust that had been there. However, even with the dirty-sex depleted from their burgeoning relationship, in its absence she was aware of what had been growing in its center: a small seed of love and compassion. And, truthfully, it may have always been imbedded in their friendship, just never receiving light or water or nourishment until that evening on the cold black beach, under Max's own reluctantly encouraging stare.

Across the street from the real estate office where she and Cole had retrieved the keys to the lodge, they'd gone to a Stewart's Shop and stocked up on cans of beer, ice cream, snacks, hard rolls, and frozen pizzas. The promise had been they would eat out this weekend, maybe even get some proper groceries, but with this sudden weather they might be better off holing up in the lodge until it was over or until they had to go back to school. So, for now she prepared *her boys* something to eat, putting a shop-baked pepperoni pizza into the massive stainless Viking stove set inside the square-chiseled stone hearth of a twelve-foot tall fireplace. She turned the red knob, sat down on a stool, elbows planted on polished black marble. It would be fifteen minutes.

Winning

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

AT THE BACK of the house, in a grand room with towering Yellowstone windows that looked out over a choppy pond whipped up by the winter wind, Max watched out the window with his arms folded; beyond, through a haze of drifting, flickering white, he caught glimpses of the mountains in shades of dying lavender.

Beyond the glass there was a wraparound deck, its railing in narrow timbers, the gaps crossed in Xs, a twenty foot drop to the woods below. Cole returned, coming in off that deck, arm holding a bundle of firewood, slamming the door behind him, stomping his feet amidst a torrent of dry rasping snow that danced around his boots. “Jesus, this Goddamned wind,” he said to himself, shaking away the cold, kicking off his untied boots and walking to the fireplace where he tossed the wood onto the stone mantle. He turned to *almost* face Max, not quite committing, shaking his shirt, pinching it in his fingers and whisking away the slivers of wood and tattered bits of bark that clung to him.

Max watched him for a moment, broke the ice with: “I know. It’s only November.”

Cole said, “Alberta clipper.”

“What’s that?”

“I don’t know. Snow squall or something. That’s what Maggie called it. Alberta clipper.”

“Sounds fitting,” Max said.

He left Cole now, walking with his arms folded still, retrieved from a low table in front of the couch the bottle Cole had held when Max arrived.

Maggie gave it to him in the kitchen, urging him to go into the living room and talk to the guy that had been at one time his best friend. He presented it to Cole without expression, holding it in two hands like a sommelier at a table side. Two quick nods from Cole were his breaking of the ice.

While the fire cracked and popped in the hearth, Max moved to a glossy, honey-stained cellarette where a mirrored tray held an arrangement of whisky glasses. The cork on the bottle came off with a squeaking pop and he splashed some of the peaty beverage into them. He took a sniff before turning, tilting the glass to his nose and looking above at a boar's head mounted to the log wall, its tusks a bony ivory, long and curved.

When he returned, the two of them standing face to face by the fire, he handed Cole a glass and he went through the same ritual of smelling. Although they didn't look at each other, choosing to watch the buttons on each other's shirts, they touched the rims of the glasses before finally imbibing. Then, with nothing to say, they both turned away and sat down on the plump and comfortable leather furniture; Cole in an arm chair and Max at the corner of a couch, facing him.

He took another sip. "I didn't see any tracks coming up the drive ... wouldn't have thought anyone was home except I saw the smoke." He pointed with a middle finger, the hand that held the whisky glass bobbing toward the flames that burned in the mouth of the massive stone fireplace.

"We got here earlier. In the morning," Cole said.

"You've been here all day?"

Cole nodded, looking at the fire and not at Max. "We came in the Jeep. It's in the garage."

"Where's that?"

"Around the back."

Now he was stuck on the idea that his Maggie and Cole came up here together, could picture them doing it. Laughing in the car, Maggie playing music from her iPhone placed in the cupholder, saying *When are you going to fix your stereo?* giggling and road-tripping. Alone in the lodge, too, all morning, his friend and Best Man looking for ways the whole time to get her in bed, knowing he would ...

Max said shakily, "Should I put the rental there?"

"Do it later," he grunted. "We should talk first."

"Right."

Sipping at his drink he continued to stare into the fire, just as Cole did. Head rolling on his shoulders, looking up at the towering hand-scribed logs, he finally said, “This is some house.”

“I know, huh?” Cole grunted with a chuckle. “There’s a huge pool table downstairs, a cigar room, uh, humidor. Home theater with red velvet curtains that, like, part to reveal the screen.”

“Like a real theater.”

“Yeah, crazy.” After a long pause, both of them listening to each other’s breathing, Cole said, “Maybe we could have a cigar later.”

“Yeah, cool,” Max grunted and nodded.

Cole said, “Maggie’s never even been here before. Her parents’ own place ...”

“I know,” Max said.

“Should’ve brought an Xbox,” Cole muttered solemnly. Yes, plans had changed, and this weekend was going to be different than anticipated.

Max said, “Does she know if there are cameras?”

“We checked when we got here. There aren’t any. Martin’s hardly ever here, she said. He rents it out mostly to guys who hunt. From Germany and Holland. They come here and stay. He wouldn’t put cameras on them, you know? He doesn’t have any artwork here. Plus, she said, he hires a company to watch the place, make sure its safe—that’s instead of cameras, right?”

“Probably.”

“I don’t know.”

“Fuck it, anyway.”

They both set their empty glasses down on the table in front of the couch at the same time, leaned back to sit and watch the fire. Max’s attention drifted to watch his friend. Slumped in the deep seat of the leather chair, elbows on the armrests, fingers interwoven, long hair tied in a bun, chiseled features set seriously as the light from the flickering flames reflected in his eyes.

Max said, “Am I ruining your weekend?”

Cole said, “A little.”

“You came all this way this weekend thinking you were going to be alone with her; fuck her brains out.”

“It’s not like that, Max.”

“Right, it’s not.”

Cole turned his head to face Max, brow set low. “Hey, Max, did you come here this weekend thinking you were going to fuck her brains out?”

Max stared back at him blankly.

Cole said, “That’s not why you came, is it?”

“No.”

“Not so crazy I might think the same.”

The implication of that potential truth was hurtful and something that had sent him running from them in the first place. Cole may have real feelings for Maggie. It was so obvious though, wasn’t it? Lips pursed, a tremor possessed his jaw, fighting the urge to yell, *You came on my fiancée’s face!* What was Cole’s game? Humiliation, sex, domination ... or, worst of all, was his friend falling in love with Maggie?

They looked at one another for a long moment, both faces set hard, then after a long moment, Cole’s features loosened, tension easing away and his eyes softening. He nodded, sniffed, said, “Max, I’m sorry I punched you.”

“Yeah?”

“I am. Really.” Cole continued to nod, affirming to himself that apologizing to his friend was his noble duty.

Max nodded too. “What I said was pretty shitty. I didn’t ... I didn’t even mean it, you know?”

“I get it.”

Max tugged and squeezed his earlobe, chasing away a tension that looked to twist his insides. “The day ... when I came in the room, the day I, you know, took the ring ... I was coming to apologize ... because I said ... what I said ... and I didn’t mean it.”

A reluctant smirk picked up the corner of Cole’s mouth. “Things got really fucked up, huh?”

Max said, “I fucked up.”

“You did. So did I.”

“Yes, you did.”

But that was all Max would say, and it seemed it was all Cole would say too, and now sitting next to him like this, watching the side of his handsome head as he looked away from him again, both of them unwilling to look into one another’s eyes for too long, he felt anger return. Hands clenched on his thighs, he stroked them up and down like he was straightening his pants, shifting uncomfortably in his seat as he did.

After a deep breath and a quick exhale, he said, “You ever go with your buddies to Brattleboro? ... Beat up Jay ...”

Cole shook his head no, eyes lost and mesmerized by the fire. Then he looked up to the ceiling, expression somewhat brighter, raising his eyebrows like he considered some thought. He huffed a silent laugh, said, “I didn’t need to.”

“Didn’t need to ...?”

Now Cole looked to him, eyes meeting, a certain sparkle there, not mirth, not happiness, but something that made Max’s stomach uneasy. Cole said, “Maggie took care of it herself.”

“Took care of what?”

“Jay. You didn’t know that?”

He shook his head no. “Know what?”

A somber expression returned to Cole, and he looked away at the fire, that sparkle extinguished, replaced with a measured dolefulness. “I don’t know,” he said quietly.

“How did she take care of it?”

“She doesn’t want to talk about it.”

“What do you mean?”

“It’s sensitive.”

“She told you?”

Cole nodded.

Max said, “I’ll ask her.”

“Don’t make her go through it again.”

“What? ...”

“It was really tough on her.”

“So tell me.”

Cole looked at his hands for a while, watching his thumbs as they rotated around one another, his eyes narrowed like he was contemplating judiciously. “Okay,” he sighed, straightened in his chair with intense preparation for what he would reveal. “So she went to—this was the day after ... uh, Monday ...”

“Yeah?”

“She went to Professor Carmichael, you know, Jay’s dad ...”

“I know she did.”

Cole paused, looking at him, taking a minute to understand how Max would know that. Did Maggie know he’d followed her that day? Did she

know her creepy boyfriend was watching from the shadows once again? And if she did, in the aftermath of what happened in *The Twilight*, did she lament to Cole, her handsome lover, *all* of Max's transgressions?

Cole continued, "She went to see Carmichael; made an appointment with him, he likes her, sees her right away thinking she wanted help getting into Harvard or something ..."

"Yeah."

"Maggie tells him she's there to talk about Jay, and he's, like, oh, okay. But he saw her already out somewhere with Jay one time—"

"Yeah. Wrestling expo at State," Max said, eager to be a step ahead of the story.

Cole nodded, eyes narrowed. "Okay," he said, looking like that was something he didn't know and it made Max feel oddly superior, at least for the moment. "Carmichael knows Maggie is engaged to you, but sees her with Jay. So in his office, like he's anticipating what she would say about his son—like even *he* knows his son is a fucking asshole—he puts it on to her."

"What do you mean: puts it on her?"

"Starts alluding to her leading his son on."

"Leading Jay on?" Max said, a ghost of his own voice echoing in his hollow mind, telling Maggie he wanted to watch her make Jay fall in love.

Cole continued: "Doesn't even know what she's going to say and already he's putting up a defense."

"A defense?"

Cole nodded. "Making it sound like whatever she's going to say is ..." he searched for the right word "... I don't know, *overstated* ... *hysterical*."

"Maggie did this?—confronted him?"

"And she didn't back down. Carmichael acts like Maggie's some campus slut throwing herself at his son, like his son is a big deal. And ..." now Cole smiled, "... Maggie just looks him in the eye, lays it out, all the shit Jay did to her alone in her dorm room," his eyes were misty and distant.

"She did?"

"Said to me she was so scared, but, like, she knew she was right. Knew what she wanted."

"What did she want?"

Cole looked at him, shaking his head with disbelief. "Told me she wanted to win."

A knot tightened around his viscera, picturing his Maggie that morning in The Twilight, riding Cole's cock, an act Max had allowed, her reaching out to her Max, happy, telling him she won, not seeing what doom Max was about to bring her. "Win what?" he said, a sad tremor pinching his voice.

"I don't know ... Just to beat him. Beat Carmichael."

"So ... what happened?"

"Maggie challenges him. Says she's engaged, yes, Jay also knows she's engaged—whatever thing they did together was complicit. Like, lessening his argument against her. He says women will say things like lies and half-truths, you know, and they don't think the words have weight and like, how they can hurt men ..."

"What?"

"This is what she told me. Maggie tells Carmichael what Jay did to her, alone in her dorm room—her clothes ripped off ..."

"What did he do?"

While Cole had been eager and engaged with his retelling, this element seem to be one that still troubled him. Expression resuming its sober frankness, he said, "He didn't ... you know ... didn't ..."

"He didn't? ..."

Cole shook his head, eyes gleaming wet. He sighed, cleared his throat, went on: "He didn't. Scared her so bad, for real. She really did think ... thought that maybe it ... it would be worse."

"Worse?"

"She was *really* scared."

Max sighed and rubbed his face. This was something she'd alluded to the day he'd come home from San Diego to find her room abandoned. Reunited on the bed in The Twilight, she let him know how scared she'd been, but using words that evening, telling details, had been too difficult for her. "Fuck sake," he moaned.

"Yeah," Cole said, then brightening, picking up the trail of the story, he said, "but then, because he didn't hurt her, Carmichael is really dismissive. Like what happened was no big deal. Asks how much she wants."

"How much? ..."

"For property damage. What an asshole."

"Property damage?"

Cole hemmed, looking for the way he wanted to say something. "Maggie was wearing my shirt and Jay ripped it off her and tore it up."

“No,” Max said, horrified, though he knew it already, but now he could see it again, his scared naked Maggie, and now with the added revelation she had worn another man’s shirt, like some sort of sense of belonging, ownership. She once wore Jay’s shirt and Max knew exactly the hurt that could deliver to a man’s heart.

“And, um ... a drawing.”

“What drawing?”

“A drawing of me. Jay saw it and ripped it up.”

Max could see it. See the drawing done in Maggie’s distinctive hand, only in his mind’s eyes the drawing was the secret one he’d seen of Jay, hidden in Maggie’s sketchbook. The pain that drawing delivered had brought them all here to a cabin in the Adirondacks, lost in the snow. “Okay,” he said, trying to hide a whimper from his voice.

Cole smiled warmly now, Max realizing the hard parts of the story were over. Eyes wistful again, looking somewhere over Max’s head, Cole said, “Flashback to that Monday morning—”

“Yeah?”

“Maggie wakes up and her phone is charged. Looks. Finds a video ...”

“Of what?”

“When Jay was terrorizing her—when I went to get fucking pizza—” his hands clenched in shaking fists, “—he sat on the bed, his back to her, and Maggie’s phone was under her, she takes it, God, she said she was so fucking scared ...” He paused to shake his head, continued, “She tried to call 911, wanted to, but was so afraid.” Now he held a tight fist over his mouth, blinking his glistening eyes, trying to get a breath that sought to become a sob. Max felt it too, his chest tight as a drum. Cole sighed, cleared his throat, said, “Couldn’t do it, too frightened to think what Jay would do if he caught her. Tucked it back under her. Didn’t know she’d swiped the screen to camera, left it on video ...”

“What?”

“Didn’t even know it happened. So *boom*,” he said, lightly but deliberately thumping his fist on the padded leather arm of the chair. “She puts the phone on Carmichael’s desk. There’s no video, the phone was facedown on the bed but she said you could hear Jay, how angry he was, how ... how scared she was ... and Jay goes on this crazy rant. He doesn’t threaten her or anything, not really, but it’s this long wild misogynistic complaint ... Like, she said he sounded crazy.”

Max rubbed his face again.

“And Jay says ... said something bigoted about her.”

“Bigoted?”

“Chinese,” was all Cole said.

“Did you hear the video?”

Cole shook his head. “You crazy? She said *she* can’t even hear it again. I swear, she didn’t even want to tell me *any* of this. Not the bad parts ... Just how ... she won ...”

“So what happened?”

“Jay is on this rant and Maggie watches Carmichael get more and more uncomfortable seeing his son’s future go...” Cole held a thumb and forefinger up and brought them slowly together, a narrowing aperture, until they closed together. “Then, from the phone ... *boom*,” Cole said, slapping one fist into a palm. “And Maggie looks straight at Carmichael, says: That’s where he punched a hole through my wall.”

Max was seized with disbelief. “Maggie did this?”

Cole shrugged, showed his palms, smiling, saying, “She did.”

It was crazy. Crazy that it happened. Crazy she ever slept with that guy in the first place, crazy she was with Cole on that weekend, terrorized by Jay, then she *recorded* him? ... Max had proposed in the spring to her, and they were to be married. Everything was supposed to be so simple. So straightforward. So sedate. Most unbelievable was his demure fiancée rising from the terror, seeking some sort of victory. And how the hell did she find the tenacity to face such an enormous confrontation? It was bewildering.

He said, “What did she win?”

Cole shook his head in a mirror of Max’s own disbelief, smiling wider now. He held up a fist, flicked his thumb out, said, “Written admission of what Jay did,” now his index finger flicked out, “Jay is not to contact her ever or in any way after the letter, and three,” now his middle finger extended too, “Jay is never to set foot on Farmingham campus while she’s a student there.”

Max stared at Cole’s hand, waiting for number four. When it didn’t come, he said, “That’s it?”

Cole gripped the armrests, raised his eyebrows, said, “Jay didn’t hurt her. Just scared her. Can’t punish him for what you thought he was going to do. He’s, like, the NCAA Golden boy, he’s got scholarships. The things he said could be trouble, but ... Everything else is hearsay. He’ll write Maggie

a letter, probably more like an apology. Saying *I'm sorry you took it that way, blah, blah, I didn't mean to frighten you*," he waved his hand, rolling in circles, indicating further non-incriminating platitudes.

"And you think he'll never come to Farmingham?"

"Really doubt it," Cole said confidently.

They both stared into the fire for a while. That was winning. That was what she'd accomplished on her own, and if this was true he was so proud of her. Only, all he could think was how it was revealed to him: retold to him by another man.

He said, "When did she tell you this?"

Cole scoffed. "Why?"

"She didn't tell me," he said toward the floor, more in disbelief, more to himself than to Cole.

"You went in exile," Cole said.

"She told you on the ride up here?"

"That's what you're worried about? How long ago she shared this with me?"

"She didn't talk to you after the hotel?"

"What? ... No, she didn't. Refused to talk to me. Max, she bawled like a baby when you took her ring." He tried to keep a firm face but there was a gleam in his eye. "It hurt her so bad she couldn't even look at me. But I was around. I watched out for her."

"Watched out for her?"

Cole looked away, shaking his head. "Dude, you left her alone, not knowing if Jay would come back, if he was still angry ..."

There was a knock behind them, a double rap on one of the enormous logs that framed the entrance to the main living room. They turned to see Maggie hanging off it, smiling sweetly but anxiously. "Pizza's ready, guys," she said, waving them to follow her into the kitchen.

White Lies

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

FRESH FROM THE OVEN, Maggie put the hot pizza on a wooden block an inch-high and half a foot broader than the extra-large Stewart's pie. Lucky to find a pizza cutter, she lifted it from the counter and offered Cole the honor.

"Ah, a-thank you," he said with flourish, spinning the board on the counter, eyeing up his subject. Max joined them now, coming in from the living room with his hands in his pockets, face drawn and morose.

"How's it going?" she asked him.

Chin lifting, eyes tracking to find where she stood on the far side of the marble top island next to Cole. He smiled weakly, then came around to join her. As Cole rolled the wheel through the center of the pie, Max's arms came around her from behind and he held her.

"Fine," he whispered, rocking her.

She tilted her head, let Max press his cheek to her neck. Her hands came up to grip his forearms where they crossed over her.

"Maggie?"

"Yeah?"

He whispered, "I let you down. I'm sorry I went home. Sorry ..."

In front of Cole was not where they should have this talk. She said, "It's okay, Max. We'll talk."

"I have a lot to say," he told her.

"We all do," she said now, twisting out of his grip and facing him. She cupped his cheek. He was warm, but his color pale, waxen. She frowned.

Still holding her sweet Max's face, she said to Cole, "How did your talk go?"

Cole finished carving the pizza into eight slices, placing the wheel down on the wooden block, saying, "Yeah, fine." Then looking to Max, he said, "We talked."

Max nodded, and she ran her thumb over his cheek, below a sad, trembling eye. "What's wrong?"

"I told you. I'm sorry I let you down."

"How'd you let me down?"

"I should have stayed. Not gone home. Worked this out, too. I don't know why I ran away ..."

She didn't answer. It was a lot they'd gone through. The removal of her engagement ring had been devastating. Max wasn't to blame for that, not entirely, acting from pain, hopefully not manipulation. Running away wasn't always a reaction to pain, it could be to fear. Was Max afraid he was losing her—or was he afraid of the things he'd done?

"After we eat, we'll talk. Agreed?"

"What do you want to talk about?" Max said fearfully, and she could see him sickened at the possibilities. Max worried what she would say—worried it would be something final.

She said, "I love you," in an effort to quell his disquiet. "Okay?"

"Okay," he returned.

"Not a bad pizza," Cole said behind her, and she turned to catch him already putting the point of a slice in his mouth. He set it down, slapped his hands, pointed at Max, and still chewing, said, "Max?—beer?" Without an answer he was already in the fridge pulling out two cans and setting them on the counter.

Even Cole wanted that worry removed from Max, and if he and she were both compassionate, there was hope.

"Me too, please," she said.

"All right," Cole said uproariously, pulling a third can from the fridge. When he turned, he popped the top for her, looking up around the high ceiling of the kitchen and all the antique armoires that had been converted to kitchen cabinetry. "This place is unbelievable," he said.

She nodded and took a sip of the beer. The house might be too big. Thirteen thousand square feet gave them all plenty of places to go off and hide from each other. She said, "Can we play a game?"

Max sat next to her on a high stool and pulled his plate of pizza over. He didn't look like he would eat. He said, "Like what?"

She said, "Maybe something like truth or dare."

Cole sipped his beer, said, "Uh-oh."

"Only: No dares, just truths."

Cole said, "Confessionals."

She said, "Liars will be asked to leave the warmth of the house and our company, out into the cold world of lying liars."

Max grunted. "That leaves you pretty safe."

"Why?" she asked.

He picked a pepperoni off a slice and ate it. "Cole and I don't want to be alone in here with each other. You can lie all you want and we won't ask you to leave."

She watched him for a moment, with his face turned down to the food he wouldn't eat. She said, "I *am* a liar. But I don't want to be. I care too much about both of you to lie, even when I'm lying sometimes, sometimes even to myself—doing it just to preserve someone's feelings."

Max said, "Oh, where's this going?" making his hurt face.

She said, "What ...?"

"I don't like where this is going."

She stared at him until he finally raised his eyes to hers and then she held his gaze. "I *really* love you, Max."

It got his attention. He said, "I ... I love you, too."

"Let's tell each other the truth," she said.

Cole said, "I'm ready," and he put his hand on her knee. She covered his hand with hers.

Max said, "I'm ready too. I can tell the truth."

BACK IN THE living room that looked out over the mountains if there weren't sheets of driving snow, Max moved to take a spot on the couch and she stopped him.

"Not on the couch, Max."

"No?" he said, as he looked to Cole paused before the leather chair angled toward the fire.

She said, "No furniture."

Cole said, "No furniture? What?—sit on the floor?"

“No shields, nothing to sink into, hide, no pillows to cover yourself.”

“Right,” he laughed. “Why would we want to be comfortable?”

She got her face serious for a moment. “We’re going to be uncomfortable.” Both her boys grew solemn.

To brighten them now, she said, “In fact,” and grabbing the hem of her sweater, she pulled it up over her head and tossed it to the spot where Max had intended to sit. With a smile, she presented herself to them, arms bare, in a tank top, only that and her leggings, feet still bare as well.

Cole was the first to smile, saying slyly, “If we’re going to bare ourselves, you want to get naked?”

“No,” she laughed.

Max took off his own sweater, now just in his khakis and a button-down. He said, “So, what’s your game?”

From inside the sweatshirt he was removing, Cole said, “Truth or Dare? No dares?”

“Not like that,” she said, walking then to the center of a huge Native American rug where the pale wintry light fell from the towering windows but where they could all still feel the heat from the fire. She watched him come to her, Cole moving to stand right next to her, Max keeping his distance. Flat gray light from the window behind her fell on his face, showing dark circles of worry under his eyes.

“You okay?” she asked him.

“Nervous,” he said.

She went to him, hands extended, took his, felt them warm but tense, led him walking backward till the three of them were together at the rug’s center.

“No dare,” she said. Looking in his eyes. “Only truths.” Then stepping back and addressing them both: “Ask or offer.”

“What’s that?” Cole said.

“When it’s your turn, you can ask another, or offer your own truth. *Before* you’re asked.”

They both watched her apprehensively as she sat herself down, stretched her legs out ahead of her, held together, hands behind her on the rug. Cole and Max looked at one another, Cole nodding, then they both sat facing her, legs crossed.

Now she said, “It’s not a game. If you want to get competitive, you can always strive to be more honest, more forthcoming, than the rest of us.”

Cole still nodded, eyes narrowed, assessing what she told him. He looked to Max, then back to her. He chewed the inside of his cheek for a moment, then said, "What if this gets too real?"

Max's hands clutched together, one thumbnail scratching at the center of the other palm. His eyes however watched her resolutely.

"It could," she admitted. "We could start off easy."

Cole said, "What's easy?"

Max cleared his throat, and looking at her he said, "Uh ... when you went back to Rhode Island to stay, go and pick ... you know... your dress," he swallowed visibly, eyes lowering for a heartbeat, then raising to meet hers again. "You didn't *really* have sex with that guy on the train, did you?"

She laughed loud, then covered her mouth.

Cole's face went serious again. "What? ..." he said, frowning.

To Max, she said, "No. Not even close."

Cole said, "Who's the guy on the train?"

"I teased Max. He just told me I could do whatever I wanted ... be *bad*," she said now, frowning a little, "and I... tricked him. Took a picture of this guy, sent it to Max, told him ... Oh, boy, told him all these dirty things we did."

Cole laughed, seeing the humor in it, but Max's face showed hurt and she didn't want that. She began to offer her own truth. "But the embarrassing thing is ..." She stopped as a sudden surge of shame flushed her cheeks.

"What?" Max asked.

"Nothing," she said. Then considering her own game she continued, "I may have ... you know ... thought about him ... you know ..." She sheepishly rolled her eyes to the ceiling.

Cole said, "Get out of here ..."

She shrugged, forced a smile that squeezed out awkwardly. With both of them staring at her she shivered, buried her face in her palms and burst out in nervous giggling.

Cole's hand held her wrist and uncovered her face. He smiled at her, brows pinched, said, "You are *so* dirty."

She yanked her wrist back, slapped at his arm playfully, but missed as he laughed and sat upright. To Max, he said, "Who is this guy? You saw his picture? Do we have to worry?"

Max smiled a little, said, "He was pretty hot."

Maggie agreed, laughing, “So fucking hot.”

“I *hate* this guy,” Cole said, smirking at her, but she saw the concern in his eyes.

She said, “I don’t even know who he is. He didn’t get on the same train. I saw him on the platform. Max and I had just been ... *intimate*, and he left me all charged up.”

Cole looked to Max and said, “Dude,” acting like Max had let her down.

She said, “No, it was good. Time constraint. We were late—sex made us late, and I almost missed the bus.”

Max smiled more, eyes narrowing as he recalled the day. Then joining in the fun he frowned at a sudden realization and teased her: “Wait, did you actually *masturbate* on the train?”

She winced and nodded.

Cole chastised her: “*Maggie* ...”

“Wait, hey,” she corrected them. “I didn’t touch myself. I didn’t have to.”

Max asked: “You came?”

She nodded, giggled again, wriggled her feet, then with their eyes on her again she covered her face. She heard Cole sigh admiringly, “I wish *I* could do that.”

MAX POINTED TO MAGGIE, and she placed a palm on her chest and said, “Me?” He nodded.

“Okay,” she said, wagging her feet back and forth. “Um,” she smiled, thinking, then with held back laughter, she turned to Cole and after clearing her throat, she asked him: “Is my mother really coming on to you?”

Max couldn’t help laughing. Then Cole answered, “Yes.”

Max said, “She is?”

Cole smiled and nodded, practically beaming.

Maggie had a follow-up: “Do you want to have sex with my mother?”

Cole laughed now, said, “Maggie, your mom is *so* fucking hot.”

And while Cole laughed and Maggie shook her head in admonishment, Max said, “Wait,” and when they both looked to him, he said to Cole, “Did

you ... *already* have sex with her mother?"

Both Maggie and Cole laughed now, and it rushed sharp crystals of pleasure through his heart to see them happy like that. Cole couldn't answer but he sliced both hands back and forth like an umpire declaring a runner safe, alleviating Maggie's potential concern while he found the breath through his laughter to answer. Max laughed so hard as well the vision of them narrowed and warbled.

Finally, Cole managed to say, "No, no, no way ...". He cleared his throat and straightened. When they all collected themselves, he continued, "But that weekend I went to your house, I thought it could happen."

Maggie said, "What about my father?"

Cole said, "I didn't *do* it."

She said, "You would have?"

Cole rolled his eyes to the ceiling. "I hate this fucking truth game."

Max said, "He *might* have," trying to ameliorate for his friend.

Maggie said, "Let him speak," her eyes still on Cole.

"I might have," Cole said.

"Wow," Maggie said.

Cole got serious and said, "The secret to a truth game—amongst friends—is not judging the answers given."

She looked at him blankly, slowly a nodding began, and she held out a hand. "You're right. I'm sorry, you're right."

Cole took her hand and squeezed it.

Maggie said, "I'm a little ... I'm a little sensitive with my mother right now."

Cole said, "Nothing should be off limits, Maggie, and, really, *you* asked *me*."

"Ah shit," she sighed, "I know. I know I did."

Max said, "What's up with your mother?"

She held Cole's hand in both hers now, said, "I already told Cole—"

"Told him what?" Max said.

Looking to him, she said, "I talked to Ken. He took or erased the security footage of us."

Cole nodded as she spoke. Max assumed she'd related this story to him on the drive up north. It wasn't true though, and now his stomach clenched further with the dread that came with telling the truth.

Maggie said, “But I think my mother saw the footage. I’m almost sure of it.”

“How?” Cole asked.

“A ... *feeling*. Knowing her so long. The things she’s saying are like ... like she *knows* ...”

Cole said, “What is she saying?”

Maggie’s eyes went to Max’s, and he felt suddenly caught, pulled in by them somehow, like he was meant to, Maggie purposely drawing him in to her with comfort but sadness as well. The strength left him, leaking out his butt and into the assuredly expensive rug. But he braced himself.

He said, “Hey, Cole?—maybe I could go ahead of you, take the next turn ...”

Cole said, “Max, I’d pay you to take my turn. Just don’t ask me anything.”

“No ask—I have an offer,” he said, and they both looked to him. His gaze went up to avoid them and he saw perched on the end cut of a log—peering down at them with a black quizzical eye, talons curled over honey-stained wood—the black ruffled shape of a gleaming taxidermist raven. “Wow,” he said, and they glanced up to follow where he looked.

“What?” Maggie said.

“Secret Society,” Cole said.

“Secret Society,” Max agreed, and began: “The weekend I went home to see my parents, I didn’t actually go home.”

“I know you didn’t,” Maggie said, compassionate face watching him expectantly.

Max said, “I know you know.” Max’s parents asking him when he returned from Connor’s why Maggie thought he came home that previous weekend.

Cole looked back-and-forth between them, puzzled. “Where did you go?”

Maggie said, “Did you stay in Vermont? On campus?” Cole frowning at this, being the one to drive him all the way to Albany before 5 A.M.

“I went to San Diego. To see Ken.”

“San Diego?” she said, her voice a disbelieving gasp.

Max nodded.

“Why?”

“To get ... to get the security footage from him.”

Maggie and Cole's faces scrunched in incomprehension; they shook their heads, mouths working to form the phrase *What the fuck are you talking about, Max?*

"I thought if I could get a copy ... if I could ... if ..." Then unable to address Maggie, he said to Cole, "if I could get her to *see* what it looked like ... she wouldn't like it, she—"

Cole said, "Why wouldn't she like it?"

"Because she knew her brother saw it, saw what it looked like. She can be so shy ... I thought it would shake her out of it."

Maggie said, "Out of what?"

Cole said, "That's stupid. This little horn dog would probably like it," he laughed, taking her hand and swinging it between them, his smile fading seeing Maggie's seriousness.

She repeated: "Out of what?"

Looking her in the eye, he said, "Quitting with Cole."

They all looked at one another for a moment, and Maggie sighed, "*Really?*" A whine laced through her tone, tension gripping her at the thought of quitting Cole.

And that was his proof. Had he asked her to, she might have quit Cole, but only for a time until the resentment poisoned her opinion of Max. As convoluted as his plan was, his motivation was sound.

Cole, still squeezing Maggie's hand, said, "You wanted us to quit?"

He didn't answer, but the reddening heat felt up his cheeks and neck should have done it for him.

"Ken—he didn't give it to you?" Maggie's face was held so tensely her lower lip trembled.

"Maggie, he didn't have it."

"He just got rid of them?"

"Did he tell you he did?"

"Yes."

"I asked him if he could tell you, let you know he saw us."

"Why?" she whined.

"Same reason."

"But what did you tell him? Why did he agree?"

"I told him you were in trouble."

She made like she would stand, her expression of puzzlement grinding into a form of anger. "You lied?—or you really think I'm in trouble?"

“I don’t know.”

“Max?” she said again, trying to capture his focus, and when he faltered again, not knowing what to say, she did rise to stand, turned her back and faced the mountains. Cole glanced at Max, then stood and joined her, putting his arm around her back. Max drew up his knees, arms hugging them and watched. Beyond the window, the daylight seeped from the sky and mountains, and between the capricious sheets of snow, the landscape seemed stark and colorless now. It would be dark soon.

He continued, speaking to their backs: “I hoped it was that you were in trouble. Hoped you hadn’t fallen out of love with me.”

When she turned, she was forlorn. “That’s not right, Max. I told you every day I love you. I said it because I mean it. That’s my truth. I absolutely know I do.” She held a fist over her heart and there was a flash of reflected light off a teardrop that dripped from her jaw. “That’s a one-hundred percent truth.”

Now he covered his own face with his hands. Through them, he said, “I felt pushed away. Less than ...”

“Why wouldn’t you talk to me?”

Hands away, wiping wet on his pants, he said, “It wouldn’t change your mind, your action ... It wouldn’t stop you sleeping with Cole.”

She didn’t disagree, standing there silently watching him, Cole at her side, running his hand over her back.

“Would you please come back and sit down?” he pleaded.

She stood a moment longer, nodding the whole time, knowing she should, knowing she would. When she returned, getting to her knees in front of him, he sighed with relief.

Then she came to him, walking on her knees, face twisting like she might cry, and she put her arms around his neck and squeezed him.

“I’m sorry, okay? I’m sorry I made you feel that way, Max.”

His hands came up her sides, her narrow rib cage under his fingers, and he breathed her in. “There’s more,” he whispered.

She sat on her heels and nervously waited, Cole watching, kneeling behind her.

“Maggie, Ken didn’t erase the security cameras. He didn’t even know they existed.”

She slumped, cocking her head, her face bending upward in sad incomprehension. “What?”

“I think ... I think he just told you that because I asked him to.”

“Oh no, I knew it,” she sighed, eyes wide and staring at the colorful section of rug between them. When their eyes met again, she said, “Ken said... said you’re a liar. Good, but a liar. Told me to tell you to tell me the truth.”

“That was it. That’s what he wanted me to say.”

Rolling off her heels, she sat on her rump again, running her hands over her hair, lost in thought. “She *knows*. My mother *knows*. She’s the one who erased it.”

Cole said, “Why would she do that?”

Eyes lost in the fire behind Max, she said, “To control me. Hid it from my father because he would kill me, take me out of school, away from both of you. But she ... she’s using it to get what she wants.”

“That’s crazy,” Cole said, disbelievingly.

Max asked, “What does she want?”

“Get out of art. Go to law school.”

“No way,” Cole said, shaking his head. “There’s no way.”

Maggie said, “But I want to go to law school.” Then more speculatively, “I *want* to go to law school, don’t I? That’s me, that’s not her ...”

Seeing her wild and lost eyes as she clapped her hand over her forehead, bewildered between unreality and authenticity, slumping with overloaded burden, it occurred to him that all of them, not just Carol, sought to control Maggie from outside the perimeter of her knowledge, make her a marionette ignorant of its strings. What he wanted to do right now is genuflect, fall before her and declare unending apology and recompense, but when she emerged from her fugue she looked at him, slack-jawed and aching.

“What? ...” he asked her, worried over her expression.

“Max, I’m so sorry ... Maxy, she ... my mother ... they...” Her eyes brimmed with tears, one spilling over, following a leftover track and dripping from her jaw. “They canceled the wedding.”

Black Truths

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

THOSE WORDS TOOK EVERYTHING out from under Max. She held back her own sob and struggled to keep her composure—for his sake—but the color dropped from his face in a heartbeat, leaving him ghostly and colorless, his eyes black and uncomprehending. Seeing her love so wounded tore at her heart.

“I’m sorry, Max,” she said, the words coming out as an inaudible whisper.

He shook his head, whispered, “No.”

“Maxy, I’m sorry ...”

“Wait, no ...” he said, the stunned and hollow look on his face opening now to sorrow.

“They did, Max.”

“Why?”

She struggled to answer. Tears bubbled in her lashes and Max seemed to retract in her vision, visibly shrink before her like he was condensing. He drew his knees to his chin protectively, hid his face from them, touching his forehead to his knees. Quiet sobs shook his shoulders.

The pain in her heart was physical, real, manifest. Her mouth fell open, and she squinted with an overwhelming sadness, and while her body shrieked for her to react, to go to him, it was Cole that got there first.

She watched as Cole walked to him on his knees and threw his arms around his good friend. Max fell into it, needing to feel someone hold him right now and both his hands gripped Cole’s upper arm, his fingers curling over the muscle. Cole held his friend as he cried but made no sound, his

hand coming up and fingers weaving through Max's hair. He softly said, "Dude, I'm so sorry, I am, I'm so sorry ... it never should have been like this ..."

"It was me," Max sobbed, "I did it, I did it ..."

"It's okay, buddy, it's okay ..." Cole soothed him. "We'll make it right ... we will ..."

"How? How will we make it right?"

"I don't know, Maxy, we just will ..."

Somehow she found her strength, got to her knees and joined them, slipping her arms around Max, underneath where Cole gripped him. She was face to face with Cole, both their eyes open and looking at one another, and while their gaze connected, trembling with pain, and the compassion they felt for their friend, she had an enormous urge to kiss him. His plump lips were set in a firm line in defense against the heart-wrenching moment, but she knew their softness, knew it and longed for them to be on hers. She shook her head in disbelief and he did as well.

"What did they say?" Max sighed.

"Maxy, Maxy," she cooed, looking in his eyes now, running a thumb over his cheekbone, feeling her tears spill over and trace the angle of her jaw. "I told you: she knows. My mother *knows* ..."

"But ..."

"When you didn't come for dinner last weekend, I said we would consider postponing ... because of school ... but she ... she saw there was no ring, and I'm telling you ... she *knows* ..."

"Why ... why did you go home without me?"

She set her face harder, still showed him compassion. "Why did you leave me? Why did you run away and leave me?"

Max sighed and thumped his forehead against his knees a few times. He groaned. He writhed away from both of them and they let him go so he could sit up straight again. With the heels of his hands he wiped at his cheeks and the hollows of his eyes. When he looked at them again, as if to speak, he hitched a breath and covered his face, rubbing at his brow with his fingertips.

Cole offered: "I'm sorry you saw us like that, Max. In the motel. We ... you knew we did that. Maggie said she was open with you ..."

Max sighed again, opened his mouth and flexed his jaw, his eyes turned up above and behind them, watching the raven that loomed from the log. "I

wasn't ... I wasn't running from the things you did ... I ran from the things I did."

Cole regarded him blankly, but Maggie knew what he meant. Now Max's eyes moved to look into hers. He said, "You know."

She nodded.

Cole said, "Know what?"

Max rolled his eyes. "You didn't tell him?"

"No."

Max lowered his gaze and shook his head, his mouth twisting around.

She said, "Tell me. Tell me what you did."

He huffed with a laugh though she knew he didn't think it was funny. Looking to her again, he said, "I watched you with Jay."

Cole looked to her, but she kept her eyes on Max.

Max said, "I watched you draw Jay. I hid in your closet and I watched you tie him up with pink tights."

"Which time?" she whispered, feeling her throat and face go hot, a tremor gripping the tendons of her neck and making her vision shake.

"I saw the drawings you did of him. You wore his fucking shirt. Right in front of me. I got in the closet to see if what I thought was true. He got hard, and you untied him. He jerked off in front of you and you held his ... you held his balls while he ejaculated." Max's cheeks had taken on fiery roses as well, his eyes glistening with wet anger. "You *cheated* on me." His voice was fierce but still somehow quiet and restrained.

In her periphery she saw Cole's eyebrows raise high. Shame washed over her and she gripped her knees so hard her fingernails dug painfully into her flesh. "Oh. Okay," she gasped. "I did. Yes." Teardrops blinked off her lashes, and she watched them absorb into her black tights in dark expanding circles. Cole gripped her arm but said nothing. She looked to him, saw the disbelief, then to Max, saw his pain. "Max, I'm sorry. I really am."

Max just stared into her eyes and kept his mouth closed. She felt agonal waves radiating from him, heard his breaths loud and slow and controlled. Without saying anything she pleaded for forgiveness with her eyes.

Cole cleared his throat, said, "You ... you thought you could keep her if you let her ..."

Max shook his head no. "Partly," he said weakly.

She said, "You liked it. You liked what you saw."

Max nodded and Cole frowned.

It was true. Max had fucked her in the alley next to Altieri's then sold her on the idea of being with Jay. This was *after* what he'd seen. And he'd seen the worst of it. Saw her at her lifelong lowest: holding a stranger's balls while he masturbated for her. When Max arrived that day, she'd worn Jay's T-shirt, and he knew what it meant. That must have been devastating. Yet, her Max stuck with her, found a golden thread in her tangled woolen mess and plucked it, but now they'd come unraveled. It had all been doomed from the moment she'd donned another man's shirt and hosted him in her dorm room. *She'd* ruined them. "Oh God," she choked and curled forward.

Someone's hand, Cole's she thought, rubbed her back.

Cole said, "I ... I showed Max your video ... where I asked you to state for inculpability that you weren't really cheating ... to convince him to let me ... be alone with you."

She said, "I knew that."

Cole said, "Max doesn't know ... you *weren't* serious."

Max raised his reddened eyes to look at Cole.

She whispered, "No."

Cole said to Max: "She was joking. Maybe I thought she was, deep down, curious, but ... I cut out the part that made it obvious she was playing along with me."

Max's haggard face didn't change, his lips pursed and pouted, swollen almost, the seam woven in an archer's bow. His shoulders went up and down once.

Maggie smiled for him though it was thin and wan. She said, "I think I mixed up feeding your badness with getting my own selfish pleasure, telling myself it was ultimately for you ... I let it get convoluted because it suited me."

Cole said to her: "Why did you cheat on him, Maggie?"

Max looked to the side of Cole's face, then to her. She looked away.

"I was afraid, curious. *Bad*."

"You're not bad, though," Cole said.

Max said, "She didn't want to. But in the end she did."

With both of them staring at her, she covered her face with her hands before she burst into flames. The skin of her back felt hot and wet, the tops of her ears burned. "I *didn't* want to."

Peeking through her fingers she saw Max still staring. He said, "You masturbated when he left."

Cole flinched and groaned, sensing the angst that would deliver, maybe even affected himself.

Her mouth hung open, and she moaned. She pinched her nose and held it.

Max said, "I'm sorry I hid and watched. I'm sorry I saw those private things but ... I knew ..."

"I'm sorry, Max," she said.

He said, "I just didn't want to lose you. I told myself what you did was okay ... and I ... I know, I somehow *liked* it, too ..."

Cole clapped him on the shoulder, gripped him hard enough his thumb dug into Max's chest. Max put his hand over Cole's but couldn't look at him.

Maggie whispered, "It was good. What we did was good. I'm not sorry I liked it. I'm not sorry you liked it."

Max raised his face to look at her. "I liked it too. I never felt closer to you." Cole shook him lightly, rubbed his thumb into Max's chest and he pat Cole's hand. He said, "Whose turn is it?"

Maggie said, "Do you still love me?"

Max hung his head and flashed her a funny smile. "Maggie, come on. I love you so much."

"I wasn't sure," she whispered.

Cole let him go and returned to sit, his eyes on her. She began to shake, knowing what would come next.

Max said, "The question is: Do you still love me?"

She nodded rapidly, earnestly, tears returning. "I love you so much, Max. More. More than ever."

It was what he needed to hear, but she didn't go to him. Not yet. She knew he wanted to know more. She waited, face scrunching up as she waited for him to build the courage.

He said, "Do you ... do you love Cole?"

She nodded, held his gaze. Said the words. "I do. I love Cole."

Cole covered his mouth with a hand in her periphery.

Max looked on the verge of tears. He quietly said, "How long?"

She said, "When Jay had me in my room, and I thought ... I swear he was going to hurt me ..." she whispered, "maybe *worse* ..." then

continuing, “I ... I was afraid, no *sad*, horribly *sad* that I’d never see Cole again.”

Cole let out a low gasp next to her, coming to her and pulling her into his arms, her cheek pressing his chest and his hand cupping her head. She hugged him back.

Max watched, horrified.

She said, “But Max, I love you too, just as much as Cole ...”

He scoffed, hung his head as he rose to stand.

He said, “You love me ... as *much* as Cole?” His features fell slack with desolation.

She pushed herself from Cole’s clutch, standing as well, but Max stepped back.

She said, “I love Cole as much as you. Just as much, Max.”

“You were mine,” he whispered, and he took another step backward.

She pleaded, “Max, you’re not hearing me ... I love you more than ever ...”

With tenting, sorrowful brow, he said, “You were *mine*, Maggie ...”

“I’m still yours, Max. I am.”

Cole stood now as well, mouth working, looking for something to say. At her side, he paused, then looking from her to Max, he stepped forward. Max didn’t retreat, looking to Cole, bewildered. He said, “You got between us. You tried to take her from me.”

Cole said, “I did. I was wrong. I did do that. I love her, Max.”

“You’re taking her from me,” Max said, raising his eyes to meet Cole’s.

“Max, it’s okay. We can figure it out ... we—”

“You keep saying that ... what are we figuring out? What’s there to figure? It’s over ...”

“No, Max, it’s not,” Cole said.

Maggie said, “Max, it’s not over, don’t say it’s ... don’t ...”

As he turned to walk away, Cole gripped his arm. “Don’t, Max. If we all love each other, what can go wrong?”

“It already went wrong,” Max said, snatching his arm from Cole and turning.

She said, “Where are you going, Max?”

“I gotta ... I gotta get out of here ...” Max stumbled to the log arch that passed between the living area and the corridor that opened to the kitchen

and dining room, waving over his shoulder as if he were gravely wounded, his posture hunched.

Cole said, "Max ... we're all equal, Max ..."

"I love you both, Max," she tried, but he didn't stop, didn't turn, instead passing through to the front hall with her and Cole following. "Max, I understand, I do. But please, don't go. Max, look at me, we have a future."

Behind her, Cole stood, and she wondered what his face registered. She hadn't discussed any of this with him, but could see that Max saw himself losing and Cole winning. But she didn't think it was like that.

She pleaded with him, even clasping her hands together in front of her. It didn't stop him, Max going now and resting his hand on one of the curved metal shapes of a moose antler that formed the railing winding up the stone steps to the second floor. He paused a moment, his back still to them, not looking their way. She knew what he was going to do, standing there with his legs apart, between them the boots he pulled off when he arrived. Sure enough, he slipped one foot in and then another, stomping until his heels settled.

"Max," she said, steadily but quietly. "You can't go. We have a future. All of us do. All of us liked what we did. If we can just be honest ..."

Now he did turn, his gaze low, then tracing from her knees up to her eyes. He nodded, but his expression showed no acceptance. He plucked his jacket from the newel post and thrust his arms into it.

Cole said, "Max, I don't think you should go. I think you should stay."

Max stood for a moment, his eyes lowered on her chest, not seeing; that well-educated brain of his trying to form all the complex shapes of their past and the present, assemble some sort of structure that he could rely on in the future. His hand fumbled in his pocket and she heard keys jingling.

"Please," she said once more.

He shook his head, not angrily, just as if to clear its tangled mess within and then he moved to the front door, waving idly at them again, saying, "I need to get out. I just need to breathe."

She tried once more: "Max, I'm begging you to stay."

It stopped him, but just for a moment. Still with his back to them, he opened the door and the cold rolled into the foyer in tumbling balloons of frost. She hugged herself, took a step forward.

Max said, "I know. I hear you," his voice whipping over his shoulder on the breeze. He stepped outside, left the door open and she went to stand in

the gap. Cole came behind her, his hand on her shoulder. Together they watched Max as he made his way down the steps, pulling up the collar of his jacket. He rounded behind the vehicle that she called ahead and rented for him, wanting it ready at the airport, wanting so desperately for him to join her up here in the mountains. He opened the door and got into the car without looking up at them.

“*Why* would he leave?” she said to Cole, her voice pinched with the wind.

“He’s hurting,” is all Cole said, his voice low and unsteady.

Above the car, the iron chandelier rocked with the wind.

KEY IN HAND, he slowly and steadily, but without looking, lowered it to the ignition and nosed it to the slit, pausing, frozen in thought once more. Maggie fell in love with Cole. The worst thing imaginable, but now it all seemed so *inevitable*. How had anything else been expected? He’d allowed her Cole. Allowed their union even though deep down he knew this would happen.

Inside, he was surprisingly empty. A pervasive numbness, a vague tingling, and yet what was curiously absent was the deep sharp emotional pain he would’ve expected.

He inserted the key, feeling the click of its teeth, metal against metal. With a quick turn, the rental came to life, dashboard lighting, chimes pinging. On his right, his gaze tracked up the stone steps from where he’d just come down. In that open ten-foot tall maw, standing clutched together, his best friend and the woman he was supposed to marry. His two best friends. He’d never been closer to anyone than he was with Maggie. Seeing them together, so close, looking like a couple, twisted at him, constrained his insides, but their compassion, their love for him was clear. Unarguable.

In gear, he let the Rogue roll forward, and once past the edge of the log-leg canopy, his windshield scratching under a driving sheet of cold dry snow, he wound the vehicle around, making a loop, coming back from the eye of the driveway to meet the needle that would lead him to the road out of to Schroon. On the left, vaguely evident through the white squall, he saw

an offshoot from the drive that curled to the north side of the house, descending between low evergreens.

If he continued straight, he would come to the lake road that would take him to the hamlet, and from the hamlet to the highway, the highway to Vermont. He could get away from all of it; flee the impossible scattered mess of sharp tines all three of them found themselves in, casting their hearts and lust and desires out in a careless, dishonest, selfish game of emotional pickup sticks. In his back pocket he had his wallet, there was nothing in his overnight bag he needed, he wore his jacket; he had the vehicle; he had his keys, he could leave them ... go back to school, get serious, get on with his life. Leave them both behind.

The wind shifted, and the car went solitary, lost in its own driving white storm. He squeezed the wheel, gripped it, rolling his fists in semicircles. He sat like that until heat blasted from the warmed-up vents. Decision made, he let off the brake, and the vehicle rolled forward.

Down between protective spruce the wind abated, and ahead he saw a log garage, three bays across, a second floor above with two dormer windows watching down on him. He bit his lip, second-guessing his second-guesses. How would he open the garage door? ...

It opened on its own.

The heavy dark gray wooden door shook, jostling the silty snow that had collected on its frame, rattling and retracting, slowly rolling up inside. He imagined Maggie and Cole watching him from the warmth of the house, waiting for his decision, following him along, and opening the door from inside. The Rogue rolled in, coming to a stop nose-to-nose with the single headlight eyes of four gleaming Arctic Cats, and on the right, the tall tires of Cole's lifted Jeep.

He sat for a moment, still debating, and still squeezing on that spongy steering wheel. It would be easy to put the car back in reverse, three-point turn his way around and down that driveway, get himself back to Vermont.

Inside the house, his friends had decided for him. Another rattle, the mechanical gears groaning above as the garage door lowered behind him, sealing him inside.

With a sigh and another click of the key, he let the Rogue's motor come to rest. Then he was out, slamming the door, leaning his elbows on the SUV's roof. Ahead, he saw Cole's Jeep, imagined the two of them coming up here today alone, without him. Maggie and Cole, having fun, laughing

and joking, road-tripping. If he wasn't with them, he was profoundly alone and that was not a place he ever wanted to be.

Out the back door of the garage, he inhaled deeply and let it all out, slowly and completely; his submission, his acceptance. Pulled his collar up around his neck again, burrowed himself inside the jacket that was too light for these elements, hunched forward and made his way up the snowy path that wound its way to the back door of the house.

On the step, his chin rose, looking for the door, blinking his eyes to the flickering snow that attacked them. The door was open, Maggie stood there, Cole behind her. They waved him in.

Slate

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

WHEN HE WAS IN, she closed the door behind him. All three of them were together now at the back door of the house, under a low log-raised stone ceiling. Beyond them, in the adjoining room, under a timber archway, light shone from behind the green shade of lamps suspended over a hulking pool table. They all looked at one another without saying anything.

He said, "We can be honest."

Maggie stepped into his space, her bare feet coming to touch his boots. He opened his legs wider, and she worked even closer. She put her arms around him, her eyes looking into his. She said, "Max, nobody in my life has ever meant more to me than you do. I couldn't bear for you not to be with me. I couldn't bear for you to be hurt ..."

He sighed a deep inhale and held it.

She bit her lip and waited.

"But no one ... No one makes love to you like Cole ..."

She didn't answer, letting that plump lower lip her teeth pinched plop free. Her eyes darted over his.

He continued, "And that's something you couldn't give up either."

Cole shifted behind her uneasily.

Maggie said, "You like to watch."

He retracted, a slight grimace on his face. This was what he was reduced to. "I'm your best friend and I get to watch you with another man?"

"I want you, too," she said. "And I don't want to give you up."

Cole said, "How can you have it all?"

Her face fell as though she was hurt. She said, “Don’t you want to give me it all?”

She’d half-turned to say that, and Max wouldn’t let her go. His hand went to her waist, swooping around to feel the small of her back. He pulled her to face him again.

Both her hands came up and parted his collar, pushing the points away from his cheeks. She ran her thumbs along his jaw. He licked his lips, watching her eyes and watching her mouth. Her lips parted as well. He kissed her then, breathing her in as he did and Maggie gripped his face. The flood of warmth rose up within him, a heavenly alluvion. His feet rose from the floor and his head touched the ceiling. Both hands circled her waist, ran over her, felt her. Her tongue pushed into his mouth and his own met it; they danced over one another. Both of them began to moan. Their breaths grew heavy and when he finally parted from her, his eyes locked on hers again, he said, “I love you.”

“I love you, too, Max. I’ve always loved you.”

He ran his hands up her sides touching her elbows, moving to hold her wrists. He lowered them then, wove his fingers through hers. “So what do we do?”

“We do what we were doing. But all of us do it with our eyes open. None of us lie to each other.”

“That’s all I ever wanted.”

“Then why did you make it so difficult?”

“I don’t know. Deep down I hated that I wanted it. And deep down I suppose I hated that you liked it, too.”

“You still twisted it all to make it happen.”

“I don’t want to lose you.”

“I’m sorry I did those things with Jay.”

They stared at each other for a while, and then Maggie stepped away from him, opening their circle, holding out one hand toward Cole.

Cole stepped in, bewildered yet eager. He said, “I’m in. I always cared about you.” Then looking to Max and saying, “Cared about you both.”

“I cared about you,” she said.

Cole said, “I didn’t let myself think about you, but now that I’m in I don’t ever want to stop. Are you okay with that, Max?”

It was the way it would have to be. And though he found himself again in this inevitable situation where he could facilitate Maggie’s lust or risk

losing her, somehow he thought if it was just the three of them and they were in it together, he could really do this. He steadied himself, looked cool. "I'm okay with it," he said boldly yet shakily.

A slow smile worked across Cole's face and he ran his tongue over his lower lip. He squeezed Maggie's hand, pulled her to him. Now he held her as Max had just done, her feet together between his, looking up into his eyes. His smile grew wider still.

"What?" she whispered.

"Nobody fucks you like I do?"

She thumped her forehead to his chest and Max knew she was smiling. She pulled her head back, she said, "*Nobody* could fuck me the way you do." They kissed.

SHE'D MISSED COLE TERRIBLY, and as ecstatic as she was to touch his lips again with her own, she was careful of her sweet Max who watched behind her. Lips were pressed to Cole's tentatively, but it allowed her to savor their soft feel, their plump strength. They went slow; they would build to passion soon, but for now they felt each other out, came to tune into one another's commitment, their arousal. Her arousal would grow, she could feel it already beginning to strain at her seams.

Nails dragged over his neck, through his hair; his hands circled her now, too, coming around to touch the small of her back. She unwound the bun behind his head, pulled his thick hair out of its tangles and let it touch his shoulders. He was so beautiful, so strong, and she worked her fingers through that hair to scratch at his scalp as her lips parted and she sucked on his tongue.

Their bodies pressed closer together, and she began to squirm in his grip, feeling his hands on her back, pushing her stomach to his hips, seeking proof of his arousal. Now her breath grew quicker, and Cole's did as well. His hands went up and down her back in alternating strokes, his fingers rubbing into her shoulder blades and down over the crest of her rump. Her stomach rolled against the rising hump between his legs.

"Is this okay?" she asked him, withdrawing from their kiss and looking in his eyes.

He nodded, his eyes narrowed.

“Are you sure?”

“I want this. I do,” he said, looking away from her now and over her shoulder. She turned to see Max watching them. She held her face still for a long moment, then knowing how she wanted things, she smiled. He blinked a few times, reluctantly, then he smiled too. She extended a hand to him and drew him to her with curling finger.

“I missed you both so much. More than I can even explain. I don’t want to be alone. And I don’t want to have only one of you.”

Cole whispered, “You can have us both.”

She looked to Max, and he nodded as well though his face was more solemn.

“Touch me,” she said to Max.

He took her cheek in his hand and she kissed the heel of his thumb while she watched his eyes. He stroked her skin, lowered his hand to hold her neck.

“Please, kiss me,” she said.

With her back to Cole, who now held her by her waist, she tilted her chin and watched the loving boy who won her heart in her first year away from home. That sweet cutie-pie at the Lamda party, with his unicorn T-shirt and charm. The one who did everything for her, supported her, made her feel loved ... The one who got down on one knee and proposed to her. The one she cheated on. The one who she’d hurt. She closed her eyes and accepted his kiss. Their lips worked over one another in familiar action, sucking, tasting, darting their tongues. They parted slowly, their eyes on one another and she said, “I want you to watch me. Will you watch me?”

“I will,” he said. “I want to watch you. Show me.” Now his eyes moved from hers up to Cole, his chin resting on the top of her head.

A smile took hold of her mouth, and she wiped at her cheeks with her fingers.

Max said, “What is it?”

“I really do love you,” she said.

“I know. I know you do,” he said and returned a small but warm smile.

She writhed her back against Cole’s chest, eager to show Max. Eager to be with Cole and for her Max to watch.

Now she turned, ready to commit, nails scratching at Cole’s neck to drag his kiss to hers. They locked lips more aggressively, breath chugging

through their nostrils. Her stomach pushed, wanting so badly to feel that hard thing. Found it, too, thick and pointed upright at an angle, trapped in his jeans. She slipped her hands down to his waist, ran them underneath his shirt, felt his warm skin soft, yet the hardness of his muscle underneath. It made her knees weak. "Oh fuck, you feel so good. I missed how you feel."

Cole's hands moved down and cupped the cheeks of her ass, lifted her, parted her, squeezed. She went on the tips of her toes, desperate to feel those fingers of his probe her creases, find her hot core.

"I want you so bad," she whispered.

"I missed you. I told you how bad I missed you," he whispered, hoarse urgency in his voice.

"It was torture," she said.

Toes pushing off the floor, Cole received her in the same instant, the two of them working as a team. She leapt to his waist, thrust her knees up and wrapped her ankles behind him. He supported her, his hands cupping her bottom, a gasp escaping her, feeling the tips of his fingers stroke her middle. Fingernails raking through his hair again, she consumed his kiss with her own. Breathing heavy, chest heaving in and out, she sucked his tongue.

Cole stumbled backward, turning, pulling from her kiss with a smack so he could watch where he walked. He carried her into the next room, ducking so she wouldn't hit her head on the low timber archway. With her hands caressing Cole's face, she watched Max following behind. She said, "Come with us. Watch us," her heart swelling seeing his sweet smile.

Then she was being set down, her rump coming down on a hard edge, looking to the side and seeing the green felt, thirteen colorful balls held in a polished beech triangle. Cole was eager, grabbing at her tank top and pulling it up over her head. She lifted her arms and helped him get the shirt off, tossing it toward Max.

Their mouths came together again as Cole's hands were in the center of her back, tugging at her bra to undo it. Snapped free, he traced the straps of her pink bra down her arms, and the heat of his body so close had her nipples clenched tight in seconds. Then she was laying back, Cole's kisses pushing her, pinning her until she felt the felt-covered slate behind her. He kissed her chest, kissed her ribs, coming up and suckling on a nipple. She stroked his hair. His hardness pressed between her thighs; could feel his

hips working his bulge to push it against her sex. She swiveled and bucked, hungry for his hardness.

As he kissed her neck, she rolled her eyes up, tracking, looking for her Max. Saw him, upside down to her on the opposite side of the table now, watching, smiling, leaning forward then and resting his elbows on the slate, his two hands clasped together in the attitude of prayer. She reached for them, hooked her fingers around his two hands together, and squeezed. He rubbed her fingers with his thumbs.

Chin darting down, she said to Cole, "I want you. I want you so bad. I need you inside me."

Max clasped his two hands around hers now and held her tight. He said to Cole, "Let's take her upstairs."

MAX WATCHED Maggie's pale slender arms crossed over the dark gray cotton of Cole's shirt. She was topless, wearing only black leggings, bare feet hooked around behind Cole's rump. They kissed as Cole mounted the steps, his arms around her, supporting her, hers around his back, Max walking three paces behind.

They ascended the steps from the lower level, coming from the billiards room, passing the humidor Cole told him about, up to the foyer, then the wide grand steps lined with metal moose antlers, curling around in a looping corkscrew to arrive at the bedrooms on the second floor. Max got ahead, pushing open heavy pine doors, looking for the master suite, finding it at the end of a wide hall; double doors set in a tall timber frame, and he pushed them open finding the peaked roof of the master bedroom with windows that looked out toward the mountains, somewhere beyond the white cataclysm that churned past the windows in the fading perse light. The bed lay at the base of the towering triangle of framework glass, an ornate monolith with four tall posts at the corners, neatly made with a crisp wool blanket in fur-trader stripes folded over the foot.

Cole and Maggie still kissed, their mouths making smacking noises against one another, soft moans and groans from each of their throats. Cole walked Maggie to the high king-size bed and dropped her rump down, leaning over top of her and putting his hands on the bedding. The zipper of

Cole's jeans drew down with a faint metallic tearing sound. Maggie's two hands working together between his legs, unbuttoned his pants then, searching and pulling out Cole's hardness. Cole grunted, inhaled sharply at her touch on him, arching his back and rearing up over top of her. Max saw how hard his friend was for Maggie, saw her slight hand stroking and touching, running her thumb over his exposed glans.

"It's been a while?" she whispered with a breathy chuckle, seeing the effect of her grip on him.

"Your hand feels so good."

"I love your cock," she said.

Then Cole was over top of her again, kissing at her neck while she stroked him, one hand going up and down the shaft, the other shoved inside his open pants and squeezing his balls.

Max came around to the other side of the bed, stood opposite them, putting a knee up. Maggie twisted underneath Cole until she lay flat on her bare belly, raised up on her elbows, her perky breasts pressed together between her arms while she smiled at Max. Cole kissed her bare skin, over her shoulder blades, down to the small of her back, his hands rubbing up her thighs and over her rump, fingers hooking under the waistband of her tight black yoga pants. Maggie wiggled her butt from side to side, teasing him, but showing her eagerness.

Maggie alternated smiling at him, then looking over her shoulder to see what Cole would do. They watched together as he stepped back, pulling her pants down, the tight fabric scrolling over the softness of her thighs, bringing them to her knees and pulling them inside out, tugging their tightness off her pointed feet. She turned and giggled for Max, narrowing her eyes sheepishly and showing a big smile of white teeth. Max got up on the bed with both knees, reached out and stroked her hair.

Then she was glancing over her shoulder again, down over her naked body, her knees bent, her pretty feet crossed over one another, and beyond her at her handsome stud, Cole pulling that dark T-shirt over his head and shaking his long hair out, his muscles showing starkly in the glare of the snowy light coming through the windows at the head of the bed. The end of his thick cock pointed up toward his bellybutton. He pushed his jeans down his hips, stepped out of them smiling grimly.

Maggie smiled with anticipation as Cole gripped her hips and brought her so she was on all fours. She swung her hair out of the way so Max could

see her face, making eye contact with him. Now she sucked her lips in her mouth swaying her butt back and forth as Cole gave his cock a few quick strokes. The delay had her frowning with frustration, looking over her shoulder and groaning.

She got down on her elbows, seeing him line that thick thing up. Cole ran the tip up and down her opening and Max could hear the eager wet sounds of his Maggie ready to receive him. With the tips of his fingers, Cole angled his hardness downward, nestling the huge foreskin-covered glans in her folds, then holding her waist he pushed himself slowly inside her. Maggie's toes curled, and she kicked her legs lightly.

Max stroked her hair again, and she raised her face to him, wincing with discomfort. She thrust a knuckle in her mouth and clamped her teeth on it while she snarled. Soft grunts came from her throat as Cole entered her completely, his pubic hair nestled in the concave swell of her bent rump. He asked her, "You good?" She let her knuckle go and bit her lower lip, nodding. Max nodded for Cole to continue.

She looked to Max and said, "It's been a while for me, too."

When she lowered her head, smiling, Max cupped her ears and kissed the crown of her sweet smelling hair. Cole withdrew and entered her again, did that over and over. Doing it slow, doing it steady, getting his girth coated with her excitement. Max continued to kiss at her hair, his hands rubbing over her back, on his knees over top of her.

As she grew more comfortable, Maggie began to groan; Max watched her begin to bounce against Cole's thrusts, eager to meet him. Then she was up, planting her hands on the mattress, head hanging down still, hair swaying. Max touched her shoulders, down her collar, two hands cupping her jiggling breasts. He caressed her like that for a good long while as Cole stood at the side of the bed, hands gripping her waist then smoothing over her rump, giving it to her from behind.

Maggie moaned and groaned, her head coming up, hair hanging down, her back beginning to heave with more excited breaths. Cupping her breasts like this brought a badness to mind. A further confession. Something that weighed on him, something light and weightless yet of enormous burden just the same. It was nothing to him, but it could be hard for Maggie to bear.

The hardness of her nipples pressed his palms and slowly his hands came up, gripping her shoulders and then he brought her to raise. Her hands grabbed at him, climbing his body, Cole helped her, getting closer to the

bed, hooking a forearm around her stomach to support her. Now Max was face-to-face with her, though her eyes were hazy and distant, Cole still thrusting, wet sounds still smacking from between her legs. She tried to caress him but her hands were clumsy.

He cupped her face, ran his thumbs over her beautiful cheeks. Her eyes fluttered, meeting his gaze, and she smiled. He struggled to speak, struggled to phrase what he wanted to say, wishing that he didn't have to, but knowing that if everything was going to work, it was required. His mouth hung open and Maggie mistook his intent, claspings his cheeks now and kissing him ardently. He took her lips, and she guided his hand down below. With hers over top of his, he felt her stomach, underneath Cole's forearm, feeling the bump-bump of that large knot as it thrust inside her. Then lowering, spreading his fingers into a V he felt her labia stretched.

He said, "Maggie ... There's more ..."

"More what? ..." she gasped, falling forward now, letting his hand go and hooking her arms around his neck.

"In Chicago. I was drinking. I made out with someone." He bit his lip and watched. She pushed away from him, back against Cole. Her eyes narrowed, caught between suffering and pleasure.

He said, "I'm sorry. Nothing really happened ..."

"You kissed someone?" she whined.

"I'm sorry," he said again.

"Who was she?" Maggie asked. Cole watched him though he didn't slow his stroke at all.

"Some girl. A friend of Connor's girlfriend. I swear nothing happened."

"You just kissed her?"

"I put my hand in her pants," he said.

She moaned and frowned and slapped his face very lightly and softly. He held her hand against his cheek. "Maggie, I'm so sorry. I didn't even want to ..."

"You didn't have sex with her?"

"No. I did ... I put a finger ..."

"No ..." she said.

"And she put her mouth ... on me."

"Max," she whined, her eyes opening now.

"Maggie, I swear—I swear it was nothing. I wasn't hard. I ... I just cried and then I showed her pictures of you."

Cole chuckled enough to shake, and Max's heart burst as he saw Maggie's face bowed with sudden good humor.

She cupped his cheeks again, said, "You showed her pictures of me?"

Max said, "I think she must hate me. I couldn't stop talking about how much I loved you. How amazing you were."

Cole laughed a little more, squeezed Maggie to him and Maggie groaned, "Oh Max, I love you, too." She touched his cheek.

"Is it okay?"

"It's okay. I slept with someone too while you were gone."

"What? ... You did?"

She nodded, her body being rocked by Cole's thrusting.

"Two guys," she said with a smile, and now he knew she was joking.

He asked, "Where did you meet them?"

She said, "Mm, at the pool. Swimming team. They had beautiful, muscular bodies. Totally shaved. I watched them all afternoon ..."

"You did?" he said, on the verge of breaking out laughing.

She nodded, said, "They both had huge bulges in their Speedos. They took me to their dorm ..." and now she was giggling. Cole thrust deep, and she gasped out.

Max asked, "They were shaved? Totally shaved?"

She moaned, said, "Totally hairless. So hot. I helped shave them," the last part breaking up as her back shook with laughter. Cole laughed too, looking to Max who shook his head. With an arm hooked around her now, Cole pulled her upright again, holding her against him like a hostage-taker.

Maggie said, "Their dicks were so long—" and Cole clamped a hand over her mouth. Maggie laughed snorts of air around his grip. They stopped moving, trying not to laugh. She hooked both hands around Cole's and pulled it away and she said, "Sorry, he doesn't like me to talk about other men."

Fur Trader

SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

IT WAS SO good to see him smile. So good to be naked with him, be seen by him, get bawdy with him. She missed him so much. That wonderful boy who she loved, her constant companion and best friend, and for a long time her confidant until the lies overtook them. But now it was all open, the book spread wide until its spine creased. They could read each other's pages. It hurt to think of her Max with someone else. She pushed it away. He was truthful. It meant nothing. He drank too much, and he was hurting and vulnerable. She'd done that to him. He was good and faithful. And she could picture him, drunkenly flipping through his phone and showing some poor girl her pictures. While Cole fucked her, she fumbled with the buttons of Max's shirt.

That was another thing she missed, and now she was getting it good. Cole's big perfect cock pushing out her insides, the hard shape of his glans stroking in and out of her—and bent like this on her knees, getting her in just the perfect places. If they could all keep their shit together, this could be a beautiful thing between them.

She pushed pearly discs through sewn slits, working out one then dropping to the next. Getting his shirt undone and then grabbing fistfuls of cotton, yanking his button-down and his T-shirt up, Max helping, grabbing them and pulling them over his head. She kissed his bared chest. His warm loving chest, his beautiful heart beating beneath. She sucked his nipple, grunted as Cole got a little deep. Then sucking on the other nipple, her hand pulling out the end of his belt from the buckle. Max's hands went over hers, taking over, undoing the button of his pants. She took the zipper and pulled

it down, could feel his hardness underneath. He jumped back off the bed; she watched him take his pants down, him smiling at her the whole while.

Cole gripped her again and pulled her upright, but she rolled away from him, collapsing and bouncing on the bed, bucking until her head reached the pillows. She looked from left to right, seeing her thoroughbred Cole with his muscle, his model's face, and his big cock. And her Max, her sweet and best friend, the most open and understanding guy in the world. One who accepted her darkness, offered up his own. And together now they would celebrate what they had wrought.

The two of them tumbled next to her, bouncing on the bed and shimmying until they joined her with their heads on the pillows. Her two best friends. They lay on either side of her, both smiling, and she held her hand up to cup each of their cheeks, running her nails over their handsome faces. Cole kissed her first, and she took it, Max's hand running a circle on her bare tummy. She turned and kissed him now too, taking his plump rosy lips and putting her tongue in his mouth. Cole rubbed her now as well, gripping one breast then the other, and she writhed between them. They snuggled closer, their hard cocks pressing into the outside of her hips. She hooked a foot over each of their thighs, opening herself to them.

Now she kissed Cole and both their hands worked lower, her two boys slipping fingers over her lusty sex. She moaned for them, let them know how much this meant to her. Max pushed his erection down, and she felt it pressing against her rump; she hooked her leg higher for him. She kissed him eagerly, wanted that connection to him when he entered her. He dipped his hips lower, his hand slipping over the cleft in her mound, his fingertips pointing his hardness where it needed to be. It slipped inside and she gasped into his mouth.

They made out while he put it in and out of her. Cole fingered around their connection, his middle finger coming up to press against her hardened button. Max withdrew, looking to Cole, and she turned to face him as well. She gasped and bit her lip, feeling his large size now pushing up inside her. She kissed him, biting down on his lower lip and looking in his eyes. He thrust in and out, pulling it out then and slapping it against her wet folds. Max slipped inside, got her gasping again, and she wriggled against him.

Right now it would be wonderful if there were cameras. She *hoped* there were cameras and Carol could get a good look at how well her daughter was loved. Hoped she appreciated the quality of her suitors.

Hoped Carol saw every bit of this. What would she think then? She'd got them both. How was that for winning?

Then Max withdrew and Cole was back inside her. The two of them working together to drive her crazy. Her heart drummed against her ribs, and their alternating intrusions came quicker and quicker.

Her head moved from side to side, kissing one then kissing the other. Soon it was like she couldn't catch her breath, no longer able to kiss, just trying to gulp air. Cole took it over again, putting his big thing inside her, going deep and holding. He took the backside of her knee, and brought her leg up higher, looking to Max who did the same, putting his warm hand behind her other knee and pulling it up to her shoulder.

With Cole still inside her, she felt Max probing, his narrow tip slipping along her crease, seeking her anus. She gripped her own knees now, wrapping her hands around them and craning her neck to watch between her legs ... Looking down then and seeing Cole wrap his masculine hand around Max's erection, Max looking to Cole. He brought the point of Max's hardness up, Maggie watched it press into Cole's scrotum, Max pushing his hips forward, his expression puzzled but following Cole's lead. The tip of Max's cock pressed the same opening where Cole parted her.

She gasped, flicked to face Cole. He smiled. She bit her lip, looking at him, neither of them saying anything. She nodded, returned to watch.

Max had it now, holding the end of his cock, his glans' pointed shape running along the ridges of Cole's much thicker shaft, finding a gully there and slipping along it, parting her, squeezing inside her tight space.

She had them both inside, Cole fully, and just the head of Max's cock. She let her knees go, curled her hands up to grip their necks, twisted so they could both get close enough to penetrate her. Max pressed further, Cole withdrawing a little, their two cocks rubbing belly to belly, making a wet sound as they forced her apart.

"Yes," she gasped, and nodded again. It hurt, it hurt terribly, but she wanted it *so* bad. Wanted to feel her two men inside her at the same time. Completely preposterous but she ached for it.

She grunted and complained, gasped in pain and dug her nails into their necks—but she nodded. Together they inched in deeper.

Max pressed, Cole withdrawing further, and now they were both inside her. Her two cocks slipping their undersides together, fitting like puzzle

pieces, finding themselves squashed together by her tightness. She cried out brightly; pain and joy.

And now the pleasure came, the high sharp tearing feeling that she swore would damage her lifting away, dissipating into thin air; lust and unabashed baseness taking hold, twisting at her heart, twisting her insides.

“S-stay there,” she stuttered, “stay, s-stay ...” She scratched at their necks, wriggled her hips against them, feeling stretched wider than was possible but loving it completely.

She looked from face-to-face; for sweet Max with pointed concern, his eyes darting over hers, measuring her pain, measuring her pleasure, always so thoughtful ... then to Cole her hungry and capable lover, his narrowed gaze piercing through her, knowing she liked it, knowing she’d asked for this. He was her knowing lover; Max encouraged her badness and Cole fed it. Her heart pounded, she thrust her head back into the pillows, grinding against them, running her hips in circles, anything but tilting forward where she would be hurt again. She thought of them all together, thought of them as one ...

THE SIGHT of his Maggie having an orgasm on two cocks was too much. She squealed, and she cried, writhing and gyrating between them, both of them hard as they could be and almost fully inside her. Her head thrashed in the pillow and he watched a tear slip from under the spidery line of one narrowed eye and run into the pillows. She gasped and sucked for air now. His neck ached from the gouging of her nails and he could see bright red lines on Cole.

The feel of his best friend’s cock pressed up against him, his beloved Maggie wrapped tight around both of them, was too much. The slightest slipperiest push against his cock as Maggie tilted her pelvis forward—sinking him a fraction deeper, Max’s glans crushed against Cole’s cock—set him off. His stomach bounced with terrible excitement. He sucked in his stomach, and his face formed a shocking drawn look—he inhaled deeply, seeking control of his body. It was too late; it was coming.

He ejaculated, sending swishing ropes up inside her and all over Cole’s manhood. Maggie, still in the throes of her own ecstasy felt it, cried out

with happiness. She made one of them come, and she always like to do that. Her nails scratched his neck but not Cole's.

She whined with happiness, "You came, you came, Max ..."

He bucked, the slightest movement short-circuiting his nervous system and sending his body into spasms. He grunted, "How do you ... *ah* ..." then getting his air, saying, "How'd you know it was me?"

Cole chuckled lightly, Maggie looked at him sweetly. "Of *course* it was you," she said, running her nails in circular stripes over his neck.

He kissed her shoulder. "It was me," he admitted, laughing and blowing a raspberry against her hot bosom. Now they all laughed, Maggie slapping at his cheek. He told them: "I'm still hard. Don't worry about me."

Cole said, "No one's worried about you."

Maggie agreed, "We've got all weekend."

He withdrew himself from her and she sighed, tilted her chin to the ceiling and winced.

He said to her, "You took two cocks at the same time."

She nodded with her eyes closed. "I *know*. How bad am I?"

Cole said, "You're the worst," and he took her chin, tilting her face toward him and kissing her lips.

Max lifted her shoulder and rotated her to face Cole, whose cock was still inside her, Maggie on her side now. He looked down at her perfect round bottom, smoothed his hands up and down, lifted her cheeks and parted them, inching down, pointing himself in her crease, intent to show her just how hard he still was.

Cole held her steady, still kissing her, and Max pushed himself up inside her anus. He didn't thrust, held himself in place, let Maggie take control and pull what pleasure she needed from him. Cole thrustured mildly, doing the same, letting Maggie reap what she wanted. Wet gushing sounds came from her sex, Maggie's thrusting against Cole squirting out what he'd put up inside her. He could feel it against his own thighs.

It wasn't long until they had her gasping again, running her nails and leaving red lines on the muscles of Cole's arm. She came again, his time holding her breath, her face in a twisted snarl while a long draggy croak emanated from her neck. Soon she was gasping, looking for breath, laughing and wiping at her face. She laughed softly, smoothing her hands in circles over Cole's shoulders, hiking a leg up his hip, his cock popping free from her with a slick wet sound.

She said to him, “I want you to come. It’s your turn. Come for me ...”

She reached behind her, pushing on Max with her elbow to give her some room, her eyes connected to Cole’s as she rolled to her back and he got between her legs, one hand on her hip, both her arms wrapped around his neck. Max watched Cole’s bare ass flex as he got the end of his cock in place, then Maggie made a joyous exhale as Cole entered her again. She hiked her knees up past his waist, locked her feet around the small of his back—and Cole began driving, looking to come. Looking to come inside her.

Max watched, and though Maggie had pushed him away, he felt no disquiet. Felt only happiness. He was in it. In it *with* them.

They made love eye-to-eye, working with each other, nodding and gasping, caressing each other’s faces and stroking nails through their hair. They writhed on the sheets, the force of their fucking shaking the bed underneath him. Cole’s breaths came quicker, and that had Maggie nodding in rapid affirmation. She said, “Yes, ah, *mm*, yes, come for me ... okay?—come inside me, I want to feel you come inside me.”

Cole nodded too, his face and chest blazing in hot-blooded red now, the veins and cords in his arms and neck standing out, a sweaty shine on both of them. Maggie’s arches flexed, her toes curled, she whined and frowned, so eager to feel him shoot his semen into her belly that the delay—the long buildup—was frustrating her.

Then Cole was roaring and stabbing; holding himself deep in her, bucking and withdrawing, thrusting deep again. Maggie exclaimed joyously, a hissing *Yes*, a moan, a cry, locking her ankles over his rump and digging her heels in, wanting to feel her lover as deep as he could get, wanting to feel his hot splashes up against her womb. Head writhing in sheets, she hummed with satisfaction now.

Cole stayed over top of her for a long moment, his back lurching with heavy breath. After a while, Maggie’s nails traced over the back of his neck and over his shoulders, bringing her stud back to life. Cole stirred and took a deep moaning satisfied breath.

“I needed that *so* bad,” she whispered to him.

“Fuck, so did I,” he whispered, lifting off her, his long tangled blonde hair hanging over his shoulders. Maggie released her heel-hold, lifting and opening her legs, and Max watched to see their biological union revealed. Cole’s thick cock slipped out of her, Maggie making a grunt as the glans

pulled free, leaving a long shining strand between them. Her sex glistened with their mutual excitement, Max's too, her labia puffed and stretched, reddened from their vigorous action. A white pearl swelled in her wet nest and slowly seeped from her.

“Max?”

It was Maggie's whisper, breaking his reverie, drawing his gaze from between her legs and up to her eyes. She said, “Come here.”

Her expression was warm and caring, a glimmering dot of white reflected under her lashes, her sweet pouting mouth showing a gentle smile. He climbed over to her, got his hands on either side and kissed her mouth. She took his aching cock in one hand and gave it a few strokes, her legs opened wide around him, her knees up in his armpits. That hand let his hardness go, soft skin sweeping up his belly and chest, coming to rest over his shoulders while they still worked their mouths over one another. Pressure began where she lay her grip. His Maggie urging him lower. He broke their kiss and looked in her eyes, saw her love and care. Hands on his neck, now she guided his kisses low, and he worked on her throat, then her collar. Plucked at her nipples, kissed down her ribs and belly, his tongue swirled through the cup of her navel while his arms stretched over his head and he cuddled her perfect breasts. He looked up her body.

Cole sat at her side, watching him, his hand stroking at her cheek. He wanted to taste her so badly, but he felt an unexpected rising shame. They both showed him their love in their expressions but he was frozen. His hands drifted down her body, touching her hips, coming low and opening her thighs.

“Please, Max,” she whispered. “I want it.”

He glanced to Cole who smiled. He kissed her warm belly just above her mound. Cole's hand cupped the back of his head, his thumb stroking at his scalp, urging his mouth lower. Maggie's hand then too, scratching over the side of his face and cupping his ear.

He heard her whisper, “Please, Max.”

He kissed low, cupping mouthfuls of flesh above her sex, kissing and suckling, lower and lower until he took in her hot and sopping coppery tasting flesh. He slipped his tongue up and down the lines of her folds, felt her sex-flesh full and pumped and abused, and so ready for his touch. Her thighs closed around his ears and a tremble could be felt inside her tummy and in the muscles of her legs. She whined as he worked her sex, tonguing

her slit, up and twirling over her hardened pink pearl, peeling its hooded cover and poking at its live wire surface.

She bucked at his work, her hips thrusting up off the bed and colliding to meet him. He got her writhing. Her sex was flooded. Her own wetness rising anew and the remnants of what they'd already conjured from her; she seeped semen. His own, and Cole's too, running almost freely from her aperture. His head was squeezed tighter, and she moaned and coughed above him, her two hands worked nails through his hair, tearing painfully at his scalp.

"Fuck, Max, oh, fuck, Maxy, *mm*, I'm going to come, don't stop, oh Maxy ..."

It drove him harder, despite the difficulty brought by his growing smile. He laughed and blurted against her sensitive flesh and it got her bucking again. Tongue then pushed inside her, the muscles of his lips pulling and tugging at her petals, she cried out, one brief loud shriek and he heard her hand slap to cover her own mouth, a sure sign that his Maggie was on the verge of losing control.

He twisted and worked her and her thighs clamped him so hard all he could hear was the furious thudding of his own heartbeat and the ocean whoosh in his eardrums. Then he was twisting, Maggie turning on her side with him still imbedded in her sex, him rolling with her, trying not to laugh, doing it anyway, blowing raspberries on her vagina. When she let the grip go with her thighs, he heard her gasping and laughing.

He sat up, wiping at his mouth and cheeks. Maggie lay on her side with her knees drawn up and her hands clutched between her legs like a man who just got kicked in the balls. She howled, only not from pain, but joyous breathy laughter, her eyes closed, burying her reddened face in the pillow. Her body writhed from the afterglow of the orgasm he just brought her. Cole laughed too, watching her and rubbing her shoulder.

He bounced himself higher up the bed, coming behind to spoon her but kissing on her upper back as she still shook with laughter. He bit the back of her arm and she yelped, rolling around and throwing the arm over his head to hold him against her. He took a nipple in his mouth and she kissed his forehead.

With a satisfied sigh, she said, "That was *so* fucking hot."

He reached up and kissed her lips and she put both arms around his neck.

Above their heads, out the tall window, snow swirled, the squall thickening, blocking out the dimming blue light, and they lay that way, talking and joking until the room grew black.

Claim

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 5TH

OUTSIDE THE WINDOW to the bathroom, the wind howled under the eaves. A sheet of metal rattled, beating out a tinny wobble as the wind pulled at where it was fastened, looking to tear it away. Cole parted the wooden louvres of the window shade, peering out into the night.

“Coming down sideways,” he said in a low disinterested tone.

They were safe in the house, safe together from just about anything the elements wanted to throw their way out here in the mountains. Safely sealed behind the massive hand hewn logs of this hulking lodge. Hot water roared from the down-turned copper faucet, filling the deep marble tub, steam rolling in hazy plumes.

She sat on the cold polished stone of the tub’s edge, naked and a little sore between her legs, but a blatant driving horniness that still thrummed a low, deadly idle, looking for a little juice on its pedal. Max rubbed her shoulders, sitting behind her, equally naked, and for maybe the first time in the last few months she felt he was at ease. Her hand stroked up and down the inside of his thigh. It moved absently, working behind her while she admired Cole’s bare ass as he watched out the window.

He was hunched over, his gaze lowered to measure the snowstorm’s ferocity, naked as they were and looking gorgeous. One hand scratched the other forearm idly, the muscles in his arm flexing, down his leg and calf too as his weight shifted. With a sigh, she leaned against her Max and his arms encircled her, his lips finding her neck and kissing. The soft steady sound of his contented breathing soothed her. Cole turned, ran his hair behind his

ears and smiled at them, crossing the dimly lit bathroom, his genitals swinging.

After the first time they'd made love, he'd gone downstairs and brought hot coals up in a metal bucket and she lay in bed and watched Max and him get a fire going in the bedroom's stone hearth. Seeing her two boys being good together, working in conciliatory humor, God, maybe becoming best friends again, pleasing her depthlessly.

She rolled her head around to Max and said, "What was that? I didn't hear you ..."

Max, having said nothing, paused the thumbs he circled over the knots of her back, saying, "I didn't—"

Now she lay back, pushing herself to seal against him, her temple resting against his cheek, interrupting, saying to Cole, "Max says he wants me to suck your dick."

Cole laughed, set himself down next to her on the tub's flat edge and rested a hand on her knee. "He does?"

Max shook her back with his quiet laughter.

She shrugged, and showed Cole an expression of '*whatever*,' and said, "I guess if he *wants* ..."

Cole lifted a knee and dipped a leg into the hot tub, straddling the edge, reaching behind him to pull the copper lever and ceasing the rush of water. The room was quiet now, and she sat upright, her two hands planted on the marble as she leaned toward Cole. His penis and balls rested on the stone, dark reddish brown against the ashen marble striped with swoops of gray. She wanted to suck it. Wanted it in her mouth. Wanted it while it was still soft. Wanted it hard, too, of course, but right now that driving horniness wanted his warm soft flesh to fill her mouth.

She asked Cole, "How's the water?" As she ran a hand up his thigh now.

He smirked, seeing her getting playful. "Hot."

Hands walking across the marble behind him, he leaned back, arching his back, the skin on his belly getting tighter and now she did see his abs. That beautiful big cock was presented to her like this, and he smiled with narrow eyes, knowing she wanted it.

She crossed her leg over to straddle the edge as well, letting one leg dip into the tub, finding the water scorching. Max followed suit, getting himself behind her, putting a foot in the tub then running his hands over her back.

“You want me to suck his dick?” she said over her shoulder toward Max but returning Cole’s narrow gaze with one of her own.

Arms around her, he squeezed her tummy, and cupped a breast. “Suck his dick, Maggie.”

With an arm reaching up, she ran her hand over Max’s cheek and whispered, “Okay, I’ll do it. I want ... I want him in my mouth while he’s big and soft.”

Cole said, “You better hurry.”

She could see his penis rolling inside its skin already, beginning to grow.

Max released her, and she eased forward, lowering her face between his legs, the effort and the angle mashing her stretched sex against the cold of the stone and feeling quite soothing. She moiled her hips against it, making her sex kiss the marble.

Now she ran a tongue up the topside of Cole’s penis, tucking a forefinger knuckle under the covered cock head and hoisting it up, wrapping her lips around it. It squirmed in her mouth, buckling, wanting to drop out and fall to the marble again, but she gripped it with the ring of her flexing lips, while her tongue traced over its shapes. Her thumb caressed over his testicles sitting on the stone, and it wasn’t long before the fun of having his big soft thing squishing in her mouth became replaced with the excitement of his growing turgidity. It thickened, it lengthened, and she wrapped her fingers around the base and her head bobbed up and down on him. He grew to full proportion, that flared cock head pressing out against the foreskin until her lips rolled it back, her tongue slathering the underside, feeling the cloven chin of his glans. Behind her, Max’s hands worked up and down her back.

She wanted Cole to come in her mouth and was on the verge of suggesting she would slip into the water where the angle would be more comfortable for her neck when something hard poked her from behind. She tucked her chin down, looked between her legs, felt Max’s hardness running over her labia then saw the head of his cock poke through, bringing the squishing folds of her sex, then dragging them back. The feel of his hardness stroking against her but not poking up inside where she felt a little tender right now was exciting, and the sight of his cock head blipping in and out between her legs and the feel of Cole’s big penis in her hand had

her heart racing again. This was what she craved, this was what she wanted. She could have it all.

Max gripped her waist tight, pressing his body against her, the inside of his thighs closing against the inside of hers. While one of her hands gripped Cole's thickness to steady his angle to the thrusting of her mouth, the other hand slipped between her legs, alternating touching at her own clit, then stroking over the top of Max's cock head every time it thrust through.

The point of Max's chin dug into her upper back as the pleasure he took from this collapsed him over her. He dug his thing through and held it, and now she tickled the tip with feathery stroking from thumb and forefinger. Cole leaned farther back, his cock pointing straight at the wood strip ceiling, drawing her closer, and she rose, lifting off Max and raising up to stand over top of him, her mouth still bobbing, her hand stroking, her other one now coming up to play with his bouncing balls. Max stood as well, she could see his bare foot on the bathmat next to hers, his hands running over her body, his hard cock poking between her thighs.

Max pulled her hair aside, moving to the left so he could watch her and she angled her shoulders so he could see. Eyes closed, Cole leaking semen now, she bobbed faster, sucking so hard her cheeks went hollow.

Max said, "That's it, Maggie, suck it ..."

It delivered a dirty punch to her belly, and she flexed her thighs, frowned and pinched her brow. The idea he watched and loved it was intensely arousing.

She nodded, and hummed, *uh-huh*, for Max, and then Cole was thrusting his cock against the inside of her cheek, that huge glans pushing it out. Hot jets of his cum squittered into her mouth with great force, splashing and roiling and filling her maw to overflowing. Cole's legs kicked and shook underneath her and he roared and writhed. She drank it all, swallowed and swallowed, keeping him in her mouth as he continued to pump weak streams.

Max's lusty breaths roared next to her as he continued to watch and she opened her eyes to see him slack-jawed, awed, and aroused. She smiled and let Cole's cock fall from her mouth into her waiting hand where she squeezed and emitted another pearly strand that ran his shaft and she teased it with her tongue, her eyes on Max's, drawing the line of semen up to his foreskin then scooping it into her mouth and swallowing.

Her sweet boy groaned, and she laughed, said to him, "Stand up."

She sat, saw Cole stretched out over the tub ledge, his head up by the taps where the edge opened to a flat expanse of marble like a table top and his face was obscured by the fronds of a small potted plant.

Max stood next to her, chest heaving, face held in an expression of horror though she knew it was just lusty excitement. He was practically panting.

“Maggie ...?”

She withdrew her leg from the tub and turned to face him, splashing hot water all over the bathmat and the tile floor.

“Can I ...?”

“What?”

His cock stood strikingly erect, pointing up and out from his body.

“Can I ... come ... on ...”

He couldn't finish.

She slipped off the marble and set her knees on the bathmat between his feet, took his cock in her hand and looked in his eyes as he stood over top of her. Her hand pumped him steadily, smiling and watching his reaction. His lower lip quivered, and he still fought to catch his breath.

She nodded, continued.

He groaned and squinted, body swaying with her tugging, his breath stopped and his face went red, he coughed, eyes wide, locked on hers, then she flinched at the first hot stream that flopped on her cheek and brow, closed her eyes and smiled.

WHEN HIS EYES FLUTTERED OPEN, it was well past dawn, and he saw only brilliant azure beyond the arrow-shaped window towering above him. He lay in the bed, on top of the covers, and it felt like he might be naked. His head was at the foot of the bed, his feet up toward the pillows, and beyond the headboard he saw the beautiful vista of Adirondacks, snow, and clear sky. There was a syncopated *creak-creak* that repeated; the sound of fixed wooden joints being tested, like a heavy baby bouncing in a wicker bassinet.

The fire must have died down because he sensed the slightest chill and swept an arm around, seeking the edge of the blanket, finding it and curling

it over to cover his bare body. He closed his eyes and breathed ... behind his eyes now a placid void; his ataraxia. In the aftermath of this once terrible enterprise he felt now strangely *equal*.

Feeling equal didn't feel bad. It was liberating. For so long, he'd struggled with the complexities of this relationship because he wanted to possess Maggie. *Own* her. Deprive her from others and deprive deserving others from her. This morning all the hurt that had ached his back and jaw and curved his posture, twisted at his insides and truly threatened to tear his life apart ... was all gone. He felt good. Warm, content, accepted, *loved*.

Happy eyes fluttering open again, he looked high up the spire logs that held up the shellacked pine plank ceiling and smiled. He kicked his feet around, felt no bodies near him, rolled over onto his stomach, saw that he was the only occupant of the big warm bed. But picking his vision up to peer over the bed's footboard he saw the source of the creaking.

Sunlight filtered into the room, making it bright and setting a gleam on all the polished wood. On a sturdy pine log rocking chair, Maggie sat on Cole's lap, the two of them completely naked and lit up. She faced Cole, his bare toes touching off the floor, her legs bestride his thighs, her little feet tucked against his knees. His thick cock was buried deep inside her and she rocked on him, her face hovering over his, their eyes pouring into one another. Cole humped against her rocking, and Maggie's perfect, round but tiny rump jiggled and shook as she squirmed against his wide intrusion. Cole's hands went up and down her back with loving care, cupping the top curves of her ass cheeks then smoothing up her sides and caressing her neck.

The sight was insanely erotic, and he felt love for her; happiness for her.

As the speed of their grinding increased, Maggie beginning a cute little bounce, he reached a hand under the blanket and gripped his throbbing morning wood. Hand moving up and down in time with her movements, it wasn't long before his grip went slick with his own lubrication.

They slowed again, Maggie sighing, looking to prolong her pleasure, rising and sinking on him, and they both chuckled then kissed.

Maggie caught him watching then, glancing over her shoulder and finding him on his side, watching her yet again, his hand and cock bumping out the blanket as he stroked himself. She laughed and showed a comical expression of shock, then pretended to shyly hide her face away. But she

looked back, running her hair away from her face, beaming, cheeks shining, biting her lower lip.

“*Naughty boy,*” she mouthed silently, frowning and wagging a finger of admonishment.

With a wink, he continued, showing her a devilish smirk and keeping her gaze.

Still riding Cole, who hadn’t noticed yet, now she mouthed, “*Show me.*”

He raised his eyebrows, mouthed, “*Yeah?*” but was already pulling the blanket away to reveal himself to her. Eyes narrowing lustily, her face fell in a gasp and she watched his hand, her bouncing on Cole growing eager again. She nodded to him in encouragement, and soon she and Cole had the chair squeaking madly, rocking back-and-forth.

He lost her then, her attention returned to her lover, eyes squinted shut, mouth snarled, her mind away, focusing on pleasure and chasing yet another orgasm; a number he would estimate in the teens. He laughed as he stroked and watched her.

The two of them grew frenzied, bucking against each other, Maggie’s chin tilted to the ceiling, her perfect little breasts bouncing up and down, Cole’s fingers squeezed into her ass cheeks. They groaned, Maggie squeaked excited gasps, and Cole grunted like an animal. They came together, clutching one another tightly, their bodies trembling, flushing red, seized together breathlessly.

A tickle sizzled through him like an orgasm; no emission, but he tightened till his stomach cramped, an iron grip locked on the end of his pulsing erection.

Then Maggie and Cole burst into explosive breaths, gulping for air, Maggie slapping Cole’s chest lightly as she lifted a leg off him, getting off the chair to stand. Cole’s cock slapped against his belly, glowing in wet painful red.

Maggie’s knees buckled, and she rested her palms on her thighs, still trying to catch her breath. Cole stayed in the chair, rubbing a hand over his sweaty stomach, eyes sleepy. After a slow and steady exhale, Maggie stood more upright, looking over the footboard to see his cock still hard, but his hand resting on his leg.

“Did you... *whew* ... did you come?”

Cole’s head rolled to the side, seeing Max for the first time this morning, sighing a satisfied, “Hey,” to him as greeting.

“Morning,” Max said.

Maggie stepped to the bed, her hands grabbing the top edge of the wood footboard, looking at his erection, saying, “You want me to—”

He shook his head, reached up and put a hand over one of hers. “No, no. I *did* come—kind of. Nothing came out. I think I’m empty.”

Maggie laughed and bounced where she stood, shimmying her thighs together, eyes rolled up like she measured her interior wetness. She said, “I think Cole’s empty too.”

Cole chuckled and groaned, said, “Still felt good.”

She agreed: “It sure did.”

“Max and I need to replenish.”

Maggie said, “Yeah. I’m hungry too.”

Max said, “Why don’t we take those snowmobiles into town and pig out at a diner?”

Cole’s hands clutched the log ends of the chairs arms, rocking it fully forward, his expression one of awe. “*Dude ...*”

“Right?” Max said.

Maggie patted his hand and turned, walking to look out the window, seeing if there would be enough snow. With the bright winter blue sky behind her, her body became a dark perfect silhouette, reflected sun from the snow covering the ground below lighting her face. His heart soared with her beauty revealed; plus something more—a certain completeness.

Then the moment was gone—she turned and said, “Sounds perfect,” coming away from the window and crossing to put her bare rump toward the dwindling fire, reduced to a bed of coals. This was her now, and it exhilarated him to see her so assured.

She shivered, then said, “Somebody stoke the fire, I’m getting in the shower.”

“Want company?” Max asked.

“No way,” she laughed, waving them both off. “I think I need a break.” She disappeared into the bathroom and closed the door behind her.

“We did give it to her pretty good,” Cole said from his chair.

Max said, “She can take it.”

Cole laughed hard, rocked himself out of the chair and came to the bed, jumping onto it and laying next to him. He rolled to face him, Cole wanting to say something but pausing, the sun lighting up his eyes in turquoise. He reached out and put his hand over Max’s neck. “I’m sorry, Max.”

“Yeah.”

“I’m sorry for all the shitty things I did. I don’t know what came over me.”

“She did,” Max said, nudging his chin toward the bathroom door.

Cole laughed, then frowned, said, “Did you mean that dirty?”

“No. But I guess it applies.”

Cole sighed, grew pensive. “I’m a fucking top shelf asshole, dude.”

“You are,” Max said. “So am I.”

“I hate the things I did but I couldn’t help myself. I really am sorry.”

“It’s ... I’m okay. I think ... I grew up a lot ... Learned a few things about myself I’m grateful to know.”

“I’m so lucky to have her, have you ... I’m so grateful you don’t hate me.”

Now Max’s face grew pensive, and he lowered his eyes.

Cole said, “What is it?”

Eyes returned to Cole’s, he said, “Don’t take her from me.”

Cole stayed expressionless, mouth opening and closing again.

“Please, just don’t take her from me.”

Arctic Cat

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 5TH

IN THE BASEMENT they found zippered snowsuits, full-face helmets with tinted visors, and wind-proof gauntlets. Together they trudged through the drifting snow and crossed from the lodge to the garage, Cole picking up and throwing a giggling Maggie into a particularly tall drift, its peak curled over like a frozen wave a surfer would die for. Max and Maggie pelted him with shoddy snowballs that fell apart before they scattered dryly over his back, the snow not quite wet enough to pack.

Once in the garage, he showed them the basics of operating a snow machine, taking one of the Arctic Cats out and showing off, riding with one knee on the bench and throwing donuts in the fluffy white drive below the log garage's dormers. Cole watched with excited envy and Maggie watched with her hands clamped over her ears while he revved the high power machine, sending up an impressive rooster tail of snow that twinkled like sparks in the cold bright sunlight.

Cole got the hang of it quickly, disappearing on them, racing the machine around the property. Maggie was reluctant, and while he sat with her, putting his hands over hers and operating the controls with her, she was too apprehensive.

"I had an accident, you know ..."

"When?" he asked.

"In Michigan. With a rental car."

"When you went to find me?"

She nodded.

"What happened?"

“I backed into another rental at the airport. Right in front of the attendant.”

When he finished laughing, and she stopped swatting at him with her padded mittens, she said, “Let me ride with you. Can’t I just ride with *you*?”

“I want you to ride with me,” he said and darted a kiss to her cold lips. “Put your helmet on.”

She climbed on the seat behind him, wrapped her arms around his middle, and they launched down the driveway looking for Cole.

THE HAMLET WAS DESOLATE. Snow still covered the streets, and they were creased with the tracks of the few vehicles that had ventured out and been capable enough to traverse the unplowed roads. Most of the businesses were closed though she wasn’t sure if that was because of the storm or if it was because it was Sunday and it was the winter. It didn’t matter because they were able to find what they were looking for.

Off the main street and down a hill, following a laneway that backed onto a river, they found a two-story building in gray cedar shingles and white trim, its awning bowing with armfuls of white snow. A metal sign hanger fixed between its two second-floor windows showed a sign for street traffic that read: *Leachman’s Restaurant, since 1956*, in a font from that time. Its two street-level windows were dark but the neon tubes spelling OPEN were lit in inviting red. Max and Cole were able to park the snow machines right out front, and they went in, stomping their boots and taking their helmets off. They had the place to themselves.

The waitress said, “Now *that’s* how you beat the plows,” gesturing to their snowmobiles with her pen. She took their orders, and they got comfortable, setting their helmets on the floor and pulling themselves out of the top halves of their snowsuits. They took the table right in the front window though the view was mostly closed off with curtains printed with evergreens and moose.

The food came quickly. Pancakes, French toast, home fries, sausage, bacon, eggs, coffee, Coke, and Cole asked for a pitcher of water, Max and Cole making snide little jokes about having their fluids depleted.

“What do you want to do this afternoon?” Max asked her.

There were one million things they could do, and she suddenly smiled. It didn't matter what they did as long as she was with both of them. That's what mattered. She said, "Whatever. It doesn't matter. Ski, snowmobile, sleep. We could watch a movie downstairs in the theater ..."

Cole smiled at her warmly and she had a strong feeling that he got it.

Max said, "We have to drive back tonight. In separate cars."

Cole said, "I can skip school tomorrow."

"I took two weeks off. I can't. You guys can stay," Max said, and she thought he might mean it.

"No, dude," Cole said, "we'll all drive back together."

"I'm behind, too," Maggie told him, the last two painful weeks taking a distinct toll on her studying.

They ate in silence for a little while longer but then she set her knife and fork down. Cole continued to eat, but Max looked to her.

She said, "Max, can you come to Harvard with us?"

He said, "When?"

"Attend with us. I want you there with us."

Max looked pained and lost for a moment again and she hated to see that in him, he was too good a person to feel that way. He said, "I can't do that, Maggie. It's not my plan."

"I don't want to be away from you," she said.

"You won't. I swear, we'll figure something out. We don't have to think about it now. That's not for a while ..."

"It's soon," she reminded him.

"I'm going to make it work," he assured her, looking in her eyes. She kept his gaze, let it draw her in, and she saw a surprising strength there that had been missing before. "Okay?" he asked her, that old unsure Max gone now, maybe, hopefully for good, strong Max making her feel like it could possibly be okay.

"Yes," she said.

Cole said, "Lots of work opportunities in Boston."

"There are," Max agreed, winking at her.

Cole called the waitress over and ordered a sundae and Max joined him but she declined, feeling like her belly might burst. The waitress asked what toppings they wanted and Max said fudge, Cole said fruit. When the waitress left, Max rolled his eyes and muttered, "Somebody wants his cum to taste good."

She laughed so hard she bent over to protect her stomach from sending up its overstuffed and maple syrup-soaked contents, falling to touch her forehead to the paper place mat bordered with ads for local businesses. When she rose, it had stuck to her.

BEFORE THEY LEFT THE RESTAURANT, while Maggie had gone to the ladies room to wash her face, he'd talked to Cole. Now, zipping down the lodge's driveway they saw him ahead, his machine stopped at the bay of the log garage, taking off his helmet and shaking out his hair. Max continued past the garage, Cole giving him a nod, and they circled behind the towering lodge, traveling through its lilac shade, carving a fresh path through the snow. Maggie squeezed him tighter, the round shape of her helmet pressing against his shoulder.

They descended the wooded slope in a series of switchbacks until he slowed, finding the shore of the pond. It was cast in a hazy navy sheen, no action on its surface today and it froze in a fragile shell. The machine came to rest under the reaching black arms of a tall spruce. This side of the water had fallen in winter shadow, snow in pale pastel shades, the far shore and the snowy mountains beyond lit in silvery sunshine.

When he stood, he removed his helmet and dismounted the snow machine. He set the helmet and his mitts down on the seat in front of Maggie and walked to the frozen shore. With the toe of his boot he tapped at the surface and an arcing line snapped through it, water seeping up and over top, sinking the fragment of ice. He rinsed the snow from his boots and shook it from his pants with a few stomps.

Maggie stood now too, taking her helmet and gloves off and setting them down next to his. She came down to join him, linking an arm through his and standing at his side, the two of them facing the breathtaking view. Only it was Maggie he watched.

Watched those beautiful narrow eyes, the reflected mountain sunlight sparkling under her lashes; a lot had changed in the last few months. It was like she'd become an adult, matured—and it was more than cosmetic, more than the removal of the blue from her hair. It showed in her demeanor, the

way she carried herself. The Maggie he had met and fallen in love with, devoted himself to, had been a girl. At his side was the woman.

“Thank you,” she said, eyes still on the vista. “It’s beautiful.”

He took the hand that had linked through his arm and turned her to face him, took her other hand. Now she smiled, and he took it from her with a slow and gentle kiss. She kissed him back; not passionately, not lustily, but lovingly. Hands released, he lowered, getting himself down on one knee. In the pocket of his snowsuit he’d transferred the velvet clamshell case that entombed the ring he’d pulled from her. He had it now, flipping the lid open with his thumb and presenting it to her.

“Maggie, I never should’ve taken this from you. I did it to hurt you—but only because I suffered so badly. I was wrong, everything I thought was wrong. But the day I gave you this ring was true and honest. I want that back. I want you to have your ring.”

The last time she’d been presented this diamond, she’d veritably burst with giddiness, bubbling, *Yes, Max, yes, a thousand times yes*, with such deeply credulous love it was infectious, consuming him with the same almost childlike jubilation. Now, she looked solemn.

She sighed, “Oh, Max,” her eyes glued to the ring she’d proudly worn for the last six months. She dropped to her knees in the snow, slumping so she had to turn her face up to meet his. “Maxy, I love you.”

He plucked the ring from its velvet seam and palmed it, closing the case and putting it away in the snowsuit’s pocket. His gaze lowered, afraid to meet her doleful eyes, looking to her chest, the stitched Polaris logo with flecks of tufted snow clinging to its threads. Her response this time would not be a thousand times yes.

When he looked to her again, he saw her eyes gleaming wet, felt the same rising in his own. “Take it, Maggie. Take it because of what it once meant. When I bought this ring for you, I went with my brothers and I swear ... I was overflowing with love for you. And when you accepted? ... Do you remember how you felt, the things you said?”

“Yes. I do.”

“I don’t want this ring to be put in a drawer, or returned, or pawned ... not when it means so much.”

Both her hands wrapped over his that held the ring. His eyes met hers again.

“I’ll wear it, Max. I’ll wear it on a necklace.”

“You will?” he said, raising his chin and showing her he was strong.

“I’m not saying no, Max. Two weeks ago when you took it off my finger I wanted to curl up and die—”

“I’m so sorry ...”

She shook her head. “Because it meant so much to me. It still does.”

She pried his hand open with her fingertips and he lay his hand flat, the gold band and diamond lay in the center of his palm.

“There it is,” she sighed, happy to see it. She took it up with thumb and forefinger and pressed it to her lips. Arms circling his neck, she pulled him against her, kissing him fully. When she withdrew, she sat back on her heels, unzipped the snowsuit. She said, “I’d be crazy not to marry you, Max Milton.”

“You would be,” he agreed as she smiled and put her hands behind her neck and undid her necklace.

“We’re young, Max. We’ll know when we’re ready,” she said, her eyes watching the necklace thread through her ring. Clapsed again, she hooped it over her head.

He leaned close and ran his hands through her hair to pull it from the necklace’s circle. “One day you’ll be mine, Maggie,” he said.

“I’ll always be yours, Max,” she said, closed her eyes and kissed him again.

ALL THREE OF them pitched in as best they could to clean up. The company that managed the property for Martin would hire a service to come in and make it perfect, so they mostly made efforts to hide any evidence of their more vulgar activities. The garbage and recycling were bundled into clear bags and sealed in a metal bin in the garage; the Arctic Cats were parked in there as well. She left a fifty-dollar tip and a thank-you note for whomever would come to clean because whether they realized it or not they would be removing a lot of body fluids from the hard surfaces and the bedding.

In the afternoon they watched Netflix through the home theater system, displayed on a hundred-inch screen between red velvet drapes, and she fell asleep laying across the soft leather cushion of a reclining chair, Max and

Cole in identical ones on either side of her, Cole stroking her hair and Max rubbing her feet. When she woke, Max pulled her pants to her knees and went down on her while she made out with Cole. They made love together, all three of them one more time in the bed, then it was time to go home.

Lights shut off and doors locked, they packed their vehicles up. She told Max she would ride with Cole to see how he would take it and he hugged her, said maybe they could switch after they stopped for dinner. So she boarded the tall Jeep and soon they were winding their way along the snowy roads, heading out of the Adirondacks with Max's headlights staying close in their rear view.

The closer they got to Vermont the more the spell cast by their troika union in the lodge became replaced with serious thoughts on what she would do now. Her sex was satisfied, she knew what she wanted in bed and would get it, but so much more lay ahead of her. There were other things she wanted and she would get them, too.

"You want to play your music?" Cole asked her.

"Yeah," she said, finding her phone and scrolling through her music library to find her Boccherini. She set the phone in the cupholder and let it serve as its own vinyl amplifier. As the tinny strains of Jacqueline du Pré's Davidov reverberated under the drone of Cole's big tires rolling on Interstate highway, she watched the headlights in the side mirror and played through her shirt with the hard circle that hung between her breasts on a golden chain.

Epilogues

Epilogue One

A WEDDING

SIX YEARS LATER

TWO-HUNDRED-AND-SEVENTY-FIVE GUESTS GATHERED on the lawn behind The Poirot and most of them she didn't even know. That was Martin and Carol's doing, most of the invitees attending for their own social benefit. The people that mattered most to her were all in attendance because she kept that number small and controlled.

The tables for close friends and family were hosted on The Poirot's covered balcony with the bride's table. Settings in silver and Limoges, placed on Irish linen that fell to the polished decking; sheets of ivory bunting hung in the rafters, straddling the chandeliers and gently spinning palm-blade fans; open spaces softened with pewter buckets brimming with pastel roses set on pedestals. Below the balcony, on the sloping lawn that fell to the Atlantic Ocean, a dance floor on the grass, demarcated by further rose bouquets in a broken perimeter; surrounding the dance floor, the remaining guest tables. Round, intimate tables with the same settings, under pale raffia bunting wound through the trees along with cords of bare Edison globes, glowing now in amber corona as the sun set and the maritime sky turned the deep color of new denim. The tables immediately around the grassy dance floor were each overhung with huge dangling chandeliers with

twinkling crystals. The Poirot had balked at providing them and she'd been direct until they complied.

Twenty-six years of age now, officially married, first in her JD program—Law, Science and Technology—a new job offer from Google where she was invited and attended on an upper year internship; the ceremony was complete, her union made, dinner was served and finished. Very soon a new and exciting chapter would be opened.

Right now though, straight ahead, she spied one of those people-that-mattered-most. Tragically solitary, looking depthlessly alone even amongst all these mingling, laughing people, he leaned his elbows on the railing of the balcony, looking over the heads of the guests dancing on the lawn, out to the ocean beyond, a gin and tonic in his hand.

Through the dining room and coming out now to the balcony on the toes of her shoes, keeping the points of her tall heels from clicking, she snuck up on him. With the front of her wedding dress pulled up so she wouldn't trip, she got right behind him and laced her hands around to cover his eyes.

"Hey, who's that?" he said, knowing who it was.

She said, "Good evening, Mr. Milton. Who do you think it is?"

He covered her hands with his own, setting his glass on the railing's edge. "I think it's the most beautiful bride I've ever seen," he said and kissed her hand and turned to face her.

Older and sadder now, the expression he held broke her heart, but she hid it from him. "You're still the best sweet talker," she told him, squeezing his hands. "But I think you've seen more beautiful." It had to be said, and he took it well, and whatever might hurt inside him it was his turn to hide it.

He said, "Well, how does it feel to make it official now?" lifting his chin and showing strength, as meager as it may be.

She shrugged, scrunched her nose. "Not much different."

He threw his head back and laughed. "You just want to get out of here, don't you?"

"You know me," she said.

He turned, put his elbows back on the railing, watching out over the crowd, his face lit in warm yellow by the hanging strings of lights. "I'm happy for you two."

"I know you are, Mr. Milton," she said.

"Come on, Maggie," he said. "It's Keith."

She rolled against him so their shoulders touched. “Sorry, Keith,” she laughed. “I am an adult now, aren’t I? And, it’s Margaret, not Maggie.”

Max’s dad laughed, and said drolly, “Sor-ry, Margaret,” dragging out her official name and bumping her shoulder in return. He took a sip of his drink and turned, put his back to the railing, his face turned to hers and watching her with wistful admiration.

“What?” she asked though she knew what would come.

Slowly, while he held her gaze, his features dropped. “I just wish she could be here.”

Through blinking wet, she gave him a quick nod, but averted her eyes.

“Sorry,” he whispered, putting his hand on her back.

“Don’t break the seal, Mr.—Keith, I mean,” she said, her voice squeezed.

“I’m sorry, Maggie,” he said again.

She took a deep breath and cleared her throat. “I wish she was here, too. She *should* be here.”

He returned to the railing with his elbows and sighed heavily. “She is in spirit, Maggie. She’s in each of those Milton boys out there,” he said nodding toward the dance floor where they could see Max’s brother Mike having a particularly good time.

June Milton succumbed to her Hodgkin’s in the winter after a five-year battle. At the end of summer, she’d gone to Michigan to spend two days with her when she and Keith decided to abandon chemo, and returned to spend the first week of December at their home where she’d been in palliative care. June wasn’t good. The visit wasn’t sweet or warm. It was stark, heartbreaking, and sometimes ugly. She wanted to be there to say goodbye, a longing ache in her heart for this group of wonderful people who had first given her a glimmer of what it meant to be part of a family. But June didn’t pass until two days after Maggie returned to Boston.

“She is,” Maggie agreed quietly. “She’s out there.”

From behind them, a cold and even voice: “Good evening, Keith.” They turned to find Carol in her Prada mother-of-the-bride dress. An elegant hand extended to him and Keith instantly brightened, the heavy weight of the previous moment shrugged off his shoulders as he went into comedic performance for Maggie’s benefit. He took the proffered hand and pulled it to kiss in Royal protocol, then roguishly kissed both of Carol’s cheeks while Maggie stifled a giggle. Carol raised a knowing eyebrow, understanding she

was the butt of some joke between them but resting a hand on his shoulder and then kissing both his cheeks as well.

Attention to Maggie now, she said, “I’ve been looking for you, Margaret.”

“I’ve been here,” she said, suppressing an eye roll.

“Well, it’s time for your dance. You’re needed.”

“Yes, mother,” she said, hoisting herself off the railing with petulant exasperation, turning then and kissing Max’s father’s cheeks over the burgundy prints her mother had left.

“If you’ll excuse me, Keith—I have to go and dance with my husband now ...”

MAGGIE DESCENDED the four steps off The Poirot’s balcony, down to the waiting crowd who welcomed her with quiet applause. She smiled for them, eyes narrowed to happy black lines, red lips peeled back to show her wide white smile. The soft light from the overhanging strings of bulbs turned the satin of her white wedding dress into shimmering gold. Max had never seen her look more beautiful.

Across the grassy dance floor in her high heels, she held up the billowing skirt of her dress. Her hair was pulled from her face in a braided bun, tangled with raffia and beads that hung down her long neck. Someone wolf-whistled and there was laughter; she quickened her pace, trotting to her husband’s arms.

Max gripped his drink tightly, his throat narrowing, desiccated, standing outside the perimeter behind an overflowing bouquet of pastel roses. Breath held, his insides clenched till they ached. This was worse than witnessing the vows for some reason. It was her expression; her joy. He always wanted that as his own, but now it belonged to another man.

Cole stood proudly, waiting to receive her in his simple and elegant tuxedo. Tanned, shaved, unruly hair cut short at the back and sides since he’d entered the corporate world. He left his glasses with Max, tucked in his lapel pocket right now, as Maggie came to him and was swept up in his arms.

The opening strains of The Style Council's 'You're The Best Thing,' began, and though he'd heard it a couple dozen times already in the last six months the tears overflowed and his airways restricted to a narrow squeak. Every lyric dug into him despite his preparation. He'd helped Cole prepare, taking time from his hectic schedule and practiced his dance with him when Maggie traveled to the West Coast for work. This was it though, the real moment, and he overflowed with emotion, hiding his face from anyone who might see, grimacing and tucking his chin to his chest watching with warbled vision through his brows.

Maggie and Cole were flawless together, twirling, swaying, keeping eye contact—and Cole didn't step on her long dress once, which had been his greatest fear. When Cole dipped her at the end of the dance and they kissed deeply despite the smiles, the crowd erupted with cheers and he sat his Michter's down in the grass between his shoes so he could join in and praise his friends with applause.

They looked in one another's eyes and laughed before Cole helped her stand. One more kiss and then she trotted back to the balcony while Cole remained with his hand outstretched, smiling slyly, waiting to receive his next dance partner, Carol, also smiling slyly.

"Dude, how the fuck did you let that get away?"

"Fuck off, Connor," Max said, bending down to retrieve his bourbon.

Connor had silently sidled up next to him, drink in hand, eyes still watching as Maggie mounted the steps and returned to the bride's table. When he looked back, he caught Max wiping his cheeks. His snide face softened, and he hoisted an arm around his brother's shoulders and gave him a hearty hug. "It's okay, Maxy."

He groaned and shook his head, but leaned into Connor while they watched Cole waltz with Carol.

"What's okay? What are you talking about?" A sweet feminine voice behind them.

While Max groaned yet again, Connor let him go, saying, "How much this sap loves you, Keely."

With dubiety, Keely said, "He was, was he?"

"We're not talking about anything," Max moaned, putting his arm around her waist and pulling her against him.

"Oh Maxy," she sighed, looking at the side of his face. "You were doing so good."

“I’m fine,” he said, but he couldn’t look at her.

“You’re not fine, baby,” she sang in her Irish accent. “Look at your cheeks. They’re all rosy.”

“I’m fine,” he said again, but she got him smiling.

“Are you gonna start again?” she said, chasing him, trying to get him to look at her. He stretched to the side, twisting toward Connor where she couldn’t see his face.

She said, “Connor, is he crying again? Can you see him?”

Connor laughed and narrowed his eyes on him, sipping his own bourbon. “I think he’s gonna cry again, Keely. He’s welling up.”

Max twisted further from her, but she said to Connor, “Shall we tickle him?”

“You’re on your own there, but it might fix him,” Connor said.

“Do you need a tickle?” she asked him.

“Please, don’t,” he said, tensing, knowing she might anyway.

“Would you give us a kiss?” she asked.

“Yes,” he agreed, turning to face her, his tears gone, soothed away by a girl who somehow knew him better than himself.

“Do it then,” she said with a devious smile, a sparkle in her smaragdine eyes.

He did, planting his lips over hers and she closed her eyes, and scratched the back of his neck. When they parted, she whispered, “You’re okay, yeah?”

“I am,” he told her.

“Smile for the people, Max. Some of them know you’re more than the Best Man.”

He nodded, breathed deeply; she was right. Now he laughed freely and kissed her again, her arms going around his neck.

Talking behind them now, she called out for Connor.

“What?” he said.

“Did you see my ring, Connor?”

“Yes,” he said.

“Did you?” Keely said and wiggled her fingers over his shoulder at Connor.

Connor lowered his drink and looked up to the stars. He shouted, “Yes!”

“Do you see it now, Connor?” she persisted, still wagging her ring finger, flashing her engagement diamond.

Connor said, “Yes, you DMed me on Twitter, Instagram, Facebook, you sent me an email ...”

“Your fault for following me,” she said. “You gave me that power.”

“I thought if I ignored you, you would go away,” Connor laughed.

Max and Connor had bought the ring together, back when they stayed a week with Mom. Max’s sister had asked Connor what it looked like. In what he claimed was an early morning stupor, he’d fired off a photo sent directly to Keely. No message attached, Keely had asked him why he sent that; he’d claimed it was for his girlfriend at the time, who everyone knew he had no intention of marrying, and was asking for her opinion. Keely, a crafty law student, knew right away the mistake and would likely *never* let Connor forget how he’d ruined the surprise of her engagement. Only, it wasn’t really much of a surprise at all, *everyone* seeing it coming.

Keely said, “I’m never going away, Connor.”

Connor hung his head in his usual surrender when she went after him over the ‘Ring Fuck-Up’ as Mike called it. He said, “I sure hope you don’t.” Then poking Max in the ribs before he parted, he said, “Don’t fuck *this* one up, junior.”

SHE WAS PRETTY sure Max was drunk, up now and standing on a stool, organizing an impromptu toast. He’d chimed a knife on a goblet, rose to stand above the meager crowd gathered at one end of the dance floor, while most carried on their way; the festivities had dwindled and the protocol of the toasts and speeches were behind them.

“Everybody, everybody,” he was saying, getting the crowd’s attention after he’d nailed them with an opening joke. “So listen, I’ve been with these two a long time,” his eyes scanned the crowd, caught her standing at the back of the gathering and pointed his drink at her. “This one,” he said, winking, “and ...” now he paused looking over heads again, turned up empty. “Well, wherever the groom is ... shit, I have his glasses,” he said now, patting the front of his tuxedo jacket. “If no one sees him in the next few minutes, we should probably troll the waters, make sure he didn’t stumble off the cliff ...”

The crowd laughed at his delivery, Max blinking his eyes like Mr. Magoo.

Next to her, a sudden nervous flash of dove gray silk and long fiery hair, Keely in her Maid of Honor dress. Her eyes were up on Max, and while she smiled, her expression was still taut with anticipatory tension. She said, "Do you want me to bring him down from there?"

Maggie laughed. "No, let's hear what he has to say. But stay close to me." She wound her arm through Keely's and they listened with smirks on their lips.

Max said, "We don't need to panic yet, I'm sure. He's an excellent swimmer, and my ears have grown attuned and sensitive to his cries for help ..." he cocked his head as if listening. "We're good for now." There was laughter. "So, I've been with these two a long time, and no offense, I know them better than any of you." After more rolling laughter, he said, "No, that's not a joke. I'm serious. Better than *any* of you. Even you, Mr. Cantarella," he said, pointing a finger at Cole's father who shook his head and laughed.

"No, really," he said, chin lowering introspectively. "I do know them well, and they're my best friends. Cole was my roomie when we were in Vermont. And then came Maggie," he said, wet eyes raising and finding her again. But he was smiling, saying now, "Just a pretty little songbird back then. Some of you might not have recognized her, I mean it. And I don't mean just because her hair was blue ..." That got more chuckling. "She was timid. I saw all the greatness in her, saw all this bubbling beauty," now his eyes were turned up to the stars. "You know she bought a bird cage once. Antique thing when we were all on a road trip, the three of us. Couldn't figure out why she would want something like that ... you know? ... Then I thought of Carol ..."

The crowd wanted to laugh but swallowed it. Keely's arm tightened against her. "I'll get him down from there," she hissed, trying to move away, but Maggie kept her locked.

"Let him go," she laughed. Then leaning close to her, she said, "But I hope he doesn't think he's safe from my mother." Keely groaned and rubbed her face with her other hand.

Max continued. "I'm kidding, of course—I love Carol." Then conspiratorially, "She's behind me, isn't she?"

It lightened the crowd.

“I’d like to think Cole and I opened Maggie’s cage door ...”

Now she tensed again, worried he might take this in a bluish direction. Keely patted her arm.

“Once this beautiful bride we all came to see here today spread her wings ...” he trailed off, and she saw his eyes gleam. He swallowed. “Opening her door was just a tiny thing, a simple thing. She was the one who had to teach her wings to work—my reward ... Cole’s and my reward was seeing her fly.” Now he sniffed wetly, said, “I guess I’ll turn this into a toast ... if everyone could raise a glass; Maggie ... sorry, *Margaret* is standing at the back.”

“Here we go,” Keely whispered as the crowd all turned now and faced her.

Max raised his bourbon to her and she couldn’t help a big smile from pulling at her cheeks. Her own eyes went wet. He said, “The pale purple even melts around thy flight ...”

Keely sighed, “Oh, shit ...”

And Maggie chuckled, shaking Keely, getting her laughing too.

Max finished: “Like a star of Heaven, in the broad daylight, thou art unseen, but yet I hear thy shrill delight.” After a beat: “To Margaret.”

He drank and so did the others. Max kept his eyes on hers and she felt herself well up again. Unhooked from Keely, she blew him a kiss with both hands and there was light clapping. Max put his hand over his heart. Someone helped him backward off his stool.

“Maggie, Maggie,” an urgent voice behind her, low and hushed, impatient and worried but not wanting to make a scene.

Ken had her elbow now, turning her. Behind him, his husband Brian loomed woefully in the background. Brian was always quiet, but usually calm—he’d masterfully weathered the tumult of the first Becker gay marriage. Maggie had been by their side, facing down her perplexed parents caught in the hydra of having a son who was gay and seeking to marry, but also a successful bio-tech investor with a doctorate from Johns Hopkins. Brian’s nervous face pressed down on her with abrupt tension; for him to be affected this was dire.

Ken said, “Hi, Keely,” out of politeness, then immediately to her, “You need to come with me. There’s a problem.”

She gave Keely an uncertain nod, and she returned a worried look, and now she walked with Ken who pulled her along, moving briskly across the

grass toward the covered porch. As they ascended the steps together, she pulled back on his grip. “What is it Ken? What’s going on?”

“Be cool, Maggie, be calm, just come with me.” There was a wild and anxious look on his face.

“What’s the problem?” she said to his back as they crossed into the dining room of the huge mansion. Guests milled and servers cleaned, the celebration winding down now.

“It’s Cole,” he said.

“Is he okay?” she said, and the tight worry in her voice got him to stop and turn around.

He gripped her arms, said, “Maggie, some ... *guy* showed up, demanded to come in. The staff rejected him but he was mad and now there’s a fight.”

“With Cole?”

“Come on,” he said, pulling her again and leading her across the dining room. “They’re wrestling on the lawn out front ...”

“What? Cole is?—Ken? ...” But Ken ignored her now, and she struggled to keep up with him in her heels. At the end of the dining area, he stopped, pulled her in front of him, then pushed her toward the passageway to the hotel’s lobby.

She said, “Did you call—”

Stumbling into the hall, half-turning, bewildered by this insane development, some vestigial ghost from the past stroking the backside of her memories, seeing a man in the hall, turning back to see Ken’s smirk, Brian’s too, lurking behind him, turning back again and seeing with flooding relief the man in the hall was Cole.

With his back leaning against the wall next to a bathroom door, he held one hand casually in his pocket, the other at his waist, fingers gripping the long thorny stem of a large and perfect pale rose. The collar of his shirt was undone, two winged halves of his black bowtie slung on either side; head cocked, he smiled at her devilishly.

“You asshole,” she laughed. “My heart is racing ...”

“Come here,” he said, lifting his chin and narrowing his eyes at her, and she felt her feet lift off the floor.

WITH HIS BIG, strong, warm hand placed on her chest above her dress’s bustier, fingers wide, he said, “It *is* racing.”

“Do you feel it?”

The pad of his thumb caressed the soft flesh of her exposed bosom, tugging at it gently, lifting the weight of her breast, scoring her hardening nipple against the backside of her dress’s liner. He asked, “Why is it racing?”

“You tricked me,” she whispered.

A flash of a smile, then he said, “You’ve been a good girl?”

She nodded, looked over the top of his presented rose and into his endless eyes.

“You know I’ll be able to tell.”

She nodded again, but said, “How?”

His eyes shifted from left to right, watching both ends of the opulent corridor. They were alone. With striking confidence, he gripped the front of her dress and pulled the skirt up sharply, exposing her legs. His hand shoved underneath, and he ran it up the inside of her thigh and it made her fall against him. He snapped the strap of her garter and it stung her sensitive thigh.

She grimaced and squeaked, and he liked that; snapped it again making her gasp. The tip of his finger traced the crease of her hip, following the natural V to the hot space between her thighs. A tremble worked through her legs. Now his fingers rustled against her growing thatch of pubic hair.

“Oh please,” she whispered, desperate to be touched.

Three months of abstinence. That had been his instruction. The wedding night was going to be special, and he wanted her under his control. She’d been good. Hadn’t even shaved herself and had been brief with her touch while she maintained hygiene though this month her fingers ached to linger. But, Cole was not to be disappointed, and she did not let him down.

“Where are your panties, you little slut?”

She giggled, her stomach bouncing with excitement, dying for those fingers to stroke just a little lower ...

“In your pocket,” she whispered. She’d snuck them in there while they signed the marriage documents and the pastor’s head was turned. “Did you find them?”

He nodded slowly, his eyes locked on hers. “They smelled strongly.”

“It’s been too long,” she whispered.

“Beg me,” he said, tossing the pretty rose to the floor between their feet.

“Touch me, please ...”

“Touch you where?”

“Touch my pussy, please, I’m dying ...” Now she bounced on her toes, making Cole’s fingers pluck at her coarse pubic hairs.

“You’ve been good?”

“Feel,” she said, her eyes narrowing to lines.

Her lips sucked into her mouth and she braced herself against him with her hands on his strong chest while his finger ran the split of her sex and stroked over her hot slippery folds. Two fingers hooked up inside her and she cried out, swallowed it, bit her lower lip.

“Mm-hmm,” he hummed affirmatively. “Mrs. Cantarella, you have one hot, wet, and very tight pussy.”

“Stretch it for me,” she gasped, that tremble back in her tummy. “Stretch it for me, please.”

“Listen,” he said, conjuring up wet sucking sounds from her hot, desperate hole.

“I told you,” she said. “I’ve been so good for you.”

His hand fumbled between them, bumping against her stomach, then the sound of his zipper being drawn down; she shivered.

“Have *you* been good?” she gasped hopefully.

That devilish smile returned, and he raised his chin, looked down on her, his other hand took her wrist and now she had permission, her grip rushed to circle his cock. She found him huge, hard and throbbing; she glanced down, saw her slightest squeeze send out a pulsing gush of clear and silvery semen that spilled over her thumb, down his shaft, stretching to a swaying thin strand that made it almost to the floor unbroken.

“Oh God,” she sobbed. “Please, please, can I suck it?”

He pushed her to her knees with his hands on her shoulders and she glanced furtively left and right. Still alone, she went to her knees and worshipped his huge cock with her tongue. Licking up the wide underside and then enveloping the big glans, pulling his foreskin back with the tight ring of her lips. He streamed beautiful and copious pre-come into her happy mouth. He only let her bob on it a few times before he lifted her under her arms and brought her to stand again.

“Straighten yourself, Margaret,” he commanded, the look on his handsome face bisecting her; part wanting to laugh in joy and warmth, the other being tugged toward something dark and brutish, a lusting need for

that dark thing winding through her to be pulled taut and snap an orgasm out of her, release her.

She nodded, buttoned her lip, and showed him a steady face. Hands smoothing over her dress, she brought her skirt to hang down properly and Cole watched her, the whole time tucking his erection back into his pants and zipping up, leaving the fly bowed out in a wicked hump.

“Come with me, please,” he said and took her hand, led her down the hall and out to the hotel lobby. They turned, nodded to the concierge, Cole tugging one side of his jacket over to cover his arousal so the prim young woman wouldn’t see. They mounted the steps together, trotting the lush carpet, turning left as they arrived on the balcony, under an archway then, quickening, making their way to the Bridal Suite.

Almost there, he stopped her suddenly, and she frowned with frustration. They stood in the hall looking at each other, and she waited for his next game, hoping it wouldn’t take too long, because now he’d got her started she needed to *fuck*, and now.

“What is it?” she whined, when he hadn’t said anything.

“Where are you going, Margaret?”

“Our room ...”

“The Bridal Suite?”

“Yes,” she said, frowning.

“That’s for good girls, Margaret. Pure girls.” He turned and swiped a card through the door behind him. “Not whores like you. Whores like you get fucked in the Regency.”

She wanted to burst out laughing, but there was that tug again, snagged on her womb, drawing her to the edge of release; she went weak in the knees. The Regency was the room he’d taken her to the night she selected her wedding dress when she’d been engaged to Max. The first time she’d had real sex alone with Cole, or at least thought she’d been alone.

Stepping in was like being transported in time, going back six years. The room was the same, wood-paneled in deep mahogany and intricate linenfold, same furniture, couch by a roaring fire, four-poster bed raised up an elevated corner of the suite.

He’d left her breathless.

Cole closed the door behind them. “What do you think, Margaret?” he asked, walking past and running a finger up the centre of her bare back.

“Oh wow,” she sighed, her nipples clenching at his touch.

“Come now,” he said, offering her a hand.

She put hers in his and he led her to the small seat at the foot of the bed where she turned then, sat herself and watched him expectantly.

He watched her sitting, taking off his jacket and tossing it on the bed behind her. When he was close, she could smell his cologne, smell his musk. He stepped back, turned around to the huge armoire behind him, opening both of its doors, revealing it to be empty.

“Just making sure my Best Man wasn’t in there,” he said.

She giggled, then slapped both her hands over her mouth.

He said, “That’s not funny, Margaret. Open your legs.”

They were crossed now as she sat on the low, backless sofa, and she wound them apart, set both her high heels down on the floor. As she watched his face, she stepped one foot out then the other. Though her skirt kept her covered, the feeling of exposure was powerful.

He humphed with satisfaction, working the cufflinks out of their slots then placing them on a shelf in the open armoire with a click, then turning and now rolling up his sleeves and folding them just below his elbows. Hands on hips now, he said, “Lift your skirt and show me that dirty slit.”

She exhaled through pursed lips, took a hold of the fabric and with crawling fingers dragged the skirt of her dress up to her knees, then along the tops of her thighs until her sex had been bared to him.

He grunted lustily, then recovered, firming his jaw and saying, “I see beads of your wet in your pubic hair. My, what an awful little slut you are.” He clucked his tongue and shook his head. “What kind of embarrassment did I marry?”

“I can’t help it,” she told him.

“So sad. Such depravity speaks of a troubled mind, Margaret.” His palm crested the curved bend of his erection trapped in his pants and her eyes fell to watch.

“So horny,” he said, displeased. “Up on all fours, please. Climb on the bed like a dog.”

“Yes,” she said, her heart thrumming away. She turned and got her knees on the bench, crawled her way up to the bed.

“That’s far enough,” he said, and she stopped.

He was behind her then, quickly whisking up her skirt and throwing it over her back. She was exposed to him now, and she could feel the cooler

air of the room touching all her wets seams, and they were quite wet. He grunted again, his finger stroking up her labia, parting them.

“Please,” she urged.

His thumb slipped higher, the pad circling her anus, then inserting inside.

She moaned and reared backward to meet its entry, hungry for it. Two slipped in, the thumbs from both hands going inside her, pulling her passage open and a warm string of spit flowing into the hole.

“Oh,” she moaned and closed her eyes. Now his middle finger stroked in and out of her anus with the wet of his saliva.

Then he was gone, backing away from the bed and she stayed on her knees, but put one shoulder down on to the mattress and turned her head so she could see where he’d gone. At the dresser next to the armoire he opened a drawer and withdrew a slender bullet-nosed dildo, and she clenched her toes in her shoes. When he turned he caught her watching. “It will take some tools and a firm hand to relieve you of your burden, Margaret. Are you prepared?”

“Please, hurry,” she answered.

In response he twisted the base of the dildo and it hummed with high frequency vibration. “Pull your cheeks away for me, please.”

Eyes still watching him, she reached her hands down her body, up her thighs, coming to the curves of her rump and pulling her cheeks wider, exposing herself fully to him. Her wetness slipped warmly down the inside of her thighs.

“Oh Margaret,” he sighed to himself. “So shameful.”

With that, he was on the bed behind her again, and she felt the hard bullet nose circle her sensitive sphincter, its vibrations shooting through her heart. Cole pushed it till it was inside her deeply, thrumming away at her core. Her pussy spasmed, and her stomach clenched to an iron column, she fell to her side on the bed and cried out with a hot and surprising orgasm. Her knees drew to her chest as she choked and cried, her eyes squinted shut, her features snarling in ecstatic discomfort. One wasn’t enough, and she could feel another orgasm already pushing behind the first.

A snap of leather sounded behind her, Cole whisking away his belt from around his waist and whipping it next to her. Without being asked, she wormed facedown and hooked both hands behind her back, crossing her wrists at the small of her back. The leather belt wound around, Cole doing it

in practiced moves that weren't rough; determined but not hurtful. Soon he had her hands secured behind her back with his belt wound tightly. The dildo still hummed inside her and she knew he would penetrate her soon.

"Please," she muttered.

"Hold still," he said in a low commanding tone, nudging her ankles wider so he would fit between her legs. She kept her knees together still, and he thrust her face into the mattress with his hand curled over the back of her head. When he entered her, she cried out. It had been a long time, and he was very thick—but the pain was so welcome. Her cry turned to exultation as she felt her membranes parting but clinging to his perfect cock, her muscles clamping on his large intrusion, wanting to reject it at first. By the time he'd withdrawn and plunged again, her deepest core was ready for him, welcoming with liquid gushing that slopped noisily around his thrusting.

"Oh fuck, oh fuck," he grunted, and she could feel the tremble that his own abstinence sent through his hand, a quiver in his thighs as well where they pressed her calves.

She kicked her feet and wailed, wanting it hard and wanting it deep; Cole gave it to her, pounding her wickedly now, the dildo rocked by his thrusts, plunging her asshole deep when his stomach bumped it. She grabbed a mouthful of sheets and clamped her teeth, grunting and snorting wetly.

Both his hands wrapped her neck and pulled her face from the bed, bracing her so he could fuck her so hard his pubic bones slapped her ass cheeks. Then she was thrown aside, his cock springing wetly from inside her and she wailed complaint.

She was on her back, her hands lashed behind her, her knees drawn up to her breasts, eyes struggling to focus, pinpointing finally on Cole looming over her. Her thighs opened wide to invite him and he got over her, his cock head finding her gaping and eager hole and his shaft burying itself inside her to the hilt in one stroke that made her scream. His mouth went over hers and she was trapped underneath him, impaled fully, stretched wide, immobilized, her breaths and cries being stolen by his kisses.

He pounded her faster and faster and as her breaths got short and quick, her heart raced to a staccato, she felt it coming and she opened her arms to it. Three months without her man had made her wild with desperation and

she missed his touch, his kiss, his cock, his power over her when he wished to wield it.

Her orgasm began while she clenched her teeth so tight, they squeaked in her eardrums. Her pussy went into a fluttering spasm around his girth and she bellowed out joyously, so glad to finally get the release. He chased her down, didn't let her get a hold of it, his cock still driving deep, his kisses still taking her blubbing lips. She liked him to stop when she came, push it deep and let her grip it with her girl muscles, squeeze it like a totem, rob his male power from it, undulate her wet feminine softness against his wicked male hardness and throw herself on a long riding wave. Only now he was eager to send her past that point, eager for her to get more than she bargained for and also eager to fill her up with the massive volume of his abstinence.

He roared in her ear, coming while she still came, his forceful eruption deep inside her sending her tumbling over a high wall, tickled and raw and electrified. His cum splashed her walls, splashed her cervix, and it shot from him in strong hot pulses. Eight, nine, ten spasms of his cock against her tight walls, each one sending what felt like buckets of his semen into her. She rocked and writhed below him, feeling a scream building inside her and tightening everything she had to keep it at bay, her body cramped, and her feet bowed to curled arches, heels digging into the backs of his legs.

She cried out, "Oh shit, oh shit, oh no, oh no, mm, you asshole," and now she was laughing. Her insides released as a new and slippery chrome orgasm whisked across all her surfaces, pulling a hot sheet of excitement over her, covering her mouth and nose, getting in her lungs and suffocating her. He'd started it and she couldn't stop it. She tinkled wildly. Hot water pattering from her pussy, all over her bare legs and Cole's stomach, across the bedding, soiling her wedding dress. Cole withdrew to watch, falling to her side. Through squinted eyes she could see it now sparkling in the lamplight, dancing up in the air in happy, squirting, pulsing arcs. It was out now, and she enjoyed it: pressing with her flexed stomach and spritzing it higher and farther, letting it all go as insane voltages of pleasure rocked her up and down.

"Oh fuck, mm, oh you, ah," she grunted and coughed as the orgasm continued to seize her.

"Oh God, I missed you so bad," he sighed, shimmying up the bed to join her face to face, putting his arms around her, caressing her and kissing

her.

She let him put his hands all over her, her chest rising and falling with great lurches of breath. “That’s how ... ha, how you wanted to do it ... ha, the first time we’re husband and wife?”

Cole closed his eyes and turned his face upward, thinking interiorly. “Yes,” he said.

She kissed his ribs, working a little higher, suckling his nipple, then running her tongue through the hair in his armpit. With her head laying on his shoulder, she said, “Three months without you was torture.”

“Was it worth the wait?”

She chuckled. “Not yet.”

“Oh, not yet? I didn’t satisfy you?”

“It was a good start. Untie me.”

He watched her eyes, and she locked on his blues while his arms went around and worked behind her, undoing the loops of belt that bound her.

She added, “And the dildo ...?”

He smiled, slipped it gently from her bottom where it made a slick crackle heard over the drone of its little motor. She ran her hands over his muscle, up his chest and cupped his cheeks. “You called me Mrs. Cantarella.”

“I did.”

“Do it again.”

“You’re an honest woman now, Mrs. Cantarella. I’ve freed you of your shame,” he said, caressing her breast, his thumb circling her rubbery nipple.

Her hand went down between his legs, cupped his balls, let them sag, stroked his shaft. “Make love to me,” she whispered.

KEELY SAID, “I thought your speech was quite rousing.”

“Did you?” Max asked.

“Yes, but I have a fondness for mentally unstable drunks who quote Shelley.”

“Hilarious,” he said. “But I didn’t have much to drink.”

“Hmm, just mental then?”

“Just mental,” he agreed.

They were on the second floor of The Poirot, heading along the hall toward the room, Keely ahead, standing at the door to their room. He stopped and put his hands on her face, kissed her.

“What’s that for?” she asked.

“You’re my rock,” he told her.

Her face softened, her eyes going wistful, and no smart quip for him this time, she said, “It’s my honor, Max. I mean it.”

The door to the room loomed large behind her and though he heard nothing behind it, he imagined there would be much ribaldry. With imaginary sounds in his ears he protected Keely’s, putting his hands over her long thick hair and covering her ears.

“What are you doing?” she asked with one peaked eyebrow. “Take me to bed already.”

“I will,” he said, running his hands from her ears and down her arms, leaving her and continuing down the hall.

She called to him, “Where are you going?”

“Down here ...”

“That was our room ...” she said, catching up to him and thumbing over her shoulder.

“We’re taking another room.”

“What was wrong with that one?”

“I got us a better room.”

“You’re always full of surprises, Max,” she said, obviously piqued, and taking up his hand.

At the end of the hall, they turned to the right and made their way to the last doorway.

“Oh no, Max,” she said. “This ... it’s the Bridal Suite ...”

“It is,” he said, swiping the key card through the slot. “Surpri-ise ...”

They entered the opulent room together, Keely hesitant, leaning forward with her clutch pressed to her stomach, looking around the space. The suite was massive, beautiful, ornate. Walls in French blue-gray with white trim, Louis XIV furniture, crystal chandeliers in each of its many rooms. A fire lit up a brick hearth and white wood mantelpiece at the foot of a very tall and massive four-post bed.

“This isn’t our room, Max,” she whispered, afraid to come in further, standing on the gleaming maple at the edge of a woven wool rug.

“Come in,” he laughed. “We’re alone. This is *our* room.”

“What’s going on?” she asked, loosening, coming to stand with him.

“It was a surprise. They took our room because ... just for old time’s sake.”

“You switched?”

“Cole wanted to surprise Maggie.”

“Old time’s sake, huh?”

“They shared an evening in it. A long time ago.”

“That’s sweet. He’s so thoughtful. Why didn’t you tell me?”

He took the key card and his wallet out of his jacket, threw them on a tall dresser. “We didn’t tell you because you can’t keep secrets.”

“I can keep secrets.”

“No, you can’t.”

“I can keep the boring ones.”

“You just forget the boring ones.”

“Aye, that’s true,” she said with a cute little smile and coming to stand with him, putting her hands on his shoulders. Keely was as tall as him, taller in her heels, looking directly into his eyes with the greatest understanding. Most often without makeup, he liked to see her this way, made up for the wedding in her satiny gray dress, her hair in a long tail and a braided crown. She said, “Were you covering my ears outside our room?”

He huffed a breathy laugh and smirked for her, ran her ponytail behind a pale shoulder.

With her hands cupping his cheeks, she said, “You did really good today, Max.”

“Don’t ...” he warned her. Looking down to avoid her serious gaze, he noted Cole’s glasses still in his pocket. He plucked them out, tortoiseshell rims with stainless arms, opened them and put them on, regarding her now coolly with his hands in his pockets through Cole’s prescription.

“Would you stop it,” she said, taking them off him and throwing them onto the bed. “Be serious.”

“What?” he laughed, trying to make light of it, but inside his heart was breaking and he just didn’t feel like talking about it right now.

“Max, my angel,” she said softly, her hand smoothing over his chest and slipping under his tuxedo jacket, then across his shirt and finding the gap between two buttons her slender hand slipped in to touch his bare chest, right over his heart. “I can take it away.”

“Take what away?”

“Your troubles,” she said, and now she turned away from him, staying close and looking over her shoulder at him with lowered chin. A finger came and plucked the stringy strap of her bridesmaid’s dress off her ivory shoulder where it fell along her slim upper arm. She waited.

He did the other, taking the string and sliding it over that graceful curve, letting it fall. With his index finger hooked down the back of her dress, he tugged it lower, bit by bit, till the silky thing she wore lost its form, clinging to her sexy body for one more second then billowing to the floor in a quiet whisper. Now she was bare but for lavender lingerie and her gray satin pumps. Eyes wandering up and down her absolutely flawless body, wide hips and bottom and narrow waist, he chuckled.

“Breathtaking, yeah?” she said over her shoulder.

He chuckled again, said, “Breathtaking.” Tall, curvy, a striking mane of fiery red hair streaked with blonde highlights that tumbled to the top of her ass cheeks, whip-crack smart, sexy accent, funny, accepting, and ... fucking faithful. “Breathtaking,” he repeated.

“It’s all yours, Max. I want you to do anything you want to it.” She swayed her ass as she spoke and it mesmerized him.

“I’m going to do awful things to it.”

“You’re a big talker.”

“You know I’m not,” he said, unsnapping the clasp that held together the bra of the woman he would marry.

“Hurry up and show me then.”

His hands came around her front and swept up her tight belly to find the swelling goblets of her creamy bosom, his palms scored with the already hard shapes of her strawberry nipples. She moaned with pleasure and leaned her back against his chest. While one hand cupped a heavy breast, the other strayed low and made its way down inside the front of her lacy panties, fingers smoothing over her shaved sex and finding her split, creasing it along her slippery center.

“Keep your heels on,” he told her as he pushed her panties downward. Keely seesawed to help them pass the swell of her hips, then they fell to join her dress, still hooped around her ankles. “I need you so bad, Keely.”

“I need you, Max,” she moaned, bringing a hand up to gently scratch at his cheek over her shoulder.

He walked her toward the foot of the bed, kissing at the nape of her neck, and when they got there, she climbed up and looked over her shoulder

at him. Emerald eyes sparkling in the low lamplight, she gave him a devious yet loving smile, swaying her hips and presenting her glossy, salmon pink sex to him. With a push of his hand against her haunch she rolled over to her back, fan of hair spreading around her, bringing her knees up and cupping her big breasts together with her arms. On the bed on his knees now, he hooked a finger around her lacy panties, drew them off her pointed heels where they'd snagged, kissed her ankles and then down the back of her thighs. She drew her knees to her chest and watched excitedly, waiting to feel his tongue against her favorite part.

She moaned when he parted her, the tip of his tongue working both sides of her hot coppery petals. She was excited, wet, looking for his tongue; he slipped it inside her and she let out a high quavering note.

The points of her heels lowered and dug into the back of his tuxedo jacket. His hands climbed her hips, walking up the bed, and they locked forearms. Him gripping each of hers, she digging her nails into him hard enough he felt them through the fabric. Hips swiveling, she moaned and gasped. Soon, her legs fell to drape over his shoulders.

He looked up her body, saw her head rocking from side to side. His hands came up to clutch her breasts, she joined in, both her hands over top of his, and then he was pushing her, turning her over and she complied. With both her forearms crossed over her chest, she turned over, lay on her stomach thrusting her rump up in the air. She made high girlish sounds that drove him crazy.

The points of his thumbs pushed into her ass cheeks, he spread them apart, turned her glistening slit into a puckering sideways line, bright pink anus winking at him. He attacked her again with his tongue, letting it go wide and slipping up and down. Then he was climbing, getting over top of her, hugging himself to her back, both her breasts mashed together, and he was able to grab both her nipples, gripping them in his hand. While he kissed her, she reached up and cupped the back of his head, her neck craning to meet his lips.

They made out like that, man and future wife, him humping his bulge against her ass cheeks, the two of them writhing in bed together sucking on one another's tongues. She hooked a leg over his hips, opening her sex, inviting his touch.

He ran his hands down her stomach, slipped a finger inside her. She humped against it. Her arm crossed over his, hand gripping his cock

through his pants, stroking it underhanded, growing impatient then grabbing at his belt. Took his finger from inside her, helped her, undid the belt and pulled down the zipper the whole time his mouth locked over hers. They pushed his pants down together, and he found her hand, caressed it with his thumb and then wrapped it around his aching cock. They went up the bed kicking with their heels until their heads were on the pillows. She jerked him and he stroked three fingers up and down her pussy, slipping inside and rolling circles over her clit.

Now she wanted control. Bouncing out of his arms and getting over top of him. He looked up at her and her beautiful smiling face looking down on him. Complete with love and happiness, so understanding, knowing how his heart ached and accepting it. Long hair hung over her shoulders and touched his stomach. She undid his shirt buttons.

Shirt open and parted, she kissed his bare chest, worked her way down his stomach, took the point of her tongue and ran it down the underside of his shaft then sucked a ball into her mouth, her eyes locked on his. He reached down and wove his fingers through her hair running his thumbs up and down her beautiful brow. She took him in her mouth, sinking him fully and he groaned with pleasure and drew his knees up. While she sucked him, he worked his arms out of the tuxedo shirt and jacket and threw them to the floor.

She would suck his cock all night if she thought it would make him happy. But he didn't want that. It was more complex.

"Come here," he whispered, and she looked up, his cock slipped from her mouth. She looked to him questioningly but patient. "I need you," he said. "I want to make love."

Love was what he needed right now. Togetherness, companionship, that connection he felt with her. She fell over top of his chest and kissed him and he put his arms around her and they rolled until he was on top between her legs, her knees up and open. She ran her feet up and down his back.

Then he was inside her. Sliding all the way. She moaned, the sound growing high and tight as he sunk deep. A sample of the cacophony that might come.

"Shh-shh," he whispered, knowing that turned her on, seeing her smile and nod and bite her lower lip. Keely was vocal, and her kink was the anxiety that could bring. He brushed her hair back from her face as he eased himself in and out. Her arms crossed around his neck, her hands bobbing

loosely on either side of his head as he made love to her as slowly as he could. They locked eyes, looking into one another, but each time he went inside her, her eyes narrowed and fluttered and she had to bite back her sounds.

“I love you so fucking much,” he told her.

“I love you too, Max,” she said, her legs squeezing at his sides.

A sudden swell of emotions brought inexplicable tears to his eyes. It was sadness and joy and loss and the bright potential future he had, all one long tangled strand straining from his past, out to his future as long as it may be.

She worked with him, her thrusts meeting his, his hands searching around and finding his bowtie. With wriggling fingers he managed to fold it into a satiny lozenge, brought it to her mouth and she laughed and clamped down. He picked up the pace, getting faster, bringing her anguished sounds of ecstasy. They were muffled around the fabric clenched between her teeth. He explored her with his hands, running all over her body as his hips worked himself in and out of her. She made him so hard; she made him so complete. She was his perfection.

He kept them on the brink, building then waning, feeding from her reactions, tuning in to her joyous screams of pleasure. Sometime an hour later, both of them so drenched in sweat the sheets tangled and clung to them, they both came together. Keely screamed into his saliva-soaked bowtie, the crown of her head thrust into the pillows, every tendon and vein bulging against her creamy, elegant neck. He kissed her—her jaw, her chin—as he shot his seed inside her.

IT WAS three in the morning when he woke again—restless and too warm, sheets damp from their exertion, the fire a little too much for a warm spring night. He got up, slipping himself out from underneath Keely without waking her. Stopped to admire her; the sharp but perfectly feminine features, her long eyelashes, her pouting pink lips, the tangling mane of fiery hair. He ran his hands over her softly, then over the glossy curls that spread out around her on the bedding. If he didn’t have her there would be no way he could’ve made it tonight. No way he could’ve made it the last two years, probably. But she came to him when he needed her and her timing, as usual, was perfect.

He rose, stretching out his arms and back, walking in the dim amber light thrown off by a bed of coals in the brick hearth. Crossing between the pale colorless humps of ornate furniture, he wound his way to the window. On the ledge, sitting on one hip, he leaned to the glass and felt its coolness against his hot sticky body. Below, the remnants of Maggie and Cole's celebration. The lines marking the dance floor removed now, bouquets bundled and brought indoors. The tables remained, bare now, their settings being cleaned by busboys, linens being washed in the laundry. It had been some night. Heart still heavy, he placed his hand over his chest when he saw movement outside.

They'd always had a connection, had it still, and in some paranormal way he was awake to see them now. Cole and Maggie trotting across the very lawn where he'd watched them celebrate their union with a beautiful practiced dance that broke his already hurting heart. Just two pale moonlight figures trotting happily and sneakily across the grass in Poirot robes. Could be anybody but, as he said standing on his speaking-stool, he knew those two better than anyone.

Just ghostly figures, their silhouettes were still imprinted on him forever. He'd seen them in everything, seen them in every way. They trotted down the lawn, crossing the walkway. Looking around, he could tell that they were laughing though he heard nothing. They wound their belts from around the robes and threw them off their shoulders. He knew they would be naked. Then they disappeared. His two best friends off together on their new life. They slipped away, their shimmering pale forms being eclipsed by the grassy knoll running the cliff's edge. They danced naked down the steps along the cliffside to the beach below where he knew that they would go swimming together in the ocean as man and wife.

A brief mournful sob erupted from him suddenly and unexpectedly. He grabbed his mouth with his hand. A tear spilled from one eye and he blinked it away. Things never stay the same and he would be foolish to think they would. A long inhaling groan to strengthen himself, he rose from the ledge and turned his back to them, crossed the room to the perfect naked figure in his bed, her long porcelain limbs lit in the glow of the dying fire's embers.

He slipped in next to her, put an arm around her waist. She covered his hand though she slept. He sniffled and breathed deep and did the best to put it all behind him. One fitful hour later he'd finally fallen asleep.

Epilogue Two

A HONEYMOON

ONE WEEK in Tahiti had left her shoulders peeling. Though her skin took sun reasonably well, she didn't generally like it, preferring paleness to uneven tan lines and the current flaking shorelines on her browning collar, marking pools of rosy pink skin. Tahiti was Cole's idea, and it was a good one, because it gave them peace and privacy, living in a grass-roof suite hoisted above the ocean on stilts. The air was warm, the sun hot, the ocean cool and clear. The first two days, they never even left their bedroom, but since then, they'd been enjoying the amenities.

Today they'd come to the main island of Bora Bora to eat out, get away from the St. Regis, do some shopping and walk around to get some *vertical* exercise. Boat ride across the lagoon to the island, a walk on the sandy beach, Tuna Tartar brunch at the Maikai Yacht Club, and now they were doing some afternoon shopping in the outdoor marketplace.

An easy breeze came off the ocean across the walkway from where she stood; the sun was bright, and she wore a wide-brimmed hat to cut the glare and to further protect her damaged skin. Now she was in a thatch-covered stand, this one selling hand-painted scarves and an assortment of pearl jewelry. The scarves, or pareos, hung from rods where they'd been looped. Between the hut's bay doors, opened wide like wings, a Polynesian woman helped a man select a bracelet from trays she brought out from behind the glass displays. Cole was around somewhere, the last she'd seen him he was trying on raffia fedoras at a T-shirt shop farther up the beach.

Eschewing the more elaborate patterns that maybe catered to the tourists that came off the ships, she chose a deep green pareo with a Polynesian

border across one side, then a blooming spread of traditional *tiares*, white flowers over bright emerald leaves. Paid without dickerings, handing over six-hundred French Pacific francs to the smiling woman, then walked away, tucking her wallet back in the rope purse slung over one shoulder.

A man said to her, "I like your ring."

In reflex, her fist protectively clutched the ring that hung over her heart on a gold chain, feeling violated, knowing immediately the man had been staring at her breasts in their black bikini top, and that this was a come-on.

Only when she looked up, she went weak in the knees, buckling and putting a hand out to support herself against a table arranged with beaded jewelry. Standing on the far side of the table, wind rustling his hair: her Max in a white Oxford and khaki shorts.

Inexplicably, she burst into tears. "Max!" she cried and covered her mouth and nose with both hands.

He came to her immediately, laughing, rounding the table and throwing his arms around her, she clutched him tight.

"What are you doing here?" she asked, her voice still tightened by emotion.

He said, "What are *you* doing here?"

"What?" she laughed, stepping back now and wiping her eyes.

"Why are you crying?" he laughed.

"I don't know," she said, laughing and sniffing, regaining composure.

"The surprise ... *why* are you here?"

"Is this some coincidence or what? I thought you went to Europe."

"Europe ... that's next week ... *what* ...?" She struggled to understand. He just stood there with a big smirk watching her blubber with his hands in his pockets.

"Maggie!" Now she turned to see Keely running along the walkway from the other side of the stall, arms outstretched, lips peeled in a wide and open smile.

"Oh my God," she cried, arms out to receive her, taking her in a big hug, Keely rocking her back and forth.

Keely laughed and sang, "Oh, we got her crying," and continued to hold her tight and sway with her. With the tips of her ring fingers she cleared the wet from her eyes to see Cole now, coming along from the same direction Keely had run, wearing a new straw fedora and his black Ray-bans.

Cole said to Max, "What the hell are you doing here?"

“This is crazy right?” Max said.

Cole turned to her now as she and Keely separated, saying, “Maggie, you see this?—Max is here! And holy shit,” he said now, shaking his head, feigning stunned, “Look, it’s Keely!”

“You can knock it off,” she said.

Cole took Max now in a big hug, the two of them laughing and rocking together as she and Keely had just done. Max slapped Cole’s back over and over. They each exchanged their cooing, *Hey, buddys*, while they embraced. Keely stood at her side now, rubbing her hand over her bare shoulder. She said, “I take it this was a surprise.”

She said, “*What* are you doing here?”

Max parted from Cole, reached in his pocket and withdrew a pair of tortoiseshell glasses. He said, “This guy forgot his glasses in Rhode Island,” and passed them to Cole.

“Thanks, buddy,” Cole said. “Long way to come for glasses, but I appreciate it. These are my favorite ones,” he winked, transferring them to the pocket of his own shorts.

Maggie sighed with exasperation, watching the two of them. “Seriously, what is *happening*?”

Cole cocked his head, and took off his sunglasses, stepping to her and putting his arms around her. “Surprise, Maggie.”

She rocked in his strong arms and squeezed him tight. “That’s a great surprise,” she whispered in his ear. “Thank you.”

“They came in to Motu Mute this morning, so I had to get us over to the island ...”

“Where are you staying?” she asked Max.

“With you.”

“What? ...”

Cole said, “They’re in already. Flew in this morning, I took you out for brunch so these two ... you know, could get their bags in and everything, move in to our suite.”

She slapped at her own cheeks, bewildered. “Cole, you’re the best,” she laughed, kissing the hot skin of his bare upper arm. “God, we’re going to have so much fun.”

“I need a hat like yours,” Keely said to her, holding a hand over her brow to shield the bright sun leaking over the top of her sunglasses and

making her squint. She was white-skinned, almost alabaster, her bare arms glowing in the sunlight.

Cole took the straw fedora off and plopped it over Keely's head, her long ginger ponytail swinging in the breeze. She unfurled the emerald pareo she'd just purchased and snapped it till it was unfolded and flapping in the breeze, folded it in a triangle then wrapped it over Keely's shoulders to protect her skin from the same punishment on her own shoulders.

Keely turned her back to her, one hand holding Cole's fedora in place as another breeze kicked up, and Maggie reached around her front to tie a loose knot in the scarf.

"It's so beautiful here," Keely sang, tilting her gaze up inland, looking at the two jagged points of the tiny island's extinct volcano, Pahia and Otemanu. She kissed Maggie's wrist.

Cole said, "You guys hungry? You eat?"

Max looked at his watch, said, "We had a little on the plane to Tahiti, but we haven't had lunch."

"How about an early dinner?" Maggie said.

Cole said, "Look at this guy," stepping closer to Max and grabbing his wrist. "You got it?"

"Came by courier a few days ago," Max said, turning his hand so Cole could admire his steel watch, the two of them developing a recent fetishization for vintage timepieces.

"Hey. It's waterproof, right?"

Max said, "What ...? Yeah, it's a Submar—"

Cole dipped at the knees and wrapped his arms around Max's thighs and hoisted him right up off his feet.

"What the fuck!" Max laughed, his hands gripping the back of Cole's shoulders, looking at Keely and her with a shocked but happy face.

Now Cole ran, pausing to look both ways at the pedestrian walkway in case they would get clipped by a bicycle, trotting across, stepping carefully over a curb, sneaking between two close palm tree trunks, and then down a short grassy hill. Then he was on the beach, running with Max still lifted up and holding on to him, both of them laughing and yelling.

Keely laughed too, watching through her sunglasses, then putting an arm around Maggie's shoulders. She said, "It would be funnier if they were closer to the water, you know?"

Maggie held Keely's wrist, said, "I know. It's an awful long way to the beach."

Cole still ran, their yelling growing faint and lost in the wind. They still weren't at the ocean.

Keely said, "You think Max would struggle a bit more. Put up a fight."

Maggie chuckled as her husband and Max finally, soundlessly, made it to the shore, Cole leaping into a wave and the two of them being swallowed by foaming splashes, arms and legs poking out through the water. She said, "He let's Cole get away with everything. He likes it."

IN DRY CLOTHES NOW, both him and Cole, they ate at the restaurant at the St. Regis. Maggie bought them towels at a beach-side stand, saying the taxi would never take them like that—dripping wet, acting like a couple of college kids on Spring Break—but smirking the whole time. They rode back to the resort and went to the suite and changed into dry clothes, Maggie and Keely going ahead to the restaurant to get a table.

Now they were all together in the restaurant, a Jean-Georges, at a window-side table on the lagoon-side shore of the Moto Piti A'au looking across the water at the darkening jugged shape of the main island's dormant volcano as the sun passed the high point and sunk toward the west. The sky still a brilliant baby blue with cottony, sunlit clouds, the teal water of the lagoon was choppy and shot with dashing white arrows.

With Maggie and Cole sitting together on one side, he sat next to Keely. Maggie wore the pareo now to cover her bikini top, Keely appropriately attired in the same light dress she'd worn on the little plane from Tahiti to Bora Bora. As a table, they split appetizers; Sautéed Reef Octopus with jalapeño, seared duck foie gras with papaya chutney, and avocados with scallop sashimi. Two bottles of wine on the table; a Languedoc Picpoul and a Spanish Albariño. He offered to buy them dinner but Cole told him the whole thing goes on the tab; the restaurant being on the resort. Martin would be footing the bill, and it must be enormous, a month-long honeymoon at five-star accommodations.

"How was your first week being married?" Keely asked Maggie.

“Blissful,” she said, eyes sparkling as she took a sip of the Picpoul. Cole and Maggie held their inward facing hands together, fingers interwoven, Maggie’s engagement ring and brand new wedding band winking in the candlelight. Cole raised their conjoined hands and kissed her knuckles.

“God, how cliché,” Max laughed. “So where next?”

Cole said, “One week with you guys here, then we go to Tuscany for five days ...”

Maggie finished, “and then Paris for ten.”

Keely, eyes rolled up with the sweet pleasure of the vanilla with the duck liver, said, “Mm, sounds so amazing.”

Max said, “And have you decided? ...”

Maggie stabbed a piece of avocado in her mouth, said, “Work?”

“Yeah.”

“Google.”

He said, “I told you.”

“You did,” she laughed. “They don’t want me till the new year.”

“Free time,” Keely sang happily.

Cole mourned, “Yeah, but I’m back to work.”

“Bummer,” Max said, Cole acting as an in-house assistant hedge fund attorney at Oxbow.

Keely said in a hushed tone: “So did you guys even get out of bed this week?”

Maggie laughed and said, “Enough to burn my shoulders,” tugging away the pareo to reveal the sunburn he’d noted earlier. Cole leaned to her and kissed the new and pink skin. Maggie caressed his cheek, her Cartier bangles singing on her wrist.

“The villa is unbelievable,” Keely said. When the two of them arrived from the airport this morning, sneaking into the suite to deposit their belongings, neither of them could believe the place, Keely pretending to swoon at its extravagance and him catching her. They made out a little before getting into a cab and meeting up on the other side of the island, in text contact with Cole.

“Isn’t it amazing?” Maggie asked. Then to Cole: “Is that why you booked the six-person suite? How long did you know they were coming?”

Cole shrugged and chuckled it off. “I don’t know. A couple of months.”

Keely said to him, “And you and Max think I can’t keep secrets.”

Cole winked and reached across to hold her chin, he wiped a dot of papaya from the corner of her pink lips. “You did good, kid.”

Maggie clutched her two hands below her chin, and Max flinched, getting caught in her direct stare. “I couldn’t be happier,” she said to him. “My two favorite people in the world.”

A NARROW WOOD deck ran from the restaurant’s exit out into the lagoon’s brilliant turquoise water. Extending out from shore it came to a T and together the four of them turned left, still chatting and enjoying each other’s company. The lagoon here was interspersed with thatch-roofed villas, sitting up on their concrete legs, and ahead was the Premier Villa, their private space for the last week. Beyond the roof of their villa the peak of Mount Otemanu poked, almost black now against a blood orange sky, its dual spires eclipsing the low looming sun.

The deck ended at the door to their villa, Cole ahead, opening it and ushering everyone in. Cole said, “Everyone grab a seat and let’s *relax*,” extending the word *relax* like it was the most important thing ever.

She asked Max: “You must be jet-lagged.”

“Pooped,” he admitted, pausing at the glass inset in the wooden floor that showed the waters of the lagoon below. Even though daylight dimmed, floodlights shone from below the villa to illuminate the sub-aquatic goings-on. He stood with his legs astride the glass, like he was afraid to rest his weight on it, ghostly blue light shining from below him. As she approached, Keely bounded over to join him, coming to his side and hugging him, watched as he watched down between his legs. The light from below filled the inside of her dress and she could see the silhouette of her tall shapely body under the fabric.

“What are you looking at?” Keely asked Max.

“Something moved down there,” Max told her.

Maggie joined them while Cole turned on some Stravinsky, keeping it low. On Max’s other side, she peered down as well.

“Nurse shark,” she said, as the black, distinctly shark-shaped shadow streaked past.

“Oh my God,” Keely said, stepping her sandals back an inch farther from the glass’s edge.

Cole said, “Don’t worry, they’re friendly. Not like man-eaters or anything.” He stood at their mini-bar and kitchen, opening the fridge and pulling out a bottle of white.

Keely said, “Well, I guess I won’t be swimming this week,” as she crossed to the black wicker couch and sat herself down, pulled off her sandals and crossed her long legs.

“You’ll be fine,” Maggie said, going to the couch, plopping down next to her so they were hip to hip.

Keely put an arm around her shoulders, saying, “Will you protect me?”

“You won’t see them during the day.”

Max joined them as well, sitting at an angle to them on the lime green cushion of an ottoman. Cole brought the chilled bottle and four wine glasses, setting them down on the table in front of the couch.

“Amazing dinner?” Cole asked, dropping to sit in a bright fuchsia cushioned armchair that faced them.

Keely said to her, “I can’t believe you didn’t have any of the kulfi. It was *cinnamon*,” emphasizing the flavor as her point of disbelief.

Cole said, “She went off sugar almost completely now.”

Maggie nodded and smiled, and Keely said, “Good for you.”

Max was watching her and he smiled warmly. “I remember a time Maggie would finish off a pizza and beers with a chocolate brownie covered in ice cream.”

Cole punctuated it with a wink to Max. “Sublimating.”

It made her laugh, and she threw her head back at the fond memory.

Keely laughed too. “Altieri’s,” she said with respect.

They were all silent for a moment, and she watched Max as he smiled across the table at her. Grown-up Max, doing very well for himself, but she always knew he would. Looking good and in shape, black T-shirt and gray shorts, his expensive watch. Handsome too, as always, some of that cuteness falling away as he continued to mature, exposing some of the man inside. It wouldn’t have been too bad to be with Max. Not too bad at all. Where would she be now? Safe in his home, free to pursue the things she’d used when she was a kid to escape. Would she still play the cello? Paint? God, the last time she held a brush was the fight with Carol. She’d handed one to her, saying, You show me how you paint. Carol didn’t shrink from

the challenge, but didn't accept it. Set the brush down, a smile showing she'd been caught, but also somehow showing victory. Carol had *never* been an artist. Just a mastermind sowing seeds of doubt. Worst thing was the bolstering pride she'd felt knowing that Carol had recognized her daughter's perception and appreciated it greatly. Carol still winning somehow even though Maggie thought the victory had gone to her. Carol winning the war, not the battle.

The sad longing in Max's eyes though betrayed that old deeply imbedded weakness. An unmovable sliver in his psyche that she imagined he would always have till the day he died. Thought that because she knew she would have it too, or at least her own version of it. There was an almost intangible bond between them, something neither one of them could sever no matter how bad they may be to each other. It *couldn't* be severed. It ran both ways between them like an umbilical. Whatever travelled its spectral membranes nourished both of them.

They stared into one another's eyes, smiling at each other almost to laughter. Finally, Max said, "You know what we should do? End of summer, Cole takes a weekend off, before Maggie goes to work ... we head up to the Schroon Lodge."

Cole nodded with a happy face, looking at each of them in turn.

Maggie said, "We should. We have to." Then delivering the bad news: "Martin's selling the Schroon Lodge next year."

Keely whined, "No-oo, I love the Schroon Lodge," and snuggled against her.

Cole laughed and said, "Buy it for her, Max."

He said, "Maybe in ten years. Way, way, way out of my price range."

Cole said, "We haven't been to your vacation place yet."

That reminded Keely, and she blurted: "Maxy bought me a boat."

Maggie said, "Bought you a boat?"

Max muttered, "I've been working while you two were fucking around at school for four years."

Keely said, "Well, *us* a boat, for the cottage, but he named it after me."

Cole said quickly, "The SS Firecrotch?"

Keely's features fell in a mimicry of shock and great offense. Her mouth formed an O, and she looked to Maggie for support, then back to Cole. With her fingers, she took the hem of her short little summer dress's skirt and

pulled it upward, parting her legs. She said, “You don’t see any flames here, do you?”

Maggie leaned forward to see Keely wore no underwear. She stroked her hand up the inside of Keely’s thigh, and she let her legs fall open a little wider. The tips of her fingers stroked up Keely’s pretty labia, hot, not yet wet, but inviting just the same. Keely turned back to face her, eyes narrow and lusty from the things Maggie did between her legs. Max and Cole’s faces were frozen in stupor. Max swallowed dryly.

She said to Keely, “You shaved your flames off for me?”

Keely nodded, lips parted.

Maggie parted her own lips and the two girls came together slowly and kissed, her taking Keely’s pouting pinks and running her tongue between them. Keely accepted it lovingly, moaning, her hand coming up and gently holding the side of Maggie’s face while her finger stroked a little slickness from her.

Now she had everyone’s complete attention.

MAX’S PULSE ABSOLUTELY THUNDERED. It had been a very long time since they’d all been together like this. More than eight months. Not since his mother died.

In the cushioned armchair next to him, Cole adjusted his shorts, breaths as deep and steady as his own. On the couch, an arm’s length away, the love of his life kissed his fiancée with an open mouth. Maggie in her green pareo, the material parting in a V at the chest to reveal her perfect little breasts in their black bra and an engagement ring strung on a chain he’d given her a lifetime ago when he thought she could be his. It sparked a twinkling white star off its diamond.

One gleaming leg crossed over the other, printed tropical skirt that fell to her knee, her graceful arm working her hand between his future wife’s legs. Keely’s long legs parted wider, letting Maggie work; her chest heaved with lusty breath and their two mouths made slow smacking sounds. They parted, looking at each other, Maggie’s smile serious, and her fingers still working her opening, making Keely giggle shyly now.

Keely exhaled shakily, her hips working against Maggie's touch, then she turned and caught him and Cole staring lustily. With her lips sucked in her mouth, she hummed light laughter and drew her skirt to cover what Maggie did. Maggie leaned close and whispered something in her ear, Keely nodding. Now she rose, standing above him, her eyes on Cole; Max saw her fingers searching for him and he held her hand, pulled it and kissed the back, her engagement ring poking him under the chin.

Still standing, she bent to him, holding his hand, touching his face before kissing him. He took her kiss, sucked her lower lip, took her tongue, smelling Maggie and tasting her. With one more kiss on the top of his head, Keely went around the table now, eyes on Cole. Maggie's eyes watched Keely's bottom and long legs as she made her way to Cole, then darted up to meet Max's as he watched her. She smiled.

Cole leaned back in the armchair, chin turned up to watch her come to him. Keely bit her lower lip, put a leg on either side of Cole's thighs then mounted him, walking her knees onto the cushion, her face turned down to Cole's, her long ponytail swaying over her back. She caressed Cole's face, running her thumbs over his brow, his cheekbones, jawline, pushing down then on his plump lower lip.

Keely darted her face, wanting to tease, catching Cole's lower lip between her teeth and pulling gently. Cole smiled wide, looking in her eyes, the widening breaking his lips from her clutch. Her nails stroked through his hair as his hands held her narrow waist.

Keely said, "I heard you've been abstaining."

Cole chuckled. "Before the wedding," he said.

Keely's hips began to sway, rubbing herself against Cole's crotch, something surely hardening there.

Cole said, "We made up for lost time this week."

Keely's hips humped, driving and curling forward and backward. "I hope you've left something for me." Then with a few more swivels of her hips, added: "It feels like you're ready for more."

"Three months was a long time," he said, smiling, eyes sparkling under his lashes. Now the hands that held her waist slipped over the curves of her round ass, lifting her soft cotton skirt, Keely leaning forward, exposing her anus and glistening petals to him and Maggie. Cole's middle finger stroked her opening as they resumed their kissing. Maggie watched through narrowed eyes, directly across from them, sunk low in the couch with one

leg still crossed over the other. She smiled, hand dropping to pat the couch seat where Keely had been sitting, inviting him to come and join her.

MAX CAME TO HER, rising, staying hunched, falling to the cushioned seat next to her, his legs clamped closed, his hands clutched together between them. She watched him a moment as he watched the girl he loved gyrate her sex against Cole. That familiar pinched tension in his face; excitement, lust, worry. She laughed and clutched his forearm; he faced her, cheeks reddening, chuckling quietly, eyebrows drawn up with anxiety, then returning to watch as her handsome husband eased his middle finger inside Keely and she made a high mewling sound.

Keely's arrival in their lives had been fortuitous. A consolation gift for Max. One of Cole's young Farmingham hand-me-downs. Keely came from Dublin to attend Farmingham; transferred after her second year to Harvard, headed for law school. Three years younger than them but traveling in the same circles she and Cole did in Cambridge, they got to know her. She was fun, funny, sweet. Caring. One weekend Max visited they introduced her to him and thusly introduced Max to his independence. Keely was a big hit and the greatest and kindest thing they could do for their best friend who they both loved so much. It was Keely's special spirit that saved Max and made her such a loving part of their group.

Max's wrist trembled under her fingers and she pulled his hand free from the vise of his thighs, wove her fingers through his and Max held her tight, eyes locked now on what her Cole did to his fiancée. Her husband had two fingers inside her now, glistening, and Keely's thighs trembled. She pulled his shirt up, bearing his warm stomach, and one hand worked at undoing the button of his shorts. Max's hand shook as much as Keely's thighs and she closed his hand in both of hers, watching the side of his immobile face, seeing the lust he had, the tragic enjoyment he took watching Keely with Cole. The only way he could care is if he loved Keely and for that she was so grateful; he needed someone like Keely in his life.

Max shifted in his seat; Cole's zipper being drawn down made a distinct sound over the soft noises of rustling fabric, moans, and kissing. She turned

to see Keely taking Cole's cock out of the parted flaps of his fly. He was fully hard, throbbing; he liked Keely and he like to be watched.

Keely sighed, whispered, "Oh, you're so hard," hand lightly stroking him.

Cole's hands cupped the pale globes of her bare ass, fingertips denting their softness, her skirt bundled at her waist. Keely looked over her shoulder, just her sly eyes visible, looking for her husband. "He's gonna fuck me, Max," she said.

Max nodded to Keely, cheeks sunken, eyes staring.

She gave his hand a squeeze, and he squeezed her back, eyes still on Cole and his fiancée. Keely's hand clumsily held Cole's girth, angling him so his covered glans rested in her bright pink stripe. Her own gaze became frozen on the garish point of contact; her husband and the girl she felt genuine love for.

Keely's hand let him go, his cock seated in her membranes. She sunk a little, his girth too much, and they both shifted. Keely grunted, and complained, rocked forward, held his cock again and wiggled her hips to work him inside her. She laughed at that difficulty, saying in a sing-song, "I forgot what a great big boy you are," her accent coming on strong.

Cole's hand appeared to help, taking a hold of his base and pushing his hips upward. Keely's fingertips teased his shaft as he slowly sunk inside her. She squeaked and squawked, made high noises of pain as she let her body sink down his shaft.

"Oh, you're so big," Keely sighed as she took him.

Max grunted next to her, his hand suddenly gripping her far too hard and pinching her fingers, sending bolts of pain shooting into her hand.

"Ow, Max, Ow," she laughed, slapping at his hand with the other.

"Sorry," he whispered, eyes glued on his Keely.

She reached over and put her hand over his heart, running it in circles, making him smile (but not look away). He chuckled in his throat, brought his other hand free from where it was pinched and lay it over hers. She kissed his shoulder.

"I love her, Max," she whispered. "I love her for you—she's so good ..."

"She is," he said, "she's so good for me. I love her."

Holding hands with the boy—now a man—she once thought she would marry, and who she loved so endlessly, she watched as Cole fucked Max's

fiancée.

Keely was still adapting to Cole's thickness, not kissing him, her face instead buried in his neck making muffled sounds of discomfort, though her hips worked to meet his thoughtfully slow thrusts. Cole's hands caressed her back, coming down and pulling up on the skirt, easing the light cottony fabric up her pale body and over her head, having to pull it far to the side to get her long gingery ponytail free.

Cole took the point of one of her swaying breasts in his mouth and Keely gasped, rearing up now, cradling it for him and feeding him the nipple. She'd grown accustomed to his size now, getting into it and breathing heavy, muscles of her back working as she hugged herself against Cole's intrusion. Her pink ring gulped around her husband's big beautiful cock, leaving it shining. When he withdrew, he pulled a thin layer of her membranes like a tight sleeve. The sound they made grew breathy; more gasping, more utterances of affirmation. Soon they were kissing, and Cole's hands smoothed all over Keely's back, down to her ass cheeks and pulling her wide, knowing Max and her were watching his cock go in and out of her.

The two of them got themselves bouncing, the chair's feet squeaking on the wood floor. Keely began her loud vocalizations. Cole called her a 'screamer,' and when she got going, she could become piercing. Even Max was known to make her wild; sometimes Maggie envied her exuberance—she really did get taken away, it wasn't an act, and Keely once confided to her an embarrassment over it. Cole and Max, however, loved it.

As it built between them, Keely's gasps becoming shrieks and Cole trying to cover her mouth, she leaned to Max and asked, "She's still on the pill?"

"Yeah, of course," he whispered, eyes still on the coupling.

Keely collapsed onto Cole, holding both her hands over her mouth, shrieking into them, her face turned to the side toward Cole, Cole had her ass cheeks pulled up, driving his hips into her at triple time, knowing she was close. His big balls had worked out of the open shorts and they came up to slap and bounce against her wetly with each hard thrust. While Keely's face lay on his chest, he tucked his chin down to watch her expression.

Then she was coming—her thighs clamping against Cole's hips, her body bucking and squirming, screaming out brightly.

“Ow,” Maggie said again, laughing, shaking Max’s hand to stop him from breaking her fingers.

On the chair, her husband held Max’s girl while she still writhed in orgasm, shaking and gasping, crying out and slowly slumping down Cole’s body.

The muscles of her own stomach flexed, feeling a sympathetic erotic surge that brought sudden heat to her upper lip and also down below. Now she worked her hand out from Max’s and sat straighter. Keely slumped further down Cole’s lap, still breathing heavy. She looked over her shoulder again, eyeing both of them, cheeks flushed, eyes twinkling with mirth as she got on her knees on the floor. With her hands reached up and tucked in Cole’s waistband she worked the shorts down his legs while he lifted his hips for her, shrugging out of his T-shirt. His cock swayed side-to-side stiffly, still steely hard. Keely now walked her fingers up his thighs. Then her mouth was over him, Cole’s head falling back to rest on the chair, arms on the rests. Keely’s head bobbed, her ponytail swishing pendulously across her creamy back.

She and Max watched Keely work for a while, her turning her shoulders so Max could get a look at what she did, one hand holding Cole’s scrotum, the other stroking just below her sucking mouth. The slurping sound of her mouth came to suction as she let it plop from her, hand stroking quickly, Cole’s balls bouncing, and Keely turned so they could both see, her eyes on Maggie. She said to her, “I could use some help here,” winking at her, nodding her head toward the cock in her hand.

Cole came instantly alert, sitting straighter, fidgeting in the chair and fixing his excited eyes on hers, ecstatic to have two girls go down on him at the same time. She laughed hard, moving closer to the sofa’s edge, thinking of joining, appreciating the invitation, but she had to deal with something before the night went any further.

Hands rubbing circles on her knees, she promised: “Later.”

Keely frowned and pouted with comical petulance.

Maggie said, “Could you two go in the bedroom—leave me and Max to talk?”

Keely looked to Cole, and they both nodded at each other. “Yeah,” Cole said, sitting up and scooting forward. Max did the same next to her, scooting forward to sit on the edge of the couch seat. Cole rose to stand, proudly erect, his cock aimed upright, holding a hand to help Keely stand.

His eyes traveled to Max, and he nodded with brow furrowed; an expression asking Max if he was all right. Max nodded affirmation.

Then, everything cool, Cole was fun again, taking one of Keely's breasts in each hand, stooping and kissing between them, Keely laughing, swaying her hips and running her fingers through his hair. With his hands on her hips now, he guided her to sit on the chair's arm, Keely unsure of what he wanted but complying. He put his palms on the inside of her thighs and she spread wide for him. The head of his cock tapped down her soft tummy into her hot wet nest and he pushed it into her.

She hissed, said, "Oh God, oh fuck," as he sank inside her, turning to Maggie and snarling, "Fuck, he's thick," doing it for her fiancé's sake. Now Cole guided her legs to close around his waist and he told her to hold onto him. With her arms around his neck, he stood with her clinging to him, Keely crying out as his cock fully seated inside her with her sinking body weight. Cole's muscle stood out, the fanning blades of muscle in his thighs and calves, the bumps and knots of his back. She missed his long hair sometimes, but fuck he looked sexy and grown-up now.

With Keely wrapped to him, standing sideways to them, now he fucked her, making Keely's eyes go wide, making her gasp as she and Max watched his balls sway, his thick thing working in and out of her with slick wet sounds. Cole growled then and kissed her neck, making her shriek. He walked toward the bedroom, stopping to pin her against the wall and thrust in and out a few more times, Keely crying out and knocking a picture crooked with her elbow. Then Cole had her again, walking, passing through the doorway to the master bedroom, Keely looking to Max and making grabby hands at him, saying, "Hurry up, Maxy, don't be long."

Max nodded, said, "Keep the door open, please."

As Cole and Keely disappeared into the dark, she heard Keely tell Cole, "Keep the door open."

From the dark, Cole said, "Yeah," then shouted out to them, "Don't be long." The sound of their two bodies collapsing on the bed came next, some giggling; shortly thereafter, gasping and moaning.

THE ENDS of his fingers still tingled with the electricity of seeing Keely with Cole, his heart still thumped in his eardrums. The sounds coming from the bedroom now—the sheets rustling, his fiancée’s building cries—demanded him to come and witness ... what he most wanted right now, however, was whatever Maggie needed. She was looking at him sideways, elbows on her knees, hands clasped together, head hung low, turned to face him, smiling nervously, her russet hair tumbling down in her lap.

“What?” he asked, sensing something big she needed to broach, and the slightest slither of worry work through his insides.

Keely gasped out from the bedroom.

Maggie’s hands wrung together as she drew the moment out. The pareo had slipped down her arm and exposed the circular pools of pink new skin.

He inched himself closer, wanting to ease whatever burden she looked to unload on him right now. Peering at the sun’s damage to her shoulders, he shook his head.

“Is it bad?” she asked him.

“Mm, it’s okay,” he said, looking it over. “Does it hurt?”

“Itches,” she said.

“You have any lotion?”

She held his gaze and smiled. “Yeah,” she said then, bouncing her head in a happy nod, reaching down and opening her purse. She turned back and handed him a small plastic bottle of fancy cocoa butter. She shifted in her seat, pointing her back to him, untying the pareo and tossing it over the couch’s arm. Her back was bare, just the black strings of her bikini top crossing over it.

Top flipped on the lotion, he squeezed a generous portion, stomach tightening at the proximity to touching her. As he lay his hand softly on her shoulder, he said, “You looked beautiful up there.”

“Where?” she asked him, turning her head, eyes lowered to watch his hand sooth her shoulder.

“The altar,” he said. “You are a beautiful bride.”

“Thanks, Max,” she said, her voice quiet and delicate. “That was my second favorite dress,” she said, her eyes coming up to meet his. The point of her warm shoulder felt exquisite against his palm. With his index finger he pulled the black string over till it fell down her arm.

“Second favorite?” he said.

She winced, but said anyway: “You should have seen the dress I chose for our wedding.”

He grunted, his stomach tightening suddenly, making a grimace.

“Sorry,” she whispered, her expression showing warmth. Sadness too, Maggie not intending to hurt him with that.

Now from the bedroom: high desperate gasps from Keely in syncope with the quick slapping of flesh on flesh, making him think Cole had her on all fours.

She whispered, “Max ...?”

His hands kept running in circles over her perfect skin, not answering her, sensing what was to come.

“I’m pregnant, Max.”

Hands paused, one on each of her bare shoulders, he stopped and breathed. The room was ominously quiet, his mind blocking out the sounds of Keely and Cole and hearing now the very solitary sound of the whoosh-whoosh in his eardrums. Another piece of his hopes and dreams fell away. Monumental tons of ice cleaving from the whole, falling off the Arctic shelf, and soon there would be nothing but endless ocean.

Bold now, his hands slipped down her body, around her waist, and came together over her belly, where the seed of another man grew. She leaned back, and he held her as her warm hands came to cover his. Her skin under his palms was warm and tight, her belly hard and muscled these days.

She whispered, “I want to have fun this week, but I needed you to know first.”

With his chin nestled in the space between her collar and her neck, he nodded, breathing her in. He kissed her shoulder where she was new, the growing pink skin hot on his lips, but so soft and pure.

“Are you happy for me?” she asked.

He said, “Is there any chance that it’s mine?”

Her tummy bounced with laughter under his hands and she ran her thumbs over his knuckles. “When was the last time we had sex? I mean penis in vagina sex,” she whispered.

“I don’t know,” he sighed. “Uh, we were in ... it was in Michigan.” God, the three of them consoled him; he cried and cried when his mother decided she wouldn’t fight anymore, and they stayed in the hotel bed all day and overnight with him.

She said, “So, eight months ago. I’m not even four months along.”

“Shoot,” he said, making her chuckle again.

Now she turned but stayed in his arms, her hand coming up to cup his cheek as she looked in his eyes. “I wouldn’t be upset if it was yours.”

“Me neither,” he said.

She smiled till her eyes went to lines. “Cole might. But I was on the pill back then, we were careful.” Then smile fading to serious, she said, “I want Cole’s baby. This was planned.”

“I can dream,” he said with comical wistfulness, putting his hand over his heart, turning his eyes to the stars.

She laughed and kissed his chin. “You’re okay?”

“Yes,” he lied. Maybe one day he would be. “That’s why you don’t start Google till the new year.”

She nodded. In the bedroom, Keely’s sounds grew to loud squeals and then went muffled like Cole had put fabric in her mouth.

With a deep but shaky breath, he said, “I’m really happy for you two. I am. You’re going to be a great mom.”

She said, “I hope so,” running her hand over his. “It’s half Cole so I’m going to have to watch it like a hawk.”

Now he hugged her a little tighter, and let one hand ease high, slipping under her untied dangling bra and cupping a breast. The pad of his thumb ran a circle around her soft puckering nipple. He kissed her neck, said, “Would you make love with me tonight?”

Head tilting away, she softly sighed. “I’m a married woman now, Max.”

“That’s okay,” he said, appreciating the circumstances.

But her head fell back to rest against his shoulder and she looked at him sideways. “I’d like to give you a blowjob.”

It got his fingertips tingling again. He said, “Can I go down on you?”

She nodded, said, “Yeah,” and laughed. “Yeah, you can do that.”

She stood and held a hand out to him, topless, smiling and fresh like she had been in college (it seemed so long ago), affable and sweet even though she was lean now, competitive too, and getting the reputation of not being fun to deal with if you didn’t know her. The teal light from the lamp-lit ocean below the villa shone up through the glass insert and lit her in eery wavering blue. Hand out, she took it and he rose. They passed over the glass floor and something dark and frightening flashed down there again, quickening his step, but soon they were crossing the threshold to the bedroom, holding hands, and there in the bed were his other two best

friends. Keely lay on her back with a mouthful of bedsheets and her knees drawn up, Cole was between her legs, the muscles of his ass flexing as he pushed his big cock in and out of her. He kissed at her collar and held a breast, and she ran her nails over his back in excited circuits, crying into the cotton.

WHEN THEY ENTERED the room together, Keely seemed seized by orgasm. Maggie knew the face, that expression she took, almost sorrowful, saw that she had clamped between her teeth a huge bundle of crisp white cotton bedsheet. Her brows turned up as if in mourning, head thrust back into the mattress, the muscles of her neck flexing. Her chest was cast in rosy blotches and she writhed while Maggie's husband pumped his hips between her legs. She knew too, from the way Cole pushed himself in and held, withdrew and did it over again, the whole time his eyes gauging his lover's response.

While Keely enjoyed it, Cole laughing softly and quietly winking at Maggie and kissing one of Keely's big breasts, she let Max's hand go and pushed her skirt down, taking her panties along with it. Then up on the bed on her knees, Cole heaving over, his cock pulling out of Keely with a slick mucous sound and slapping wetly onto his belly as he sprawled out, also breathing heavy.

Maggie walked on her knees as Max came around the other side of the bed watching Keely with a smile on his face. He went to Cole, leaned close while squatting down and slapping his shoulder and whispering in his ear. Cole beamed and covered Max's hand.

Maggie took Keely's ankle and lifted her leg up, her knee coming to her chest, walking herself in between so their legs would interlock. She squatted down, letting her pussy slip along Keely's. Found her very hot and slick opening, got their petals to touch, winding her hips in circles as Keely's eyes fluttered open. When she saw Maggie, she said, "Oh, I think I'm in trouble now."

Maggie laughed and pressed her pubic bone into Keely then leaned forward and kissed her lips. Keely began to respond, holding the back of her neck, taking Maggie's tongue, her own hips beginning to swivel and

work her soft membranes against Maggie's. Max was close to them now, still kneeling down, looking to her and saying, "Can I tell her?"

Maggie bit her lip, anticipating this, and she nodded for him. He took Keely's hand, and she turned her head, looking at him upside down. Max said to her, "Maggie's pregnant."

The reaction was instantaneous: she gasped, shocked, with open-mouth her head whipped around and the joy was unmistakable. It looked like she would burst into tears. She shimmied backward, sat up and thrust her arms around Maggie and clung herself, saying, "Oh my God, oh my God, I can't believe it!"

Maggie fell on her back, let herself be hugged. Keely went on exuberantly, nonsensically, "I knew it, I knew it. Oh my God, I'm so happy!" She writhed down the mattress and kissed Maggie over her navel, suckling on it, looking at her belly as if she could see what was in there. Now she whined, "*I want to be pregnant,*" and looked to Max.

Cole laughed at that, turned to Max and reached a hand out to punch him on the shoulder. Max groaned. "We have to get married first," he said.

Cole rolled his eyes and said, "Do you?" They'd had to make changes in order for her to accept the job she wanted.

Keely turned to Cole now, said, "I'm so happy for you," and she smoothed a hand on his chest and pet him lightly. They pecked lips.

"Thanks," Cole said. "I'm so excited."

Looking up to Max now, Keely said in a soft voice, "Isn't that amazing? Isn't it?"

He nodded, and though Maggie could see that he was still hurting, she saw that he was happy. Keely reached to him and touched his face, and he held her hand. Keely rolled over, bringing a knee up and exposing her round creamy bottom and Maggie smacked it. Keely made an appreciative sound, a long low moan, turning over on her belly and looking over her shoulder at her while Max still held her hand.

Maggie lowered her lips, kissed her soft cheeks, Keely flexing from side to side, making her ass sway. Max disrobed at the foot of the bed while he watched her. Maggie liked it when he watched, liked when Cole watched too. When she kissed Keely, she controlled them completely. Keely was receptive, loved it, but what was more exciting was the absolute and powerful silence—Cole and Max mesmerized, locked on what she did.

She parted Keely's legs, walking her knees up between Keely's knees, Keely kicking her legs wider and Maggie running her hand up the inside of her thigh until she found where Cole had left her loose. Her lips damp and pulled and stretched, Maggie ran her knuckle up and down until she found the seam and slipped two of her thin fingers inside her. Keely kicked her legs and giggled. The giggle became a long lustful moan.

Max was frozen, standing there naked now with his erection throbbing, watching what her hand did to his fiancée. Cole lay to the side, propped up on one elbow, his eyes lost and glossy like a magician had hypnotized him. A vague smirk skewed his lips. But instead of doing what they wanted, she like to keep them frustrated. At least Max. She crawled up Keely's back and lay flat on her, running her hands up and down her arms and shoulders. She whispered in her ear loud enough for them to hear, "I think you've had your turn."

Keely sighed, resigned, "Yeah. I did at that."

Maggie lifted herself off Keely's back now and began kissing her husband's stomach. He lay back, compliant, like a dog wanting its belly scratched, and Keely came to join her, both of them making soft kisses around his hard stomach, his throbbing cock between their cheeks. She looked at him and said, "Somebody's close, aren't they?"

Cole laughed and let his head fall back in the sheets. She gripped his cock and lowered her mouth to suck one of his balls, running her tongue around its shape, feeling Keely's hand go over hers, Keely getting close to her until their shoulders touched. Maggie took his other ball now, letting the other one sag, the sound of Keely's lips smacking as she put Cole back in her mouth.

Cole groaned and ran his hands over both of their heads while they pleased him. Keely offered Cole to her now, letting her lips pop off her husband's swollen glans and aiming the cock towards her mouth. Maggie smiled, and while Keely held it, ran her tongue up and down, her eyes on Cole and what this pleasure did for him. He looked like he was ready to explode, his face twisted almost as if in pain.

Keely stroked a little more, took her turn, ran her tongue up one side, Maggie joining in and letting her tongue work the other. Keely's fingertips pulled his foreskin down, his glans bared, the slit seeping a continuous stream of pre-come. Keely took it, darting quickly as if to steal it from Maggie, giggling a little in her throat as she bobbed on the end of Cole's

cock and drinking what he produced. But then she was off it, smiling and aiming it toward her.

Now Cole was too close. She climbed his body instead, straddled his hips, Keely moving aside, Max climbing behind her and putting an arm around her.

Cole put a hand down to aim his shaft upright. He was aching hard, and she was wet, her petals looking to be unfurled. His cock slipped inside her without too much protest. They'd abstained for three months but had been fucking more than five times a day since they got to Tahiti. She took him easily, settling all the way down until she felt his tightened scrotum touch the seam of her ass. It didn't take much—fucking Keely twice, doing it while the three of them watched (which he loved), making Keely come, and then two girls sucking his cock at the same time brought her husband to the point of no return.

She sensed it, felt the tremor, felt the flexing of his cock as she bounced quickly, tightened her stomach muscles hard as she could, gripped him, felt his glans swell even harder, his foreskin peeled down, his coronal rim like a hard rubber line inside her membranes ... and then he was coming, grunting and grabbing fistfuls of sheets, bucking her and lifting her right off the bed, shooting his hot nectar so deep inside her, splashing her cervix.

He roared and grunted, rising and falling while she rode him. She stayed like that watching him breathe, watching him gasp with his muscular forearm draped over his eyes. Max and Keely's faces were drawn, hollow but excited, mouths agape, eyes wide and tense. She lifted herself from her husband, ran a hand between her legs to hold what he put inside her and she fell back on the bed with her knees up, waiting.

THE VILLA'S bed was a low king-size without a footboard, and Maggie lay now with her head in the pillows below the jute headboard, her legs drawn up in invitation. Cole lay next to him, on the other side of Keely, his feet toward the pillows, deflating cock hanging down onto the bedding, elbow planted in the mattress, head resting in a palm while he watched her too. Beyond him, the sky had gone a deep indigo, a faint tracing line of orange on the horizon. The black floating shapes of nearby villas standing out of

the lagoon on their concrete legs looked like UFOs with their floodlights shining down on the water below.

Maggie smiled at him from between her thighs, waiting, offering to him her cream pie, a thing she had grown very much to enjoy, and he made his way between her legs, pausing to kiss the sole of her foot while Keely caught up with him. Together, he and the woman he would marry kissed down the smooth insides of his ex-fiancée's thighs, dragging it out because they both loved to make her tremble. Max arrived first because he just missed her so much; this was a fun sexy game for Keely but it was far more profound for him. Cole's semen seeped from her slit. The petals of her slippery flower were furred and shining, and now her fingers slipped down to part them, spread them, Maggie peering down her own body, loving what she saw.

When his mouth went over her sopping sex she hissed, murmured, "Oh God, mm, Oh my God," and she let her head sink back into the pillows as the first waves of dirty pleasure washed over her. Keely's cheek pressed his own and he let her have room, running his tongue to the side as she suckled Maggie's labia, taking them into her mouth and pulling gently, then running her tongue from bottom to top as another pearly surge cascaded from her opening. Keely sucked it in her mouth. When she turned to Max, she kissed him, put her tongue in his mouth as Maggie almost cried from ecstasy, watching them and running a finger over her clit. Max pushed back what Keely had put in his mouth and she took it, swallowed, kissed his chin, returned to Maggie and stroked her with her tongue again, pulling Cole's semen from inside her with gentle sweet suction and swallowing it.

Now Maggie had clutched a handful of her own hair, making Max smile. He watched her as her feet shook, her mouth peeled back to reveal her clenched teeth, her lips wriggling like she was struck with grief instead of lust. Her skin shone wet and rosy, and now Cole had come around to put his head at the pillows, watching her. Maggie turned to face him, and they closed their eyes and took one another's open mouth in a passionate kiss. One hand clutched her own breast, Max's engagement ring on a chain settled on her sternum, Cole's wedding band reflecting at him brightly. Her other hand clutched Cole's half-hard member and tugged at it.

Now he rejoined his Keely, pushing his face next to hers, both their tongues licking, both their mouths taking turns at suckling on Maggie's hot flesh. Max probed her deep while Keely kissed and bit Maggie's thighs and

it happened for her. She cried out into Cole's kiss and bucked her hips into Max's mouth, Keely laughing next to him, happy knowing she'd orgasmed, and biting down to playfully clench a mouthful of Maggie's sensitive inner thigh.

"Ah, mm, oh, I'm coming, I'm coming," Maggie chanted above him, breathing heavy, Cole chuckling. Her nails raked through Max's hair, letting him know he was good for her.

Max stayed where he was, suckling and holding her pussy in his mouth until she'd stopped writhing. He rose then, happy and loving, watching her lay with her husband, kissing again.

While she covered her face in her hands, her eyes on either side of her fingers watching them, regaining life, she laughed. Through her cupped hands she said, "That's so dirty but I just love it."

On his knees side-by-side with Keely, she turned her attention to him, her hands rotating his shoulders so he faced her, kissing him again, putting her mouth over his, the taste and smell of Cole's semen on her lips. When her hand finally found his cock it short-circuited him and he fell against her, gasped in her mouth. She giggled. It was Maggie's hand, her on her knees and joining them, taking Keely's kiss away while she ran her hand up and down his aching erection.

He kissed Keely's neck, then they were on him, kissing his chest, making his breaths come huge and hard as they worked their mouths lower.

It hit him so hard. He felt so loved and happy but hurting all the same—it was nothing new, that was how Maggie made him feel for a long time; sometimes when she would text him and he would see her name on his screen, his stomach would seize with a dread even though she only sent him good messages. She was permanently connected in his mind to sexual suffering; his greatest loss that he never really truly lost. He had her fully at one time though, of that he was sure. Her kisses on his chest came with a breaking of his heart even now, but he longed for it, loved it, desired it.

He arched his back, leaned away so he could watch, pressed out his own cock as far as it would go for them, give them everything he had. He'd watched them both suck Cole, saw their hands on him for a sense of scale, saw how he was smaller. It was more difficult for them to suck it at the same time, their faces pressed cheek to cheek, but they had fun. Maggie pointing it to Keely, Keely taking him all the way then letting Maggie try. When they both looked up at him, running the points of their glistening

pink tongues all over his cock head, trying not to laugh seeing the effect they had on him he almost lost it all over their faces. But Maggie liked to prolong these things, and now she was whispering in Keely's ear, tucking her sweet face under her long ginger mane.

Keely looked to Max blankly, then nodded to Maggie. "Okay," she said. There was some concern on her face but she came up to him, looking in his eyes and kissing him. "She wants to be alone with you."

Now his stomach tightened hard again, excitement zipping through him too, all of it happening at once. Keely told Cole Maggie wanted to be alone, and he scooted up to sit, came behind Maggie and kissed her shoulder. She tried to kiss his lips, but he turned up his nose and laughed. Keely and Cole got off the bed together, Keely bringing the top sheet with her and wrapping herself in it like a shroud. Cole slapped her bottom, then made eye contact with Max and gave him a nod.

They left then, going out to the living area and closing the door behind them. Maggie pulled him down to lay in the bed with her, kissing at his stomach. He lay with his head in the pillows, looking up at the tall peaked roof lined with cedar shingles, the sheet of canvas that crossed between two rafters right over the bed. Maggie's mouth went over his cock and he jumped at the sudden pleasure. The TV switched on in the other room and he heard Keely laughing, the sound of a wine bottle singing against the rim of a glass.

Maggie worked her magic. Bobbing, swirling, sucking. Running her tongue all over the shapes of him like she was just discovering it, though she'd been familiar with it a long time. This could have been his life. This could be his honeymoon with her. They could have shared their future forever. But ultimately: he *would*. He was part of her future. And she was happy, and she included him. Maybe he never would have been enough for her. Not that she wanted many men; he was almost a hundred percent sure she had only ever slept with Lee, Cole, Jay, and himself. She just happened to find the one who did it for her. Max wouldn't have been that guy; not like Cole was.

Maybe this was the best place for him. Her best friend. Sometimes lover. He'd take it.

The orgasm she brought from him dragged for fifteen excruciatingly delightful minutes, like tickling nails through his insides until he thought he

would scream for release. When she was his Maggie, she would have gone for an hour and loved it. Cole was the one who got the hour now.

He coughed and cried, bucked on the bed, knees darting up as she ripped it out of him. He spewed it all in her mouth, reaching down and holding her head, wanting to cry out with joy and happiness and simultaneously clutch her head to his chest and lament her loss with braying sobs. When it was done, he collapsed back in the sheets, his heart rattling and out of control, his head throbbing.

Next he saw her, she was sitting up, wiping at her lower lip, her long russet hair tumbling down her beautiful body, lit from behind with the glow from the opposite villas' lights.

He put out a hand, wanting her to join him. "Lay with me," he said.

She looked at him a while, her face hidden from him in the dark of her hair. She said, "I can't, Max. Come on," and now she backed off the bed. "Let's go out. We'll have some more wine ..."

"I'll be out in a minute," he said, still laying spread-eagle on her bed with his dripping wet cock laying back on his belly.

"Take your time," she said, pausing to put on a white terry robe that lay draped over the arm of a cushioned chair in the corner. Before she left, she paused at the door. "I love you, you know."

The words merely gripped on his already hurting heart. He said, "I know you do." He didn't need to say it back.

"Come out when you're ready," she said, then slipped out of the room and closed the door behind her. More laughter outside, Keely again, saying something with food in her mouth and everyone laughing.

He breathed a while. Listened to his friends, listened to the waves of the lagoon, a distant party at the resort. Life was good, and he had nothing to complain about.

"Get the fuck up, Max," he said to himself.

FOREARMS RESTING on the wound metal cable strung below the railing that lined the villas decking, and seated on the wood planks with feet dangling over the water eight feet below, Max watched across the smooth and peaceful lagoon to the jagged peaks of Mt. Otemanu. A dormant

volcano, but not an extinct one; the hot lava still flowed in its veins, just waiting for enough pressure to reward it with joyous, destructive propulsion.

Right now, out in the happy turquoise water, people swam, two couples passed each other crossways in kayaks, waving to one another in polite morning greeting; all at the foot of something huge and frightening, willing to play and live in the trust of its current calm.

Behind him now, from inside the villa, bright laughter, tinged with Irish; Keely amusing Cole uproariously. Kitchen sounds as well; a coffee maker, the pop of a top being unscrewed from a glass bottle of juice. Now Maggie laughed over something Cole said, his voice a low mumble out where Max sat on the balcony deck.

Last night out here they'd sat and had a few glasses of wine, migrated to the hot tub and had a few more. Cole decided to go swimming and Max joined him, the two of them climbing down the ladder, despite Keely's squeals and hopping in place, clutching at him and begging him not to go down there with the sharks. Maggie was calm, laughing and sipping her wine. They paddled in the pool of light under the villa with the girls watching above, Keely whining and laughing nervously. No sharks sighted, he and Cole waded for a while and Cole told him he was more afraid of being a father than sharks. Max told him he would be a good one, a really good dad, and he thought he would. When they climbed back up they shared a shower under the nozzle by the hot tub and they went to bed—each in their own bedrooms with their respective partners. Max went down on Keely and then they made love. He left her mouth uncovered and let her enjoy her ecstasy.

Footsteps now, bare feet coming from behind on the hot deck. Then a call of alarm: "Whoa, Max, whoa, look out!"

Turned to see Keely stumbling his way, a small glass of orange juice in one hand, the other hand's fingers hooked through the handle of a steaming coffee mug printed with the St. Regis logo. Her face showed worried horror, her hand tilted like the mug's boiling contents would splash all over him as she tripped. He didn't even flinch, merely shook his head at her. With a giggle, she came to sit next to him, posing like him with her bare legs dangling over the ledge. She passed him his cup of coffee and he thanked her.

After a sip of orange juice, she said, “They want to do a big brunch here at the resort. Go out and snorkel on the ocean side, look at the coral reef.” Keely watched across the lagoon like he did, the sun dappling the moving leaves of the forest that climbed the base of the volcano as high as it could go; the island gleaming in a humid haze. The sun shone from behind them, lighting up the blonde streaks in her ginger hair she tied back from her soft and pretty face. Under her white terry resort robe he knew she would be naked.

“You’re okay with that?” he asked her.

“Snorkeling?...”

He nodded.

“I can stay in the boat,” she said softly, giving him a cute grimace and a little shrug.

He sipped his coffee, reached down and found her hand. “We’ll let them go on their own. After brunch we can just chill out. The two of us. We just got here.”

“We did,” she said, giving his hand a little squeeze.

“What do you want to do?” he asked her.

“The truth—Max ...?” she laughed. “I just want to stay here. Is that lazy? You and me lay out here in the sun ...” She nodded her head behind her to the lounge chairs on the other side of the hot tub. “I’m exhausted. Jet lagged.”

“Sounds perfect,” he said, raising her hand so he could kiss it, his nose bumping the diamond on her engagement ring.

“I’m so glad you agreed to marry me” he told her.

“Aye,” she said, “you’re lucky to have me.”

“I am,” he agreed, looking into her eyes, the sun reflected off the waves below and shone gold slivers in her emeralds.

With a gentle tug on her hand, he drew her in for a kiss.

Proposing to Keely had maybe been a lot about performing for his mother—he didn’t want her to die thinking he had lost Maggie, but that he’d moved on toward his future. For his mother’s sake; so she wouldn’t worry. But he hadn’t *really* committed. Which was crazy because Keely had a heart of gold. And she had no curiosities. She’d already spent her youth ‘getting some.’ She was a recognized pervert in her own right. She’d fucked twice as many guys as he had girls. She’d fucked Cole her first year at Farmingham. Cole sat in the Oren Glen and shown Max pictures Keely had

sent him of her pussy, the whole time Max looking and liking, never suspecting he was looking at the pussy of the woman he would some day marry. No, his Keely had sown her oats and her love for him was genuine. She knew what she was getting with Max and she was fucking into it.

“There’s nothing you’re missing with me, is there?”

Keely had been with him long enough to know what that meant for Max and didn’t need any clarification. “Other men, Max?” she said with dubiety, the whole idea ridiculous. “You know how many dicks there are out there?”

He frowned, and she laughed loud, throwing back her head and rolling her eyes.

“Assholes,” she giggled. “The word is assholes—that’s what I meant. Most of them are assholes, Max. I’m the one that’s lucky. I’m lucky to have you.” She looked sweetly into his eyes as she said it, and he knew it to be true already he just liked to hear it.

She slept with Cole only at Max’s request. She had her fill of Cole when she was at Farmingham. A three-day affair that she admitted to him saw her infatuated with young Cole and his male model looks. She got over it. She was eighteen at the time. These days she fucked Cole for fun and for Max’s benefit because he like to watch her. He’d watch her a few more times this week. What he’d had with Maggie was immature. Maggie’s sexual experience and his newfound burgeoning desire—those had been infantile, underdeveloped things. All three of them—all four of them—had grown now, and with that maturity came their respective responsibility and their acceptance of all their own truths. Even the kinkier ones.

“Hey,” he said, though he already had her complete attention.

“Yes?” she said now, swaying side-to-side, bumping his shoulder and taking a sip of her juice.

“You serious you wanted to be pregnant?”

It stopped her swaying, and she set the glass next to her on the deck. She covered her hand over the one he already held her with. Her eyes were serious, but full of wonderful emotion.

“Fuck, yes,” she said quietly.

“We should make some plans,” he said.

Though she did her best to contain herself, he felt her shaking with excitement. “I wanna ... I wanna pop six months after I graduate.”

It made him smile, his Keely already planning it out, way ahead of him. “I think it’s time we made some serious moves,” he said, and he leaned to

her, setting his cup down so he could hold her in his arms. In the moment before their mouths came together he saw something deep and enduring in her quivering eyes. Something honest. They kissed each other, held each other tightly.

The sun fell on them warm and bright, a breeze crossing the lagoon tugged at their hair, water rushed and splashed against the piling somewhere below their dangling feet and inside the house Maggie turned on the stereo. Cello and bass though he didn't know the tune; the fridge door closed, bottles clanked, a toaster popped; Maggie laughed lightly, alone in there with her husband.

THE END

Afterword

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Maggie is a fourth year Art student and she can't wait for the summer to come so she can finally tie the knot with the guy she fell in love with when they were Freshmen.

They've been together four years at their prestigious private college nestled in the Green Mountains of Vermont. This is the year they'll graduate and set out into the world together as a couple.

But Maggie is surprised to find her desires set on fire by a gorgeous new figure model. She thinks she'd never cheat but she can't stop thinking about him.

When Max learns her secret he's crushed. It tears down everything he knows about her. But in the rubble he finds something shining: excitement.

Now, if he could just convince her it's okay...

Learning Lessons

A Losing His Wife Novel

This long series is now one novel! A 160,000 word cuckold tragedy ...

Pete and Jess Mapplethorpe have been married for seven years now. They've got two wonderful little boys and an Irish Setter. Everyone that knows them would say they are the nicest couple you'd want to meet.

Well, they might say that Pete can be a bit of a jerk sometimes—but Jess? Regional Grade Three teacher of the year, three years running. Pretty, polite, sensitive, kind and thoughtful...

It must have been black magic that brought them together...

Behind closed doors everyone would be shocked at what goes on. They'd never believe the dirty things that sweet Jess might do or say. Pete doesn't think he has what it takes to please his beautiful wife and they fantasize about larger men taking her and making her happy.

She's just starting to discover herself at thirty-five... She wants to make up for lost time. They've found a handsome, well-built young man to play along. It's better than they even imagined. Now that they've started will she be able to stop? What if she doesn't want to?

Her husband loves enduring distressing levels of humiliation and she's finding a crazy pleasure now in delivering it...

Cherry Blossoms

A Losing His Wife Novel

This long series is now one novel! A 300,000 word cuckold tragedy ...

Geoff J. Kane is a successful children's book illustrator. Ten years ago he married the girl of his dreams. She'd been his best friend and he'd helped her through tough relationships and gave her his shoulder to cry on many nights. Then after two years, she kissed him. Now they're married and they've got a beautiful seven-year-old daughter.

Nia Kane was a wild one. She liked to have fun and she liked to cause trouble. Everything she did, in the end, blew up in her face, hurt her. One night she realized the best man in her life was sitting with her, telling her it was all going to be okay. She kissed him and it was wonderful and he's always good to her.

Their daughter is growing up, she's away at school now and it seems like it might be a good idea for Nia to return to the workforce. The city isn't getting any cheaper. She gets a job offer from an old friend. The brother of her very hot ex-boyfriend. She cried on her husband's shoulder a lot over this guy, back when Geoff was just her buddy.

Having her ex back in her life stirs up old feelings in both of them. They both like it. There was something exciting about that time when they were twenty. It's safe now. He's got her. They can fantasize, right?

Watching Natalie Cheat

Nelson and Natalie Stacks are settling in for the night to spend some together-time. It's been a long week of work and they've got one night together before they have to spend some time apart.

One night alone, that's all Nelson wanted. But it seems fate has other plans ...

Soon, there's a knock on the door ... behind it a ghost from the past ...

They let him in—it's freezing outside. And even though Natalie has never been a fan of Nelson's old college housemate, she's ready to let the bad of the past remain there ...

Besides, it seems like he's brought quite the gift ...

Obsessed Series

Obsessed: Book One

Obsessed: Book Two

Four couples lives intertwine as they explore their erotic boundaries. From simple wife-watching to cuckolding and domination and humiliation, these couples have one thing in common: they all share the same incredible bull. And he is far more than they even expected.

Mike and Gretch: Not married, but dating for a good long while. Two comedy writers just at the edge of love, that strange and delicate space where the act of sharing can be so dangerous. But they're two cool cats and they're sure they've got it all locked down. They call her ex-boyfriend from college, Atticus Hawke, a guy who has in the years since their breakup, and before Mike, been a reliable booty call for her.

Sean and Courtney: Sean's a Type A stick of dynamite. A rocketing studio exec, competitive and driven, he shares an incredible bond with his gym-toned wife. Courtney is all in for the new game she and her handsome husband have devised. Their ten-year-old daughter is out of the house and away at boarding school. They've planned a one-year commitment to one another about honesty, openness, and exploration. They're going for broke. Their new thing? Sean likes to watch and Court likes to be watched. They've found a guy online. He seems too good to be true. A guy called Finch, endowed, muscular, handsome like a fashion model. Courtney's been working out and she's going to put this stud through his paces.

Steve and Becky: Becky's a headstrong X-Ray technician who landed herself a multi-millionaire tech investor husband thirty years her senior. Steve loves to be dominated and he found the girl of his dreams in Becky. She's got an iron will and she loves her husband. Loves him enough to lock him in chastity and keep him abstinent for months on end. It's okay, don't worry about Becky, she gets a regular visit from a drop-dead gorgeous man named Finch. He keeps her satisfied. Sometimes, if he's been good, she'll even let her husband watch.

JJ and Amy: Two young country bumpkins just arrived in Los Angeles. JJ wants to live a lifestyle he's only dreamed of and this city is part of it. He's married to the sweetest little nineteen-year-old outta Jackson Pond, South Carolina and he's sure she's on a fast ticket to stardom. She just needs her first big break. While they're waiting he's got a fantasy he wants to see lived out. He would do anything to see his little Amy with a man who's got a big one, one'll make her scream like those girls he watches on the internet. He found a guy online, one Amy didn't make her vomit-face at. He's got everything JJ's been looking for and, thank the stars, he's agreed to do it.

Atticus Hawke: Finch is his online name. His nighttime name. The one he uses on a site that puts him in touch with couples looking for a bull just like him. By day he is Atticus Hawke. You might have heard of him. You know the song from the eighties, 'Going With That Girl'? No? You'd know it if you heard it. That was Atticus' dad, Ricky Hawke. Yes, that Ricky Hawke. Now you know. Made a bunch of singer-songwriter hits in a time when all the kids wanted pop coming out of synthesizers and their stars to be pretty boys and have colourful hair. Ricky had real talent. So does Atticus. One of L.A.'s hottest emerging Modern artists, his work commands a fortune. But it pales against his enormous trust fund. These days his real work is done at night. His masterpieces. That's where his passion is. Watching and participating in intense psychological dramas in dark hotel rooms across the city. He gives women what they want. They're a canvas, a medium. His audience: their husband.

The Cayman Proxy Series:

The Cayman Proxy (Box One)

Mitchell Sutton's family is one of the wealthiest in London. But Mitch is an outsider, the handsome young son who took his own path. He's in love with a girl from the wrong side of the tracks.

Kate's a troubled Council house girl thrown into a lifestyle she never imagined. But she's more than his dressed up little princess.

He's got just about everything she needs. But she's got a mind full of dark thoughts she can't escape. And there's something Mitch can't give her.

She needs something his money can't buy.

He would do anything for her.

They hit the hot beaches of Grand Cayman, a reunion with an old friend and a handsome stranger. Passion boils in her blood. Can she make this work or will her desires destroy the man she loves?

Pool Party

A cuckold thriller.

Darren's wife is far away this weekend at a conference in New York City. At least that's what she told him. Who knows these days?

He's got a sneaking suspicion Lynn's been cheating on him. Nothing concrete; little things. Like the gym dedication, the slim-fitting new clothes ... there's an attitude as well. And she's been denying him his marital pleasures.

A distance has been growing between them though they've been happily married for twenty-five years.

Today's the hottest day of the summer. A hundred-and-five degrees, and at Darren's house it's about to get even hotter ...

A fortuitous knock on the door brings Darren surprises and clues to the mysteries that have been keeping him awake ...

He worried his imagination had been getting away from him ...
Sometimes the worst thing you can imagine isn't even close.

Going A Little Too Far

You couldn't picture a sweeter couple than Troy and Emma.

Troy's a former Division One college wrestler. A walking water park at two-sixty-five, with shoulders no woman could get her arms around and a set of abs you could scrub laundry on.

Emma's a sweet little Georgia Peach. Pretty as can be in her proper dresses; she's a good girl from a good family that raised her right.

You couldn't tell by looking at them that they were two straight-up freaks that loved to push each other's kinky buttons.

Emma, with all her book club shyness, loves to be man-handled, loves to be lifted off her feet and dominated. Troy is a monster with a six-hundred-fifty pound deadlift and she's like a feather in his arms.

Troy likes to be humiliated. He knows he doesn't have much 'down there' and he likes his virginal wife to tell him he's no good and she'd have to get what she wanted elsewhere.

Couple of closet freaks.

A summer housewarming party on a scorching hot West Texas day puts a gift in their lap. A big, larger-than-life playtoy for Emma to tease her husband with. He wants her to. She wants to do it. But once it starts, where do you stop? What's going too far?

Taken While He Watches: On Their Honeymoon

Ken and Ashley just got married and while money is super-tight they've got themselves a weekend getaway in the Honeymoon Suite looking out over the ocean on the sunny Carolina coast.

The room was a steal. Turns out it's Bike Week and no one books the Honeymoon Suite during Bike Week. Especially not two dopey white kids from the suburbs.

A mix-up leaves them in trouble and they don't know how they can get out of it, don't even know how they'll get home. They get some help from their hotel neighbours. A half dozen handsome, muscular, and very wealthy black men.

Ken's wary but Ash is all in.

When they find out she's saved herself for her special night she becomes the star of the show and they'll offer anything to help her...

Ken doesn't like it but she's going to do what they ask. She says it's for their future...

Taken While He Watches: At The Combine

Coralee has put her own career on hold to help her husband keep his Sports Podcast afloat. He's spent eighty grand on his tiny entertainment empire.

Bobby just needs a big break. His business is a half second away from going belly-up. When their camera captures an XXL wardrobe malfunction by the combine's star prospect they see an opportunity.

Coralee will do anything to get an interview with him. She'll use the video as leverage. She'll get to this bad boy super-athlete, even if she has to break into the locker room...

She's doing it to save the family business, right?

Taken By His Best Friends: At The Hockey Rink

Marguerite was a sexy little French student Randall fell in love with at college. She loved hockey. He played hockey.

They fell in love and they married. They live a regular 9 to 5 now, but Randall and his best friends still play once a week. They are four big guys and they play rough and Marguerite is always there to cheer them from the stands.

When they all end up alone in the locker room after a bench-clearing brawl passions are already high. And when some innocent flirting starts it quickly tumbles out of control.

Marguerite does nothing to stop it. Randall is frozen...

He's going to watch his best friends do all the dirty things they've ever dreamed of doing to his wife...

Measured Next To Her Ex: A Medical Size Comparison Cuckold Fantasy

When Ben Watson went to the new Sexual Performance Clinic across from his office he was just looking to get some help.

But when he showed up on Opening Day the place was so overwhelmed they started doubling up in exam rooms to make sure all the patients were assessed.

Of all the gin joints in all the—

Guess who his exam partner is? Yeah, his honey-pie's ex-boyfriend. He is going to be sitting next to him, knees practically touching, while these nurses assess their size and performance using only their latex hands.

He could leave, get the hell out of there. That would be sensible. But he's kind of curious. A dark part of him wants to know something. Wants to know what his precious girl's ex-lover has between his legs.

He's going to wish he left.

Then, when his obscenely endowed exam mate starts to relate to the nurses the casual but very dirty hook-ups he's been having with an ex, Ben's hands really start sweating.

This is going to be the worst day of Ben's life.

Size Curious Brat

Matt Walsh is on his way home from Harvard. It's Thanksgiving recess and he hasn't been with his sweet Chloe Rose in months. He can't wait to get off the bus and wrap his arms around his baby girl.

Chloe's a perverted little high-schooler with a habit for trouble. She loves her boyfriend Matt and she's been aching for him.

But there's a problem.

Matt's step brother came home early. He's a bully. A domineering man's man who made Matt's life miserable growing up. Now he's a sexy deep-sea welder just getting home from Louisiana after two months at sea and he hasn't even seen a woman in ages.

After a brief, naked encounter in the hallway little Chloe can't get something out of her mind. Matt's stepbrother Moric is built much better than other men and she can't stop thinking about it.

It makes Matt mad but Chloe is just naturally curious. She doesn't think it's a big deal. She's just never seen anything like that before.

Now Moric's got his eyes on his little brother's prize possession. She's not exactly unwilling. Moric is a big powerful stud and Matt is powerless to stop him. Once he starts neither of them could stop him. He could take whatever he wants. It might be better—if Moric would let him—to just join him...